

B4 — Chemistry in the Atmosphere

Part II · Michaelmas & Lent Term Lecture Notes

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Table of contents

Preface	4
Michaelmas Term	5
Basic Physical and Chemical Structure of the Troposphere and Stratosphere	6
Module 1 · Basic Physical and Chemical Structure of the Troposphere and Stratosphere	7
1.0 Atmospheric layers — temperature, pressure and density	7
1.1 The hydrostatic equation	9
1.2 The Troposphere — basic role and composition	12
1.4 The Stratosphere — basic structure and composition	13
Try it yourself	15
Chemical Kinetics in the Atmosphere	16
Module 2 · Chemical Kinetics in the Atmosphere	17
2.1 Time scales and lifetimes	17
Pseudo first-order kinetics	18
A chain reaction: $A \rightarrow B \rightarrow C$	19
Chemistry vs. transport timescales	22
2.2 Bi-molecular rate coefficients	23
2.3 Ter-molecular rate coefficients	24
Try it yourself	26
Atmospheric Photochemistry	27
Module 3 · Atmospheric Photochemistry	28
3.1 Calculation of photolysis rate coefficients	29
3.2 Altitude dependence of photolysis	29
3.3 Photolysis of O_2	31
3.4 O_3 photolysis	32
3.5 Photolysis of NO_2	34
3.6 Photolysis of N_2O and other compounds	36
Try it yourself	39
Stratospheric Ozone Chemistry: the Chapman Mechanism and Catalytic Cycles	40
Module 4 · Stratospheric Ozone Chemistry	41
4.1 The Chapman Reactions	41
4.2 Catalytic cycles	45
4.3 The oxides of nitrogen, NO_x	46

4.3.1 Sources	46
4.3.2 Catalytic cycle	46
4.3.3 Reservoirs and sinks	47
4.3.4 Diurnal variation of the nitrogen oxides	48
4.4 The oxides of hydrogen, HOx	49
4.4.1 Sources	49
4.4.2 Catalytic cycles	49
4.4.3 Reservoirs and sinks	50
4.5 The oxides of chlorine, ClOx	50
4.5.1 Sources	50
4.5.2 Catalytic cycle	50
4.5.3 Reservoirs and sinks	51
4.6 Other halogens	51
4.6.1 Sources	51
4.6.2 Catalytic cycle	51
4.6.3 Reservoirs and sinks	51
4.7 Relative importance of the Ox, NOx, HOx, ClOx and BrOx cycles	52
Try it yourself	52
Model Predictions of Changes in Global O ₃	53
Module 5 · Model Predictions of Changes in Global O ₃	54
Try it yourself	57
Lent Term	58
Atmospheric Composition: Sources, Sinks and Lifetimes	59
Module 6 · Atmospheric Composition: Sources, Sinks and Lifetimes	60
1.1 Introduction	60
1.2 Atmospheric Composition	61
Troposphere vs. stratosphere	62
1.3 Sources of the Minor Constituents	63
1.4 Sinks of the Minor Constituents	63
1.4.1 Dry deposition	63
1.4.2 Wet deposition	64
1.4.3 Acid deposition (wet and dry)	65
1.5 Lifetimes — putting it together	65
Worked Example 1 — Steady-state concentration of compound X	66
Try it yourself	66
Tropospheric Photochemistry and the Hydroxyl Radical	67
Module 7 · Tropospheric Photochemistry and the Hydroxyl Radical	68
2.1 Introduction	68
2.2 Tropospheric Photolysis	68
2.3 Photolysis of ozone in the troposphere	69
2.3.1 Fate of O(¹ D) in a dry atmosphere	70
2.4 Generation of OH radicals	71
2.4.1 Other sources of OH in the troposphere	71
2.5 The HOx family	72
2.5.1 Steady-state concentration of OH and HO ₂	72
2.6 Trace gas oxidation	73
2.7 Observations of HOx radicals	74

Try it yourself	75
Methane Oxidation and NO _x -Driven Ozone Production	76
Module 8 · Methane Oxidation and NO _x -Driven Ozone Production	77
3.1 Methane oxidation in the troposphere	77
3.2 Nitrogen oxides and production of tropospheric ozone	78
3.2.1 Photostationary state in the absence of peroxy radicals	79
3.2.2 Reaction of peroxy radicals with NO leads to O ₃ production	79
3.3 Rate of production of ozone in the presence of alkanes and NO _x	80
3.4 Formation of nitric acid and NO _x lifetime	81
3.5 Ozone production under low and high NO _x conditions	82
Try it yourself	86
The Tropospheric Ozone Budget, Carbonyl Formation and NO _x Reservoirs	87
Module 9 · The Tropospheric Ozone Budget, Carbonyl Formation and NO _x Reservoirs	88
3.6 The budget of tropospheric ozone	88
3.7 Formation of carbonyl compounds	90
3.8 NO _x reservoirs	90
3.8.1 Formation of the NO _x reservoir peroxyacetyl nitrate (PAN)	91
3.8.2 Formation of N ₂ O ₅ from NO ₃ — at night — can lead to NO _x removal	92
Try it yourself	93
Oxidation of Non-Methane Organic Compounds I: Alkanes and Alkenes	94
Module 10 · Oxidation of Non-Methane Organic Compounds I: Alkanes and Alkenes	95
4.0 Introduction	95
4.1 The role of NMVOCs in ozone production	95
4.2 Prediction of rate coefficients for initiation of NMVOC oxidation	96
4.3 Oxidation of alkanes	96
Fate of RO ₂	96
Auto-oxidation	97
Fate of RO	97
4.4 Oxidation of alkenes	98
Try it yourself	99
Oxidation of Non-Methane Organic Compounds II: Aromatics and Oxygenated Organics	100
Module 11 · Oxidation of Non-Methane Organic Compounds II: Aromatics and Oxygenated Organics	101
4.5 Oxidation of aromatics	101
4.6 Oxidation of oxygenated organics	101
Try it yourself	102

Preface

These are the lecture notes for B4 — Chemistry in the Atmosphere (Cambridge Chemistry Part II), covering the Michaelmas and Lent term modules:

Michaelmas term

1. Basic Physical and Chemical Structure of the Troposphere and Stratosphere
2. Chemical Kinetics in the Atmosphere
3. Atmospheric Photochemistry
4. Stratospheric Ozone Chemistry: the Chapman Mechanism and Catalytic Cycles
5. Model Predictions of Changes in Global O₃

Lent term

6. Atmospheric Composition: Sources, Sinks and Lifetimes
7. Tropospheric Photochemistry and the Hydroxyl Radical
8. Methane Oxidation and NO_x-Driven Ozone Production
9. The Tropospheric Ozone Budget, Carbonyl Formation and NO_x Reservoirs
10. Oxidation of Non-Methane Organic Compounds I: Alkanes and Alkenes
11. Oxidation of Non-Methane Organic Compounds II: Aromatics and Oxygenated Organics

Each module has a paired, pre-executed Jupyter notebook in `notebooks/`, cross-linked from the relevant lecture.

Michaelmas Term

Basic Physical and Chemical Structure of the Troposphere and Stratosphere

Module 1 · Basic Physical and Chemical Structure of the Troposphere and Stratosphere

Learning aims By the end of this module you should be able to: 1. Describe the temperature-based layering of the atmosphere and explain why the troposphere and stratosphere have such different mixing behaviour. 2. Derive and apply the hydrostatic equation and scale height to calculate pressure, density and number density at a given altitude. 3. Define and calculate the column amount (e.g. in Dobson Units) of an atmospheric constituent. 4. Outline the basic composition and role of the troposphere and stratosphere, including the importance of ozone in each.

1.0 Atmospheric layers — temperature, pressure and density

Most planetary atmospheres are heated by outgoing long wave radiation from the planetary surface, and so in general planetary atmospheres get cooler as one ascends through them. However, the atmosphere of our planet is different. Atmospheric temperature decreases with height initially, before undergoing a transition leading to increasing temperature with height. These changes in temperature gradient mean that the atmosphere can conveniently be divided into a number of layers (or spheres), depending on the temperature profile (Figure 1.1). The turning points in Figure 1.1 are known as “pauses” and are located at ~10–18 km (tropopause) and ~45–50 km (stratopause).

Figure 1.1 (recreated) — Atmospheric temperature profile
(1976 US Standard Atmosphere)

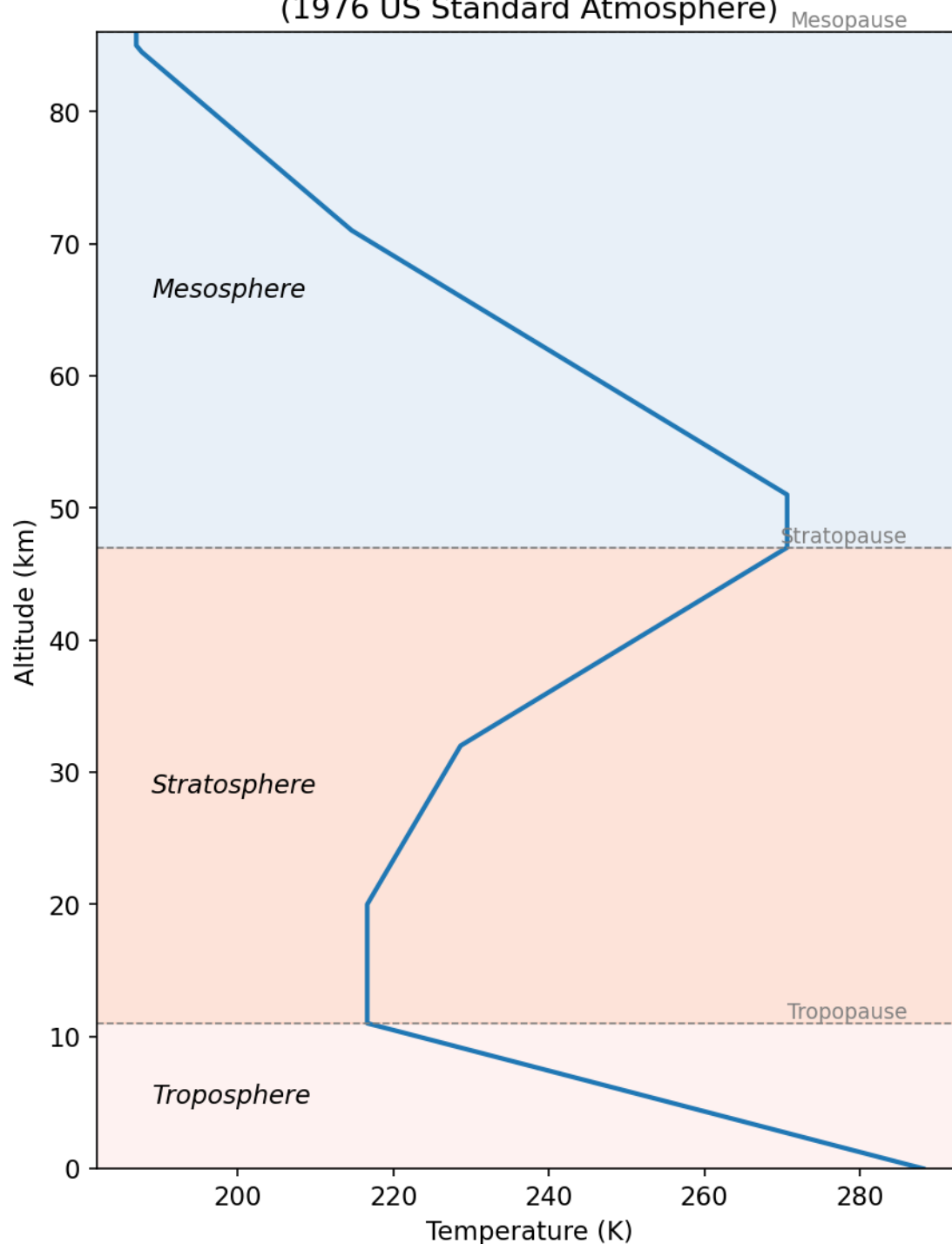


Figure 1.1 — Atmospheric temperature profile, generated from the 1976 US Standard Atmosphere reference data (see `data/us_standard_atmosphere_1976.csv` and `notebooks/01-atmospheric-structure.ipynb`).

In this course we will be primarily concerned with the lowermost layers, the stratosphere and troposphere, which make up approximately 99.9% of the atmospheric mass.

Figure 1.2 below shows that the zonal mean (latitude vs. altitude profile) atmospheric temperature profile

is not only strongly altitude dependent (as depicted in Fig 1.1), but in the lower atmosphere also depends strongly on latitude. Two key features stick out in Fig 1.2: (i) the coldest part of the atmosphere is in the tropical upper troposphere; (ii) the height of the tropopause is latitude dependent (dashed line).

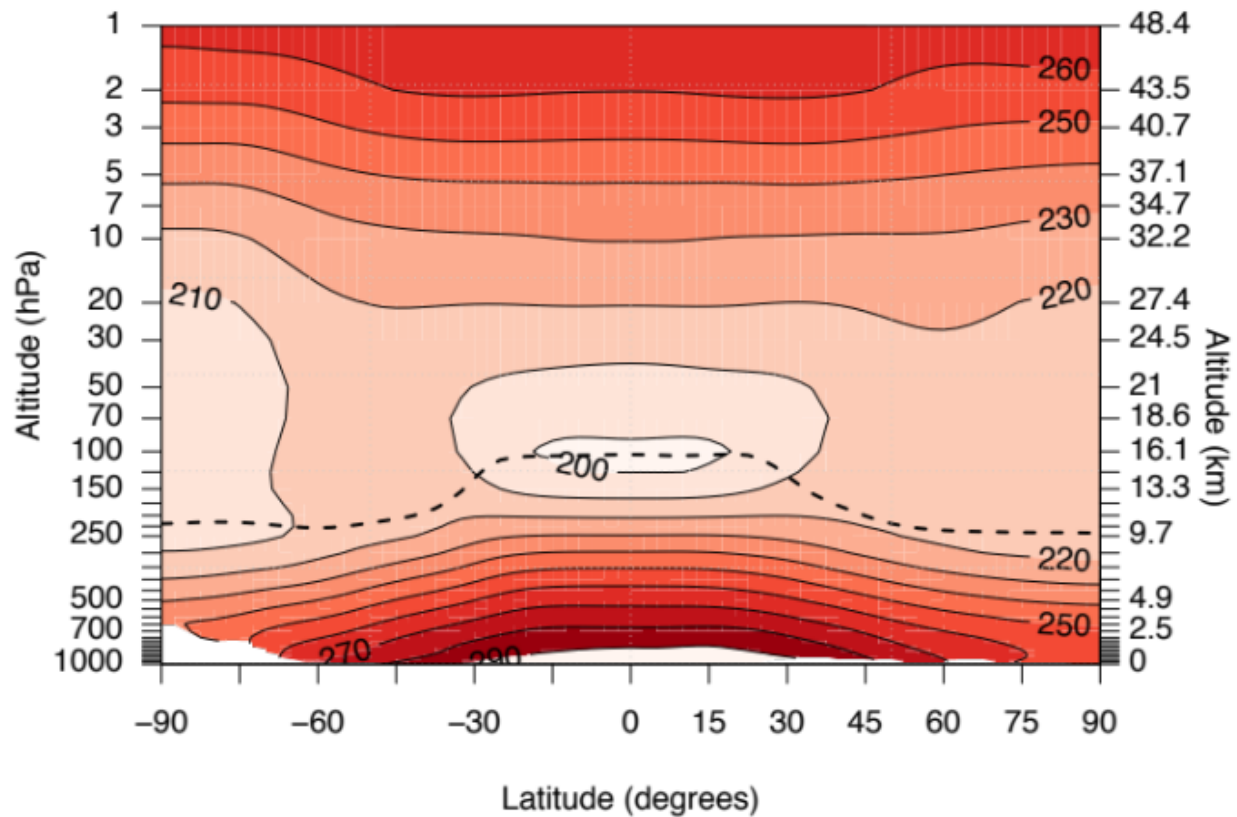


Figure 1.2 — Zonally averaged annual mean temperature.

In order to calculate how temperature varies with altitude a radiative transfer model is needed. These sorts of calculations are beyond the scope of this course. What is important to appreciate is the general structure of temperature in the atmosphere, noting the different temperature environments found in the different layers. Indeed, these different temperature environments allow air to be well vertically mixed in the troposphere but poorly so in the stratosphere. However, mixing in the stratosphere is very rapid zonally. The temperature inversions associated with the pauses give rise to the unique chemical environments found in the different layers of the atmosphere.

1.1 The hydrostatic equation

Figure 1.2 shows that as we go up in the atmosphere pressure decreases. The hydrostatic relation is used to relate ambient pressure to altitude. If ρ is the ambient air density at altitude z with pressure p , we can write, for an incremental change in z :

$$dp = -\rho g dz$$

(assumes g is constant — not a bad assumption)

For an ideal gas we can write:

$$\rho = \frac{Mp}{RT} = \frac{mp}{kT}$$

where M and m are the relative molar mass and molecular mass respectively. Thus,

$$dp = -\frac{Mpg}{RT}dz$$

Defining $H = \frac{RT}{Mg}$ as the scale height (approximately constant with altitude) we can re-write the above expression to give:

$$\frac{dp}{p} = -\frac{dz}{H}$$

and integrate, setting the surface pressure as $p = p_0$, to yield:

$$p = p_0 e^{-z/H}$$

This equation describes the fall-off of pressure with altitude.

The pressure drops by $1/e$ over the scale height, H . In the Earth's atmosphere the average $M \approx 28.9 \text{ g mol}^{-1}$, and so the scale height varies between 6 and 7.5 km, depending on atmospheric temperature.

Making use of the ideal gas equation, it is also possible to define an approximate relationship for number density ($n = n_0 e^{-z/H}$, where n often has units molecules cm^{-3}). In the rest of this course we will refer to number density as $[M]$.

So, with increasing altitude above the Earth's surface, the density (and pressure) of the air falls by about a factor of 10 for approximately each 16 km (10 miles) of altitude (Figure 1.3).

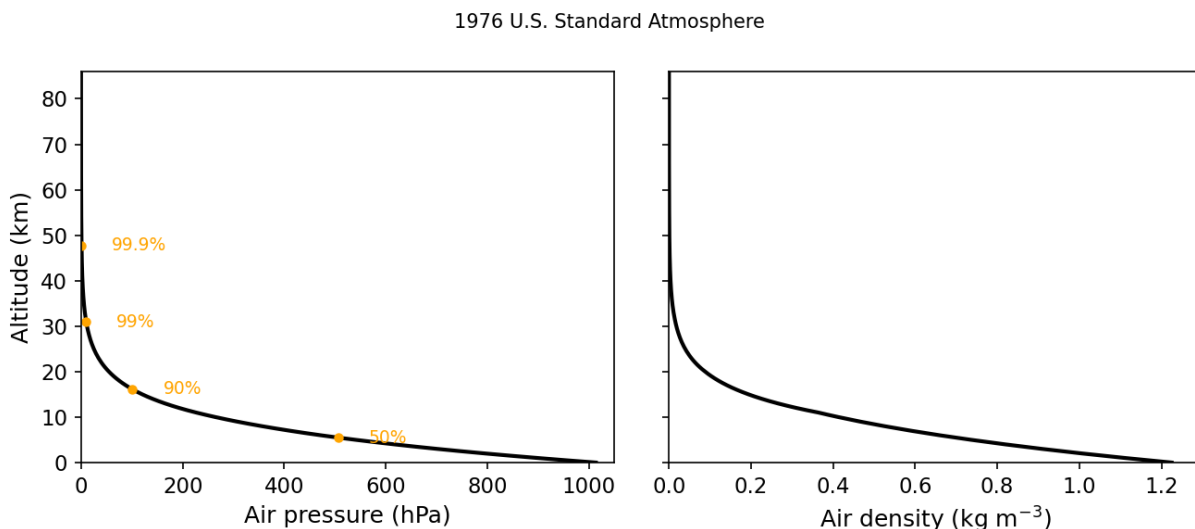


Figure 1.3 — Variation of pressure and density with altitude.

This has important consequences for the rate of some atmospheric reactions — especially termolecular reactions, but note that some bimolecular reactions are also pressure dependent. Up to an altitude of 80–90 km (the mesopause) the bulk composition is essentially $\text{N}_2 : \text{O}_2 = 4 : 1$.

Above this height atomic oxygen becomes the dominant oxygen species, the concentrations of ions and free electrons become significant and ion–molecule reactions are important.

At still higher altitudes, above 100 km, diffusive separation can occur, with light molecules such as hydrogen reaching higher altitudes (and even leaving the atmosphere altogether).

We should finally consider the timescales of mixing air across the atmosphere. The general circulation of the atmosphere is complex, but the key points to note are the different τ for mixing north–south, east–west and vertically.

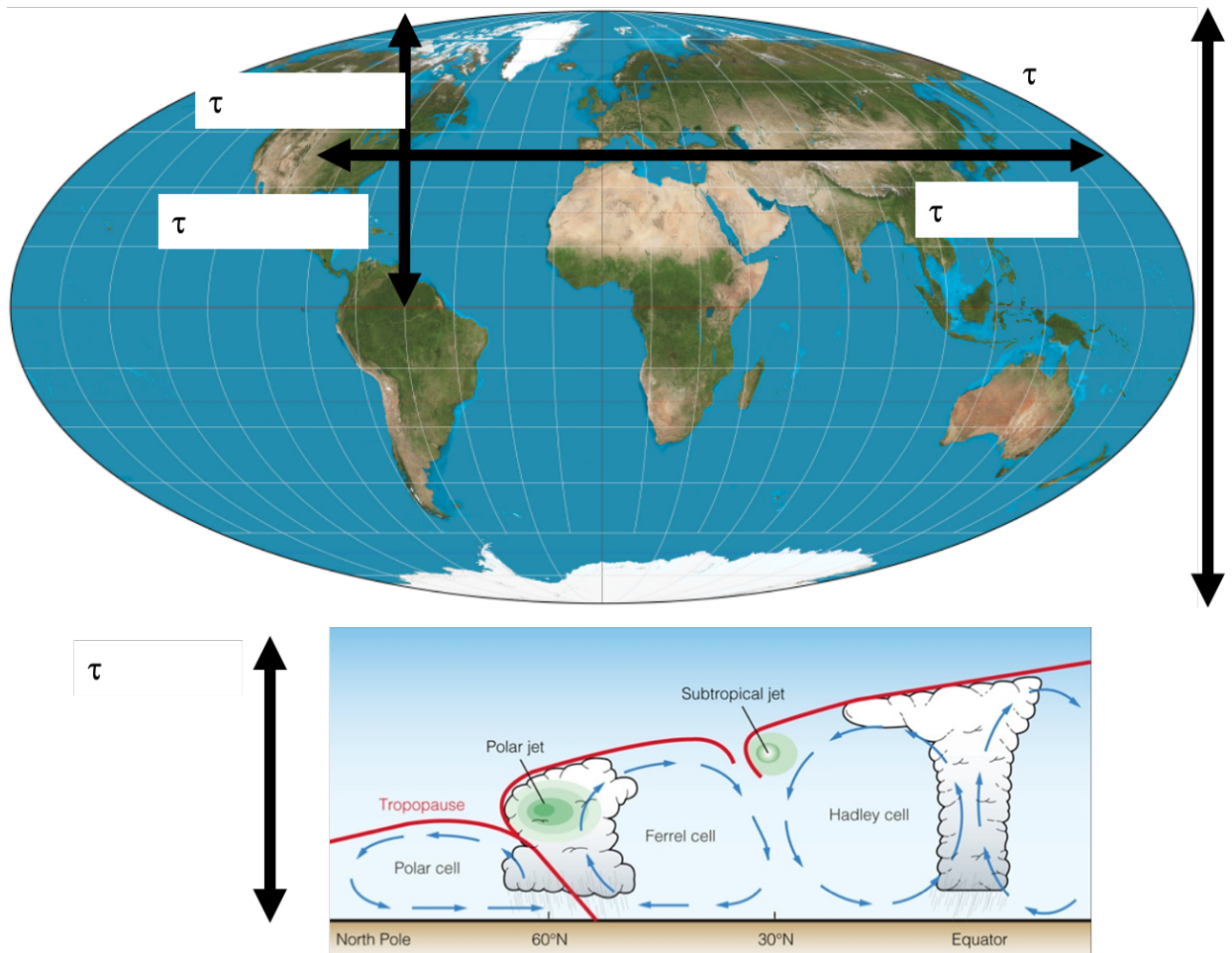


Figure 1.4 — Some typical mixing timescales (τ) in the horizontal and vertical across the atmosphere.

Exercise 1 — Calculation of the number density at different altitudes

The number density is another word for concentration, in molecules cm^{-3} .

We can make use of the ideal gas equation to calculate the concentration of a gas:

$$pV = nRT \Rightarrow \frac{n}{V} = \frac{p}{RT} \text{ (moles per volume)}$$

To get into molecules, use k_B rather than R (writing N for number of molecules):

$$\frac{N}{V} = \frac{p}{k_B T}$$

At 298 K and 1 bar pressure:

$$\frac{N}{V} = \frac{100,000}{1.38 \times 10^{-23} \times 298} = 2.43 \times 10^{25} \text{ molecules m}^{-3} = 2.43 \times 10^{19} \text{ molecules cm}^{-3}$$

1.2 The Troposphere — basic role and composition

As we've seen, the troposphere is that part of the atmosphere which lies between the surface of the Earth and about 10 to 15 km, depending on latitude (see Fig 1.2). While air in the troposphere is reasonably well mixed, it is inhibited from rapid exchange with the stratosphere because the tropopause is a relatively impermeable barrier to transport. The troposphere is also the region where most of what we regard as weather (clouds, precipitation, etc.) occurs. Radiative processes in the troposphere are the dominant processes affecting surface climate and climate change.

Chemically, the troposphere serves some very important functions. Chemical destruction (by OH (day) and NO₃ (night)) in the troposphere is the main mechanism preventing many gases emitted at the surface of the Earth from accumulating to amounts that are toxic to life or ultimately damaging to the stratospheric ozone layer or the climate system. This destruction (or usually the concentration of the oxidants) is an expression of the 'oxidizing capacity'. The troposphere provides a system of transport and chemical transformation for the natural biogeochemical cycles.

Table 1.1 shows the principal gaseous constituents of the troposphere, their mixing ratios and their atmospheric lifetimes. Disregarding the highly variable amounts of water, 99.9% of the atmosphere is composed of N₂, O₂ and the noble gases, principally Ar. These gases have been present at constant levels over geological timescales (although there is some debate over the fluctuations in O₂).

Table 1.1 — Composition of the Troposphere

Constituent	Mole fraction	Lifetime (yr)
N ₂	0.781	1.6 × 10 ⁷
O ₂	0.209	9000
Ar	0.0093	4.5 × 10 ⁹
CO ₂	0.000416	50–150
H ₂ O	0–0.04	5 days
CH ₄	2100 ppb	10
H ₂	550 ppb	4
N ₂ O	320 ppb	150
CO	50–200 ppb	0.2
O ₃	20–80 ppb	20 days
C ₂ H ₆	1 ppb	0.2
SO ₂	0.1 ppb	5 days
NO ₂	0.1 ppb	2 days
OH	0.1 ppt	0.1 s

The remaining gases, representing less than 0.1% of the atmosphere, are diverse but have an important influence on a number of atmospheric processes. The gases with long lifetimes (CH₄, N₂O, etc.) are fairly uniformly distributed in the troposphere. The minor trace species, e.g. SO₂, NO₂, organic gases, all have abundances of ≤1 ppb (parts per billion by volume, or nano moles/mole, e.g. 10⁻⁹), at the global average scale, but are very variable in space and time (NB on Lensfield Road the NO₂ mixing ratio is probably 20 ppb). O₃ has a concentration usually in the range 20–80 ppb with some variability.

Figure 1.5 shows the mixing ratios of a range of important gases in the atmosphere. This is a key figure we will come back to.

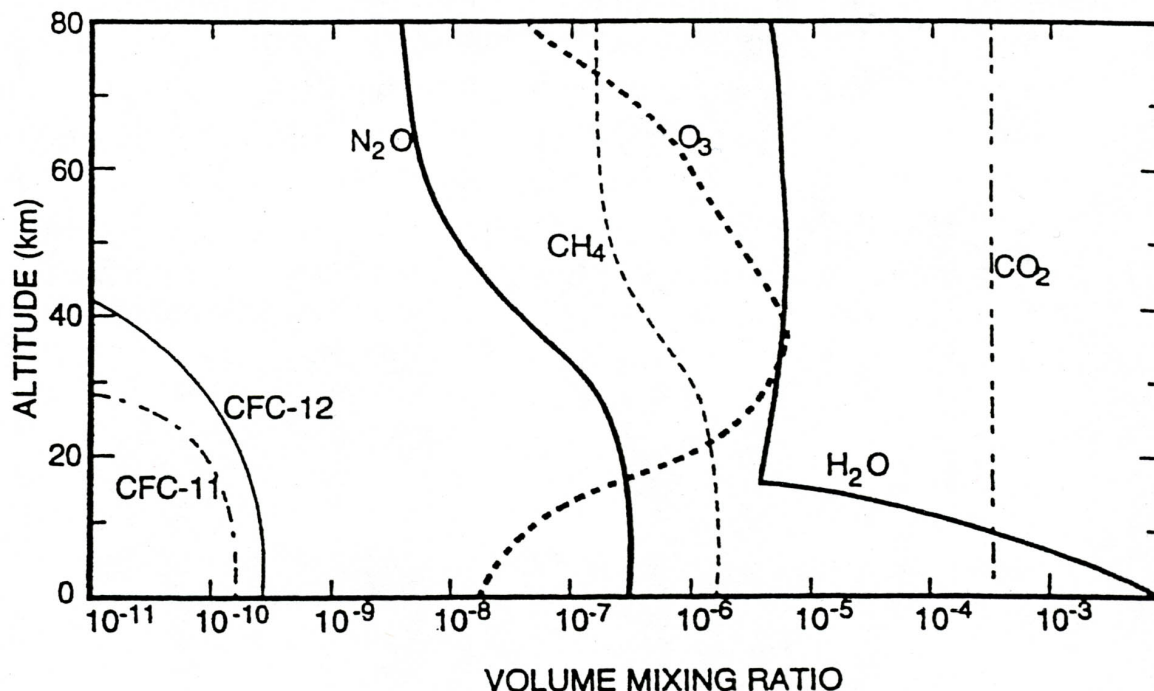


Figure 1.5 — Some typical mixing ratio profiles of a range of species.

Key points in Figure 1.5 - Mixing ratios tell us how [X] varies with [M] (NB [M] decreases exponentially with increasing height). - Long-lived gases have nearly constant mixing ratios (e.g. CO₂, N₂, O₂, He). - Increases in mixing ratio of a compound reveal to us that it is undergoing chemical production. - Decreases in mixing ratio denote chemical destruction (or loss).

1.4 The Stratosphere — basic structure and composition

The stratosphere lies above the troposphere, bounded by the tropopause and the stratopause at about 50 km. Temperature increases with altitude in the stratosphere — a stable situation which leads to a long removal time for pollution reaching the stratosphere.

Ozone is perhaps the most important stratospheric constituent. O₃ absorbs ultraviolet radiation, which leads to the observed stratospheric temperature structure and also protects life at the surface from harmful radiation at $\lambda < 300$ nm. Ozone is also an important infrared absorber — it's a greenhouse gas involved in climate change.

Stratospheric chemistry is mainly concerned with the sources and sinks of ozone. Ozone has a peak stratospheric mixing ratio of about 10 ppm. Its local abundance is determined by a balance between photochemical production following photolysis of molecular oxygen and catalytic destruction by a variety of radical species (e.g. OH, HO₂, NO, NO₂, Cl, ClO, etc.), which are present at much lower concentration (usually ppb or less). (In those regions where the chemical lifetime of ozone becomes long, transport will also be important in determining the local concentration.) The radicals are produced following the breakdown of source gases (source gases shown in Fig 1.5) including H₂O, CH₄, N₂O and the CFCs (CFCl₃, etc.).

Throughout the bulk of the stratosphere gas phase reactions dominate. However, ozone loss in polar latitudes is initiated by reactions on the surface of particles or droplets — polar stratospheric clouds — in the lower stratosphere. Reactions on aerosol droplets (mainly sulphuric acid) are also now known to be important in the middle latitude lower stratosphere.

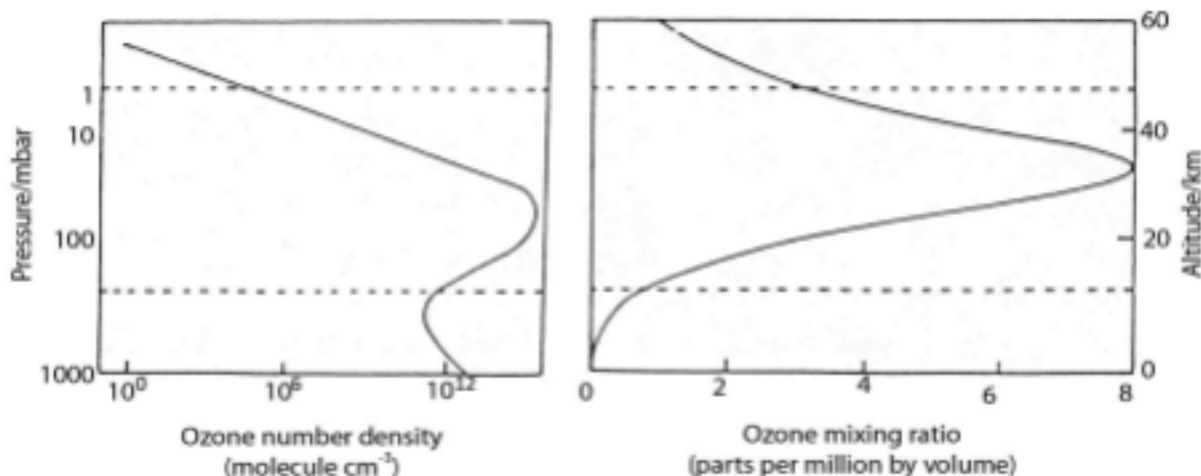


Figure 1.6 — Variation of ozone concentration with altitude, expressed as an absolute number density (n_{O_3} , with peak just above 10^{12} cm^{-3}) and as a mixing ratio (mole fraction, n_{O_3}/n_{air}).

We will see later that it is also possible to measure the amount of a species integrated between the earth's surface and the top of the atmosphere. This integral, e.g. $\int [O_3] dz$, is loosely called the column amount, the column density or the total column. It commonly has units of molecules cm^{-2} . For the special case of ozone, the unit is named after Dobson, an early measurement pioneer.

1 Dobson Unit (DU) = $2.69 \times 10^{16} \text{ molec cm}^{-2}$. A typical column density for ozone is about 300 DU — i.e. an ozone column that would be 3 mm thick when shrunk down to the surface.

Exercise 2 — Calculation of the column of a well-mixed gas

Definition of the column:

$$\text{Column} = \int [x] dz$$

(Eq 1)

For a well-mixed gas the concentration decreases exponentially with altitude following the barometric equation:

$$p = p_0 e^{-z/H} \quad (\text{just replace } p \text{ for } [x])$$

Thus, we can re-write Eq 1 as:

$$\text{Column} = [x]_0 \int e^{-z/H} dz$$

(Eq 2)

where $[x]_0$ is the concentration at a fixed point in the atmosphere. We then integrate Eq 2 between z and infinity (the top of the atmosphere) to get:

$$\text{Column} = [x]_0 \cdot H$$

(Eq 3)

From Exercise 1 we can work out $[x]_0$ as being the number density at the surface multiplied by the mixing ratio (which will be constant over all altitudes).

Try it yourself

Open [notebooks/01-atmospheric-structure.ipynb](#) to:

- Compute number density at any altitude/temperature/pressure (Exercise 1), and plot the barometric fall-off of pressure, density and $[M]$ with height.
- Fit a scale height to a modelled or real pressure profile, and compare it to $H = RT/Mg$.
- Compute the column amount of a well-mixed gas (Exercise 2), reproduce the ~300 DU ozone column, and see how mixing ratio vs. number-density profiles (Fig 1.5/1.6) relate to the column integral.

Next: [Module 2 — Chemical Kinetics in the Atmosphere](#)

Chemical Kinetics in the Atmosphere

Module 2 · Chemical Kinetics in the Atmosphere

Learning aims By the end of this module you should be able to: 1. Apply first-order and pseudo-first-order kinetics to atmospheric decay problems, and define the associated time constant. 2. Apply the steady-state approximation to a simple reaction chain, and judge when it is (and isn't) valid. 3. Use Arrhenius parameters to describe the temperature dependence of a bi-molecular rate coefficient. 4. Explain why most apparently bi-molecular association reactions are actually ter-molecular, and describe the low-/high-pressure limiting behaviour.

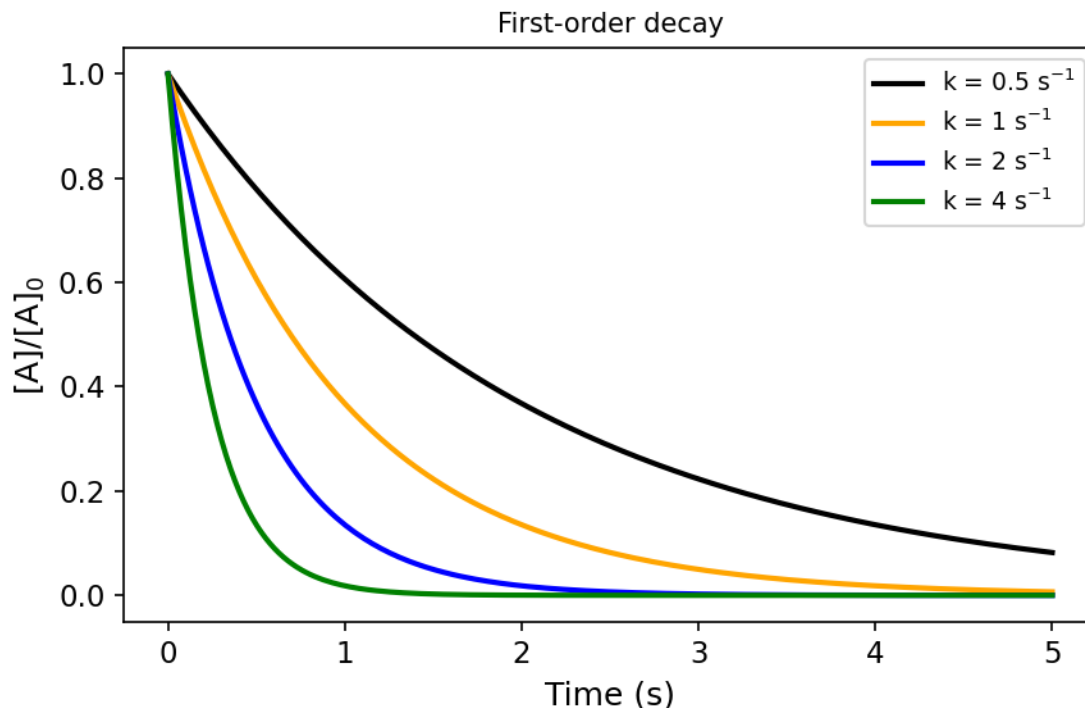
2.1 Time scales and lifetimes

As atmospheric chemists we are fundamentally interested in understanding how the constituents of the atmosphere (the gases and particles that make it up) change with time. For example, the questions of how the concentration of O_3 will change in the future and how it has changed in the past are crucial to the science of the Antarctic ozone hole. In order to understand these types of questions we rely on a solid knowledge of (i) what the constituents (chemical and aerosol species) are in the atmosphere and (ii) how the constituents in the atmosphere react over time. Hence, it's fair to say that chemical kinetics is at the heart of atmospheric chemistry.

For simple chemical systems, we can write out differential equations that describe how the components of the system will change over time. Let's start with a trivial example. Suppose that we study, in a closed constant-volume system, a reaction whose rate depends on the concentration of one reacting substance, A , only. We can write:

$$\frac{d[A]}{dt} = -k[A]^n$$

where in this case $n = 1$ and this reaction is said to be first order with respect to A (molecules cm^{-3}). Plots of the change in concentration of A with time are shown in Fig 2.1 for different values of rate coefficient, k (s^{-1}). Fig 2.1 highlights that the larger the value of the rate coefficient (sometimes called rate constant, and erroneously "the rate" — naughty!) the faster the loss of A with time.



Figure

2.1 — Plots of the first-order decay of A with respect to time.

We can define a new expression by integrating our rate equation for A and noting that our initial conditions are $A = A_0$ at $t = 0$:

$$\int_0^t k dt = - \int_0^A [A]^{-n} dA$$

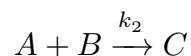
As Fig 2.1 highlights, the decay of A with time can be described as a simple exponential process. We can use this graph and the equations above to define the time constant (τ) as the time taken for the concentration of A to be reduced by $1/e^{\text{th}}$ of its value:

$$\tau = 1/k$$

The smaller this time constant, the greater the loss of A with time and hence the shorter its lifetime.

Pseudo first-order kinetics

In the atmosphere there are several very important reactions that are first order and, fortunately, many that can be described as pseudo first order. For example, consider the slightly more complex reaction:



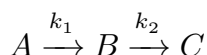
On first glance we expect this to be a second-order process (first order in A and first order in B , so second order overall). However, if the concentration of $[B]$ doesn't change much over time (for example because B is present in large excess) then we can make the approximation that $d[B]/dt \simeq 0$, which allows us to consider A as undergoing pseudo-first-order kinetics ($[B] \sim \text{constant}$, so it can be folded into our second-order rate

constant k_2 to yield a pseudo-first-order rate constant, $k'_2 = k_2[B]$). The time constant for A is now given by:

$$\tau = \frac{1}{k_2[B]} = \frac{1}{k'_2}$$

A chain reaction: $A \rightarrow B \rightarrow C$

We will now consider a slightly more complex example but one which you may be familiar with. Let's consider the chain reaction:



where A is our initial reactant, B an intermediate product and C the final product of the reaction. Following the same procedure as above we can write:

$$\frac{d[A]}{dt} = -k_1[A]$$

$$\frac{d[B]}{dt} = k_1[A] - k_2[B]$$

$$\frac{d[C]}{dt} = k_2[B]$$

Solutions to these equations for $k_1 = 1 \text{ s}^{-1}$, $k_2 = 2 \text{ s}^{-1}$, and (separately) $k_1 = 1 \text{ s}^{-1}$, $k_2 = 10 \text{ s}^{-1}$, are worth plotting side by side (see the notebook for details).

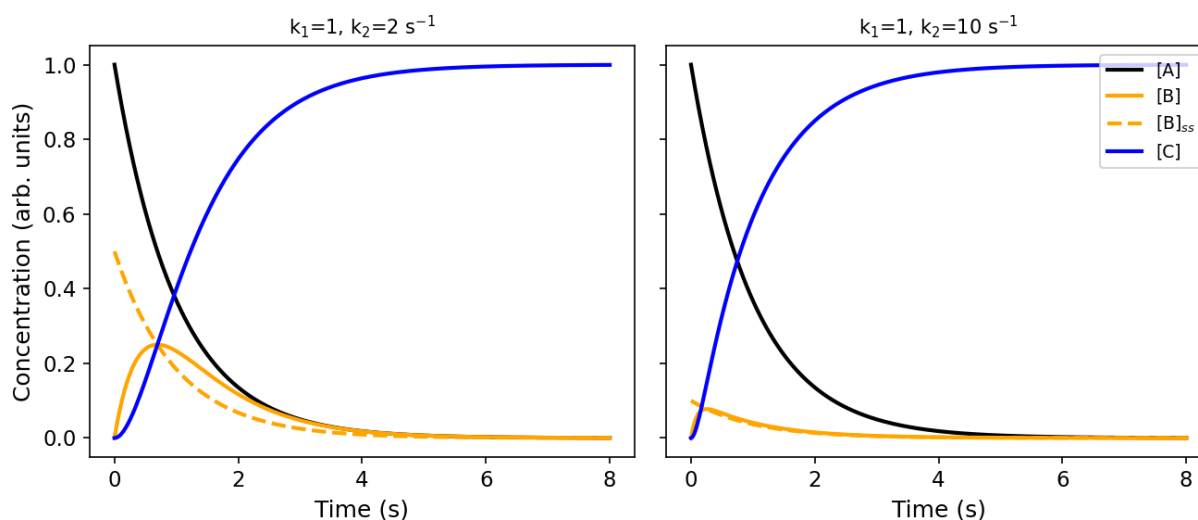


Figure — The $A \rightarrow B \rightarrow C$ chain reaction for $(k_1, k_2) = (1, 2) \text{ s}^{-1}$ (left) and $(1, 10) \text{ s}^{-1}$ (right), comparing the exact $[B]$ (solid) against the steady-state approximation $[B]_{ss} = k_1[A]/k_2$ (dashed).

What you will notice is that the intermediate B is short-lived relative to C , and that as the value of k_2 increases, the peak concentration of B decreases. The time it takes for B to reach an almost-steady concentration is $\sim 1/k_2$. In the limit where $k_2 \gg k_1$ we can make the approximation:

$$\frac{d[B]_{ss}}{dt} \simeq 0$$

where the subscript ss denotes that we are treating the intermediate B as being in steady state.

Following this through, we can re-write the remaining equations describing our reaction (substituting $[B]_{ss} = k_1[A]/k_2$):

$$\frac{d[A]}{dt} = -k_1[A]$$

$$\frac{d[C]}{dt} = k_2 \cdot \frac{k_1[A]}{k_2} \simeq k_1[A]$$

In doing so, we have greatly reduced the complexity of this reaction system.

In the atmosphere there are many examples of compounds that can be considered to be in steady state. For the steady-state assumption to apply, it is necessary that the rate constants for destruction of the intermediate greatly exceed those for its formation, so that its concentration remains low and (quasi-)constant.

Often we will consider the concept of an air parcel throughout this course. An air parcel can be thought of as a “box of air.” Suppose there are two species in the box, A and B. There are emissions of A, F_A , and A can undergo reactions (conversion) to form B, which subsequently is lost via other processes. We can consider what the inputs into the box are, and what the outputs are — and appeal to steady state to write down steady-state solutions for $[A]$ and $[B]$, and hence an expression for the ratio $[B]_{ss}/[A]_{ss}$.

Worked derivation: steady-state ratio $[B]_{ss}/[A]_{ss}$ for a source of A feeding into B

Consider the box model described above: A is emitted at a constant rate F_A and is lost with pseudo-first-order rate constant k' (converting it to B); B is in turn lost with pseudo-first-order rate constant k'' .

$$\frac{d[A]}{dt} = F_A - k'[A]$$

$$\frac{d[B]}{dt} = k'[A] - k''[B]$$

Step 1 — steady state for A. Setting $d[A]/dt = 0$:

$$0 = F_A - k'[A]_{ss} \implies [A]_{ss} = \frac{F_A}{k'}$$

Step 2 — steady state for B. Setting $d[B]/dt = 0$ and substituting $[A]_{ss}$:

$$0 = k'[A]_{ss} - k''[B]_{ss} \implies [B]_{ss} = \frac{k'[A]_{ss}}{k''}$$

Step 3 — take the ratio. Dividing $[B]_{ss}$ by $[A]_{ss}$, the $[A]_{ss}$ cancels:

$$\frac{[B]_{ss}}{[A]_{ss}} = \frac{k'[A]_{ss}/k''}{[A]_{ss}} = \frac{k'}{k''}$$

Step 4 — rewrite in terms of lifetimes. Since k' and k'' are just the pseudo-first-order loss rate constants for A and B respectively, they define the corresponding lifetimes $\tau_A = 1/k'$ and $\tau_B = 1/k''$ (Section 2.1). Substituting:

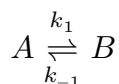
$$\frac{[B]_{ss}}{[A]_{ss}} = \frac{k'}{k''} = \frac{1/\tau_A}{1/\tau_B} = \frac{\tau_B}{\tau_A}$$

So the steady-state concentration ratio of a product to its precursor is simply the ratio of their lifetimes: a short-lived product (small τ_B) sits at a low steady-state concentration relative to its precursor, regardless of the details of F_A — this is the same intuition as the $A \rightarrow B \rightarrow C$ chain above, just recast for a species with continuous emission rather than a fixed initial concentration.

Integrating $d[A]/dt$ with the boundary condition $[A]_0$ at $t_0 = 0$ shows that, for a species with constant production F_A and pseudo-first-order loss k' :

$$[A]_t = \frac{F_A}{k'} (1 - \exp(-k't))$$

Note that for a system of two first-order (or pseudo-first-order) reactions,



the system approaches equilibrium with a time constant of $(k_1 + k_{-1})^{-1}$ (s). So we only need k_1 or k_{-1} to be large for τ to be small — which is what lets us apply the steady-state approximation.

Exercise 3 — The error in the steady-state approximation

Consider a very simple reversible system $A \rightleftharpoons B$, with forward rate constant k_f and backward rate constant k_b :

$$\frac{d[B]}{dt} = k_f[A] - k_b[B]$$

(Eq 1)

Let x denote the amount of A molecules present as B molecules, and $a = [A]_0$. Then:

$$\frac{dx}{dt} = k_f(a - x) - k_b x$$

(Eq 2)

Setting $y \equiv dx/dt$:

$$y = k_f a - (k_f + k_b)x$$

(Eq 4)

By the chain rule, $\frac{dy}{dt} = \frac{dy}{dx} \cdot \frac{dx}{dt}$. From Eq 2, $dx/dt = y$; from Eq 4, $dy/dx = -(k_f + k_b)$. So:

$$\frac{dy}{dt} = -(k_f + k_b)y \Rightarrow \frac{dy}{y} = -(k_f + k_b)dt$$

(Eq 7)

Integrating:

$$y = k_f a \cdot \exp(-(k_f + k_b)t)$$

(Eq 8)

and, since y relates to x through Eq 4, combining Eq 4 and Eq 8 gives the exact solution:

$$x = \frac{k_f a}{k_f + k_b} \left[1 - \exp(-(k_f + k_b)t) \right]$$

(Eq 9)

From this we see the timescale for the system to reach equilibrium is exactly $\frac{1}{k_f + k_b}$ — compare this exact result against the steady-state approximation numerically in the notebook.

Common question

Q: When can I put $[X]$ into steady state?

A: When we have a system we can approximate as having 1st-order loss (L' , s^{-1}) and 0th-order production (R_p), and the rate of loss is fast (i.e. $1/L'$ is small), such that as soon as X is made it gets (pretty much) destroyed:

$$\frac{d[X]_{ss}}{dt} \simeq 0 = R_p - L'[X]$$

We will consider many examples of using steady state in the supervision questions, but in general a good opening argument for whether or not to put something into steady state is to consider whether or not it is a radical.

Chemistry vs. transport timescales

So far we have considered some very trivial examples. Whilst these have been trivial, they are still very useful for our studies of atmospheric chemistry. But an important complication for us as atmospheric chemists is that the reaction vessel we use in our studies is the atmosphere itself! You only need to venture outdoors to note that the reactions taking place in the atmosphere are doing so under far-from-controlled conditions. The gases and particles we are interested in are affected not only by chemical change but also by transport — for example through the wind. In this course we won't dwell much on atmospheric transport (that's covered in greater detail in the Part III course). What is important, however, is to have a feel for the relative time scales of chemistry and transport.

The time constants (lifetimes) of a range of constituents of interest to the atmospheric chemist are presented in Fig 2.2. As we've seen, compounds with very short time constants change in concentration very rapidly with time — so one would expect that their concentrations will be very different over short spatial scales.

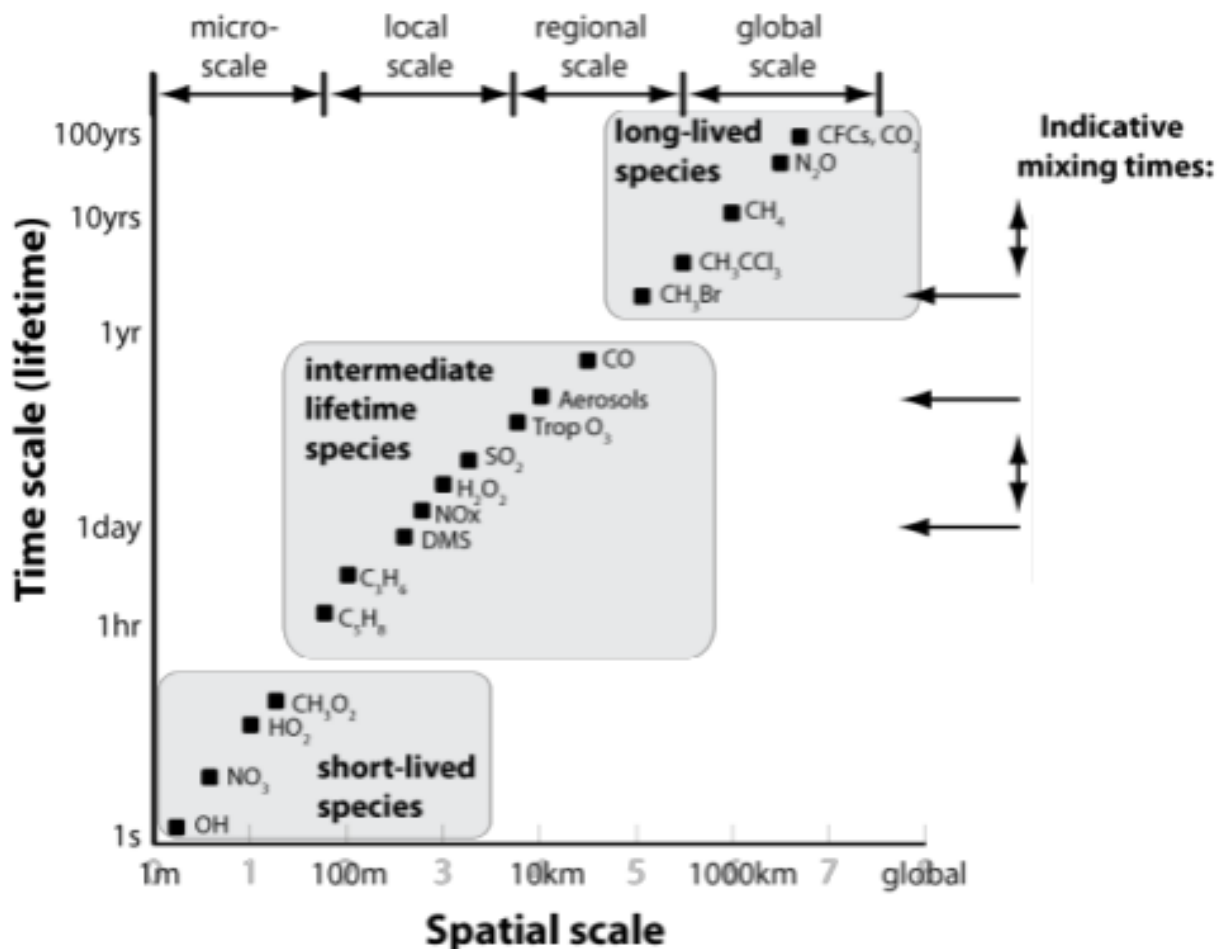
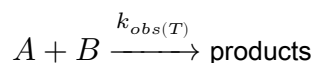


Figure 2.2 — Comparison of spatial and chemical scales of selected gases in the atmosphere.

2.2 Bi-molecular rate coefficients

Elementary reactions that involve two constituents can be written as:



Often it's found that the rate coefficients for these types of reactions show temperature dependence. Whilst we can use tools like quantum mechanics and statistical thermodynamics to predict rate constants and their temperature dependence, in this course we will just make use of experimentally observed data.

Second-order, or bi-molecular, rate coefficients are usually expressed using the following form in atmospheric chemistry:

$$k_{obs}(T) = A \exp\left(-\frac{E_a}{RT}\right) \quad (\text{molecules}^{-1} \text{ cm}^3 \text{ s}^{-1})$$

where A is often referred to as the Arrhenius pre-exponential factor, E_a the reaction activation energy (J mol^{-1}), R the gas constant ($\text{J K}^{-1} \text{ mol}^{-1}$) and T temperature (K). Many bi-molecular reactions in the

atmosphere show temperature dependence in their kinetics. A good example is the reaction of OH with methane (one of the most temperature-dependent reactions known).

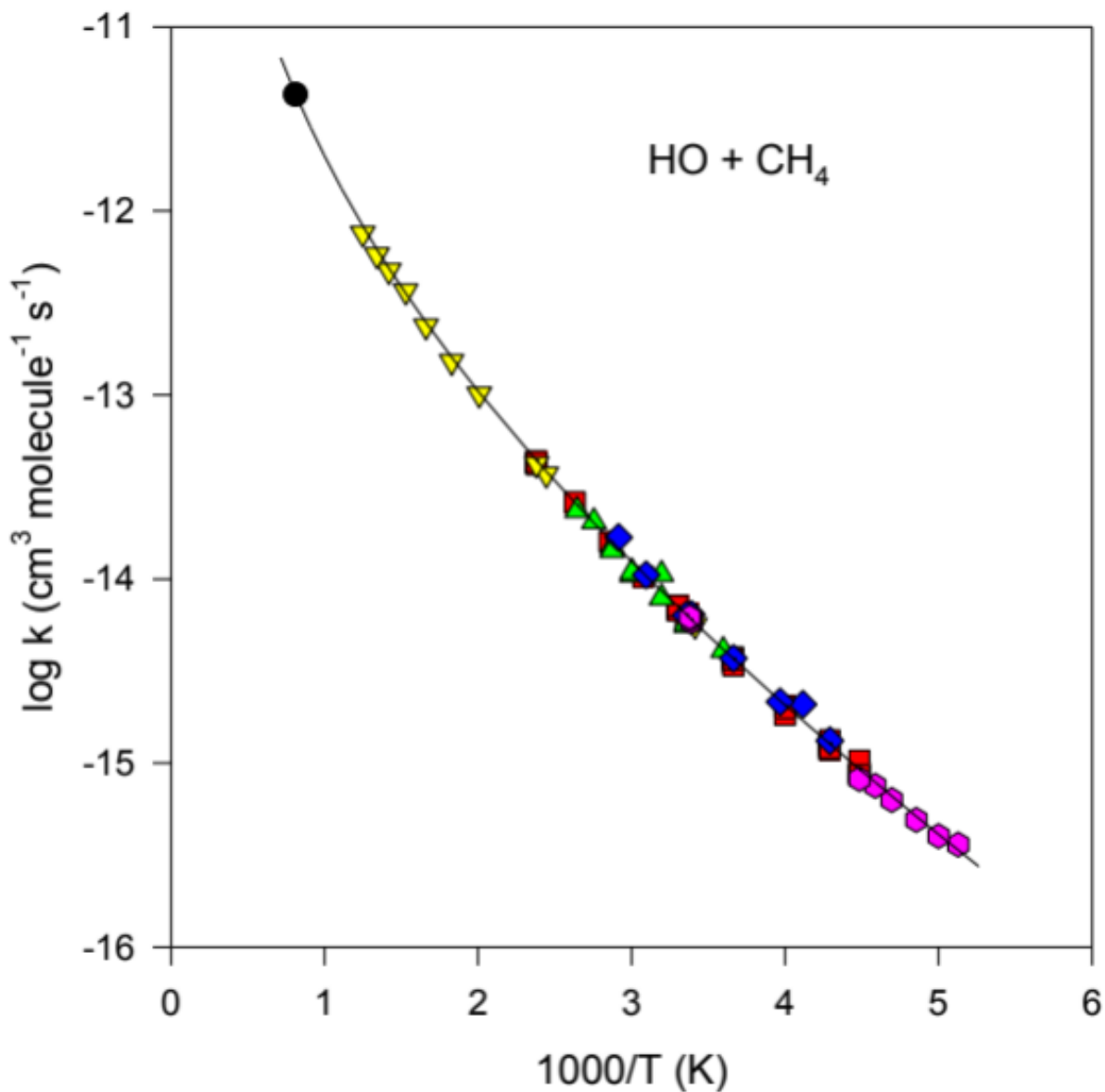
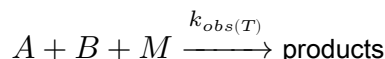


Figure 2.3 — Arrhenius plot for the reaction between methane and the hydroxyl radical in the gas phase.

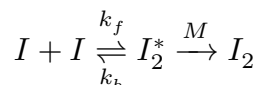
Fig 2.3 demonstrates that the reaction $\text{OH} + \text{CH}_4$ proceeds with a significant activation energy barrier. As temperature is decreased there will be a lower fraction of reactants that can overcome this barrier, and hence the observed rate of reaction will decrease.

2.3 Ter-molecular rate coefficients

A more complex but fairly common type of reaction of interest in the atmosphere is the reaction between two compounds in the presence of a third body:



Strictly speaking, most reactions require a third body (often referred to as M) to remove excess energy from the initial reaction. Consider the reaction between two iodine atoms. When the two atoms come together to form an iodine molecule, energy equal to the bond dissociation energy of I_2 is released into the nascent molecule. This is enough energy to then rupture the I–I bond and reform the iodine atoms. However, if the nascent I_2 molecule (I_2^*) collides with a third body, the encounter can transfer some of the vibrational and rotational energy of the I_2 molecule to translational (and other) excitation of the third body:

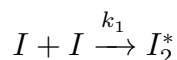


Under atmospheric conditions, M is usually N_2 or O_2 , and to a first approximation can be considered as the sum of their concentrations ($[M] = [N_2] + [O_2]$). The rate coefficients for ter-molecular reactions can be experimentally determined as a function of temperature and pressure to derive the low-pressure limit ($k_{0,T}$), which shows pressure dependence, and the high-pressure limit ($k_{\infty,T}$), which doesn't. To predict the observed rate constant as a function of temperature and pressure, we combine these two limits using the Troe equation (a modification of the Lindemann–Hinshelwood expressions), which yields a pseudo-bi-molecular rate coefficient (units $\text{molecules}^{-1} \text{cm}^3 \text{s}^{-1}$).

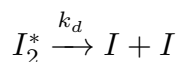
Exercise 4 — Relating the bi-molecular and ter-molecular reactions

In Kinetics of Chemical Reactions at 1A, we were told that whenever two molecules collide they bring with them enough energy to break the chemical bond that they try to form. This somewhat strange fact can be seen here in more detail.

Consider two iodine atoms colliding:



(Eq 1)



(Eq 2)



(Eq 3)

The only reaction producing our product (I_2) is Eq 3, so:

$$\frac{d[I_2]}{dt} = k_{col}[I_2^*][M]$$

(Eq 4)

I_2^* is an excited-state form of I_2 , so it's logical that it should be short-lived — put it into steady state:

$$\frac{d[I_2^*]}{dt} = 0 = k_1[I]^2 - k_{col}[I_2^*][M] - k_d[I_2^*]$$

$$[I_2^*] = \frac{k_1[I]^2}{k_{col}[M] + k_d}$$

(Eq 5)

Substituting Eq 5 into Eq 4:

$$\frac{d[I_2]}{dt} = k_{col}[M] \cdot \frac{k_1[I]^2}{k_{col}[M] + k_d}$$

(Eq 6)

Eq 6 shows the formation of I_2 behaving as a third-order (ter-molecular) process (second order in I , first order in M), whereas Eq 4 shows it as a second-order (bi-molecular) process (first order in M and I_2^*). In general, most (all) reactions that appear bi-molecular are formally ter-molecular, and this example extends to practically every association reaction (two species reacting by colliding together).

At low pressure ($[M]$ small, so $k_{col}[M] < k_d$):

$$\frac{d[I_2]}{dt} \cong [M][I]^2 \frac{k_1 k_{col}}{k_d}$$

(Eq 7)

At high pressure ($[M]$ large, so $k_{col}[M] > k_d$):

$$\frac{d[I_2]}{dt} \cong k_1[I]^2$$

(Eq 8)

Try it yourself

Open [notebooks/02-chemical-kinetics.ipynb](#) to:

- Reproduce Fig 2.1 (first-order decay for a range of k) and confirm $\tau = 1/k$.
- Solve the $A \rightarrow B \rightarrow C$ chain reaction numerically for both $(k_1, k_2) = (1, 2)$ and $(1, 10) \text{ s}^{-1}$, and check the steady-state approximation for $[B]$ against the full numerical solution.
- Solve Exercise 3 (the $A \rightleftharpoons B$ system) both analytically (Eq 9) and numerically, and quantify how the error in the steady-state approximation depends on k_f/k_b .
- Plot an Arrhenius line from A and E_a , and fit A/E_a back out from a synthetic $k(T)$ dataset — the same exercise you'd do with real IUPAC/JPL kinetics data.
- Explore the low-/high-pressure limits of a ter-molecular reaction using the Lindemann–Hinshelwood form, and see where the Troe falloff curve sits between Eq 7 and Eq 8.

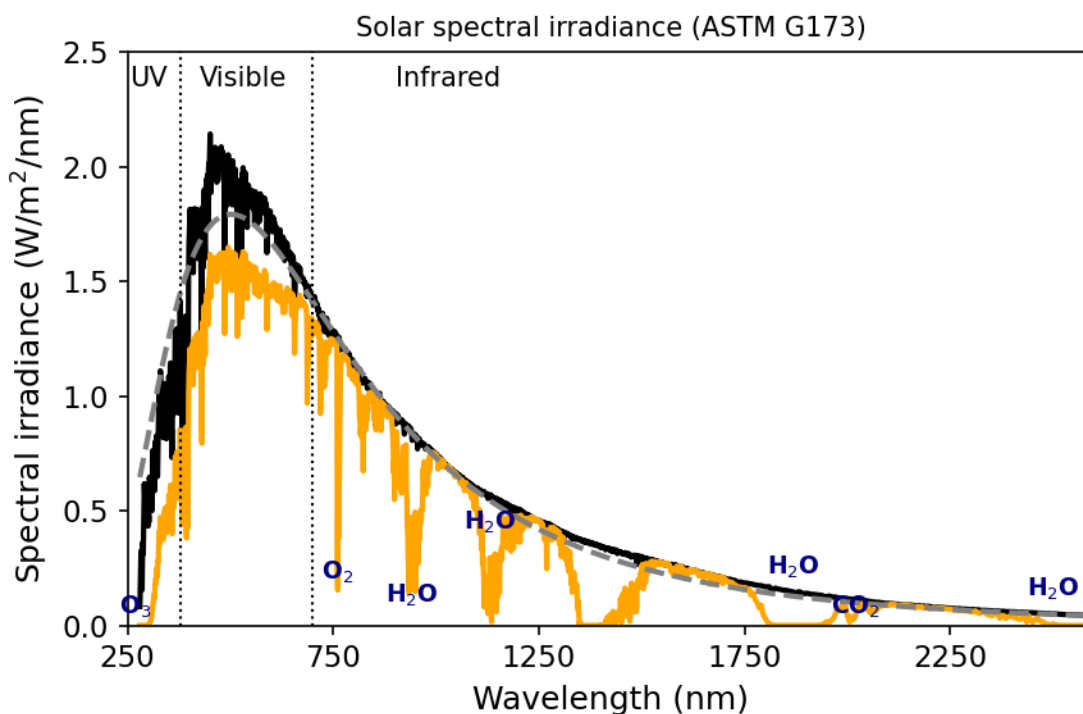
Next: [Module 3 — Atmospheric Photochemistry](#)

Atmospheric Photochemistry

Module 3 · Atmospheric Photochemistry

Learning aims By the end of this module you should be able to: 1. Write down and explain each term in the photolysis rate coefficient integral, $J = \int \phi F \sigma d\lambda$. 2. Use the Beer–Lambert law and optical depth to describe how photon flux and photolysis rates vary with altitude and solar zenith angle. 3. Describe the absorption and photolysis behaviour of O_2 , O_3 , NO_2 and N_2O /CFCs, and explain why the troposphere and stratosphere have such different photochemical environments.

The sun's energy drives atmospheric chemistry. Assuming that the Sun can be represented as a blackbody emitter, Wien's displacement law ($\lambda_{max} = b/T$) can be used to predict the peak wavelength of solar radiation reaching the top of the atmosphere (TOA). Figure 3.1 shows a profile of solar radiation at the TOA and at the Earth's surface. Strong absorption occurs in a number of wavelength intervals. Whilst significant amounts of the Sun's energy are absorbed in the IR bands of H_2O and CO_2 , Fig 3.1 shows that it is absorption by O_3 and O_2 that dominate in the visible and near-UV regions. It is the absorption of radiation by these gases that triggers the cascade of reactions we will focus on in this course. One of the most important quantities we will derive is the photolysis coefficient — a first-order rate constant — which can be used to determine the effective lifetime of a gas in the atmosphere with respect to the Sun's energy.



Figure

3.1 — Solar spectral irradiance as a function of wavelength at the TOA and at the surface.

3.1 Calculation of photolysis rate coefficients

Atmospheric chemists commonly use the symbol k for a reaction rate coefficient involving molecular “collisions,” and the symbol J for a reaction rate coefficient for a reaction involving the absorption of photons resulting in molecular dissociation. We call this process photolysis (or photodecomposition). The rate coefficient of photolysis of a constituent i (J_i , units s^{-1}) can be written:

$$J_{(i)} = \int_{\lambda=0}^{\infty} \phi_{(i,\lambda)} F_{(\lambda)} \sigma_{(i,\lambda)} d\lambda$$

where $\phi_{(i,\lambda)}$ is the quantum yield (molecule photon $^{-1}$) for photolysis (the number of reactant molecules decomposed per quantum of radiation absorbed; sometimes defined per reaction pathway), $\sigma_{(i,\lambda)}$ is the wavelength-dependent absorption cross-section (usually $\text{cm}^2 \text{ molecule}^{-1}$) of species i , and $F_{(\lambda)}$ is the incident photon intensity at a given wavelength (photons $\text{cm}^{-2} \text{ s}^{-1} \text{ nm}^{-1}$).

The absorption cross-section is defined by the Beer–Lambert law, which describes the attenuation of light by a homogeneous absorbing system:

$$I = I_0 \exp(-\sigma n l)$$

where I_0 and I are the incident and transmitted light intensities, l is the absorption path length (cm), n is the concentration of absorber (molecule cm^{-3}), and σ is the absorption cross-section (cm^2 per molecule).

Given that the source of radiation of interest to us is the sun, we can use the Beer–Lambert law to determine the flux of photons at a specific wavelength as a function of altitude (z):

$$F_{\lambda}(z) = F_{\lambda}(\text{TOA}) \exp(-\text{O.D.})$$

where $F_{\lambda}(\text{TOA})$ is the intensity of radiation (flux of photons) at the top of the atmosphere. The optical depth (O.D.) can be calculated as:

$$\text{O.D.}(\lambda) = \sum_i \sigma_{i,\lambda} \times \text{column}_i$$

— where we saw in Exercise 2 (Module 1) how to calculate the column of a well-mixed gas. In the cases we will consider, the relevant distance for the column is from the TOA to our point of interest.

If the sun is at zenith angle θ , the path length is increased by a factor $\sec(\theta)$. The optical depth thus increases rapidly as the zenith angle approaches 90° . This may be important near sunrise or sunset, or at high latitudes, and can result in a marked reduction in photolysis J values.

In principle the O.D. depends on all absorbing species at the wavelength of interest. In practice, for this course most of the time we will need only consider that O_2 ($\lambda < 240 \text{ nm}$) and O_3 absorb solar radiation significantly, and only these two need be considered when calculating $F_{\lambda}(z)$.

3.2 Altitude dependence of photolysis

Figure 3.2 shows the altitude at which the intensity of solar radiation is reduced by $1/e$ from its TOA value, as a function of wavelength. There is a lot of variation in this plot, but in general we can note: (i) as we move to longer λ , radiation penetrates closer to the surface before being attenuated; (ii) beyond 320 nm, there is no difference between the photon flux at the TOA and at the surface.

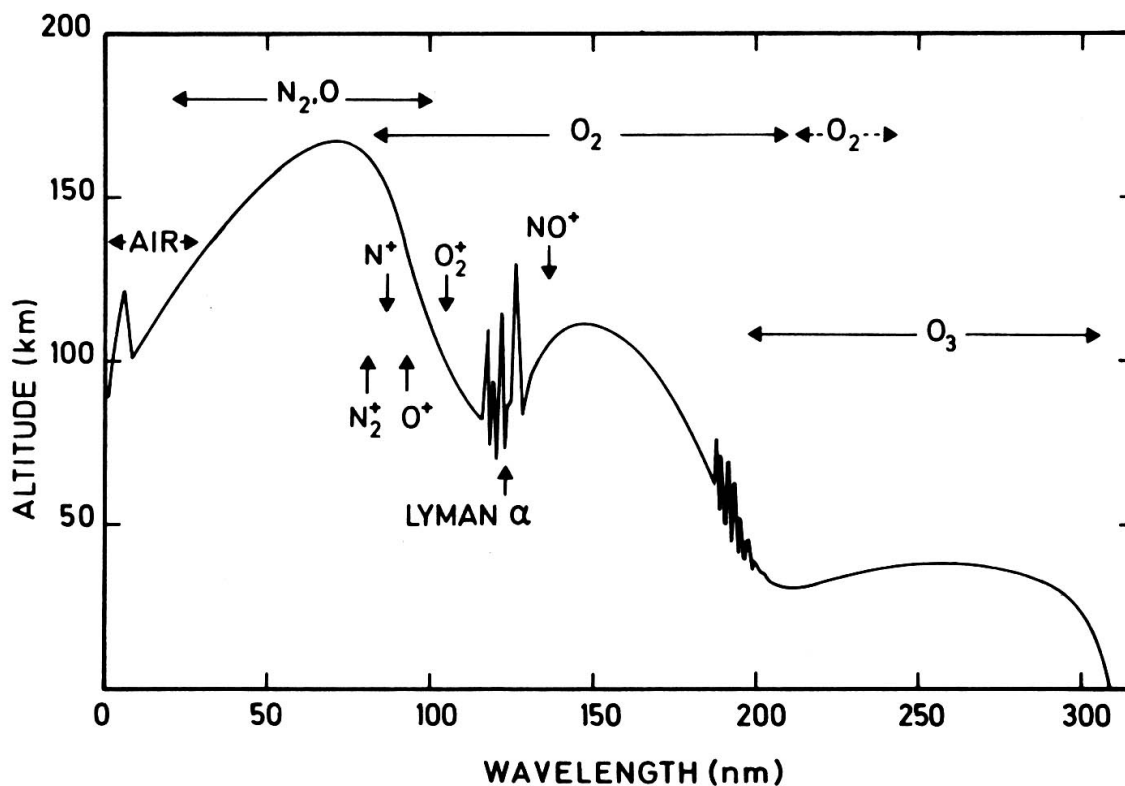
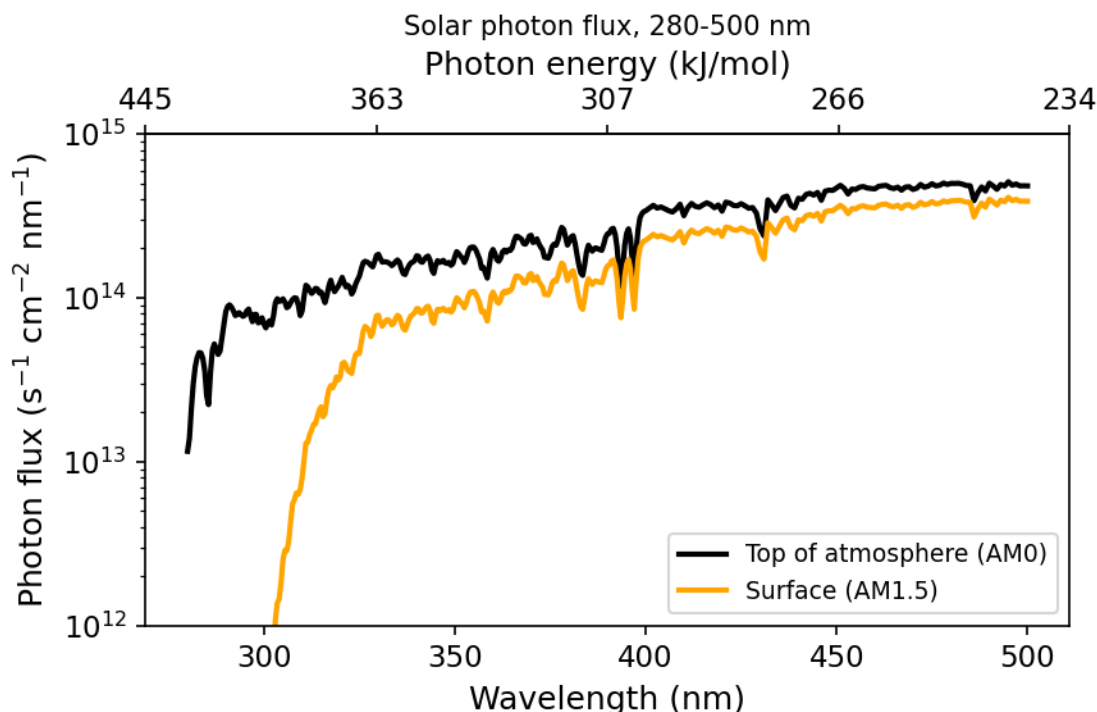


Figure 3.2 — Altitude at which attenuation reaches $1/e$. Shows how the depth of penetration of radiation varies with wavelength. Based on Thomas 1980 DOI:10.1098/rsta.1980.0167

The fine structure in Fig 3.2 comes from the fine structure in the absorption cross-sections of the atmospheric absorbers. Briefly: Fig 3.2 shows that little radiation of $\lambda < 300$ nm penetrates below the tropopause. This means the photochemistry of the troposphere is very different from that of the stratosphere.



Figure

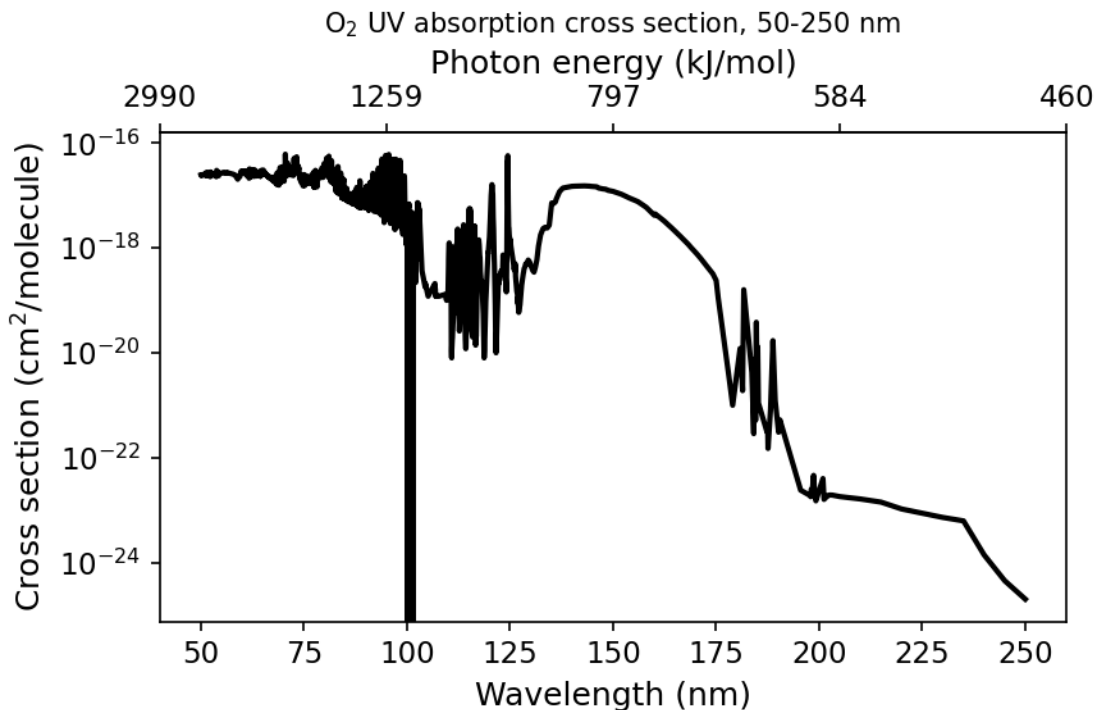
3.3 — Difference between photon flux at the top of atmosphere and the surface.

These altitude dependencies of photon fluxes matter when we come to calculate photolysis rates in different parts of the atmosphere — at 290 nm there is a factor-of-100 difference in photon flux between 40 km and 15 km, so processes requiring this wavelength proceed much more slowly at 15 km than at 40 km.

J for O_2 ($\lambda < 250$ nm) varies strongly with altitude, as the relevant photons are absorbed and removed on the way down. In contrast, J for $\text{NO}_2 + h\nu \rightarrow \text{NO} + \text{O}$ ($\lambda < 400$ nm) varies little with altitude, and it is this photolysis reaction that leads to ozone production in the troposphere (covered in more detail later).

3.3 Photolysis of O_2

The presence of O_2 has a profound effect on the photochemistry of the atmosphere. O_2 has likely been present in our atmosphere for the last 2 billion years, with its current mixing ratio roughly constant over the last 500 million years. O_2 is produced through photosynthesis and is involved in a number of biogeochemical cycles giving rise to long lifetimes in the lower atmosphere (thousands of years). However, in the stratosphere O_2 can absorb short- λ radiation and photo-dissociate. The absorption cross-section for O_2 consists of characteristic features, many named after the scientists who discovered them. The cross-section at $\lambda < 150$ nm is large but not important to O_2 photolysis in the stratosphere owing to a lack of photons at these wavelengths. The major absorption in the stratosphere is in the Herzberg continuum (220–260 nm), $A^3\Sigma_u^+ \leftarrow X^3\Sigma_g^-$.



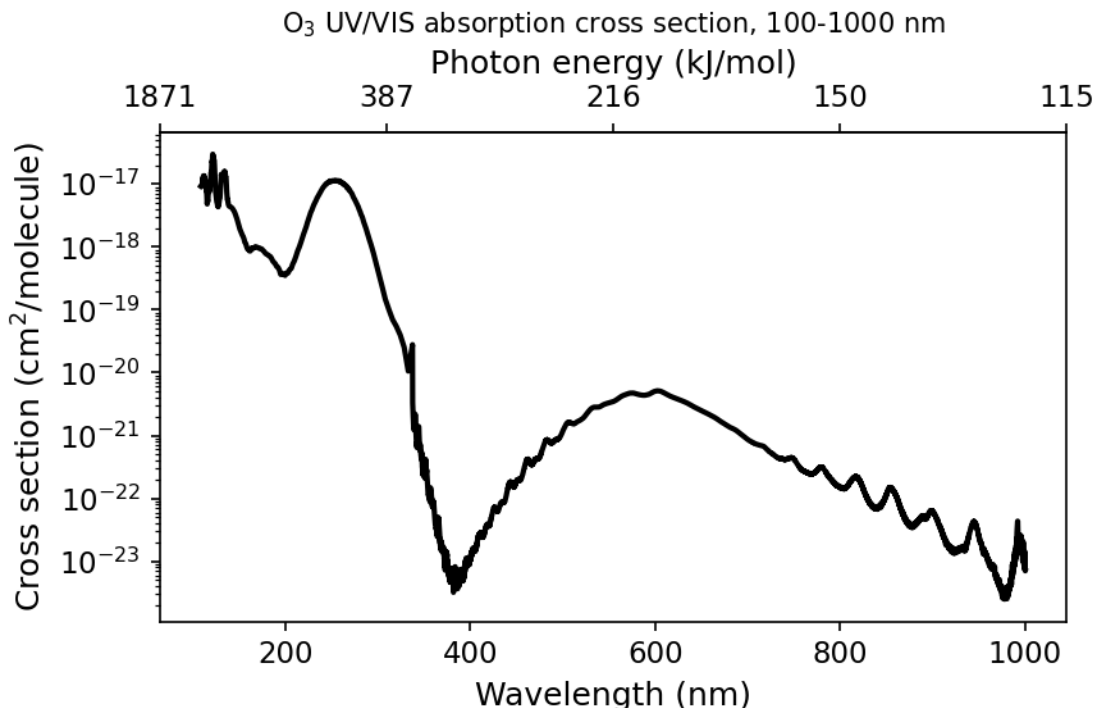
Figure

3.4 — Molecular oxygen absorption cross-sections.

Assuming unit quantum yield for photolysis of O₂ ($O_2 + h\nu \rightarrow O(^3P) + O(^3P)$), we can combine the wavelength-dependent flux profile with the absorption cross-section to calculate the photolysis frequency J_{O_2} ; the reciprocal gives the lifetime/timescale for photolysis. The lifetime of O₂ with respect to photolysis varies over 5 orders of magnitude across the altitude range 20–100 km. The longer-wavelength Herzberg absorption is relatively more important at low altitudes, while the shorter wavelengths (Schumann–Runge Bands, Schumann–Runge Continuum) are only important at high altitudes (photons at these wavelengths are absorbed high up).

3.4 O₃ photolysis

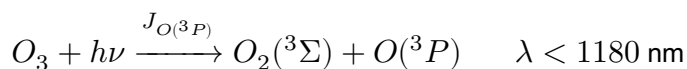
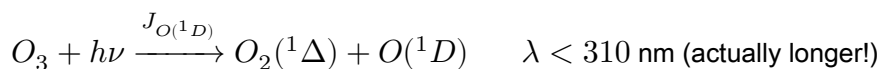
Ozone is central to the chemistry of the atmosphere! The presence of ozone in a layer in the stratosphere (the ozone layer) has helped provide an environment suitable for the evolution of life at the Earth's surface. Yet ozone itself is toxic to most plants and animal life. Hence the phrase "good up high, bad nearby" is apt for ozone.



Figure

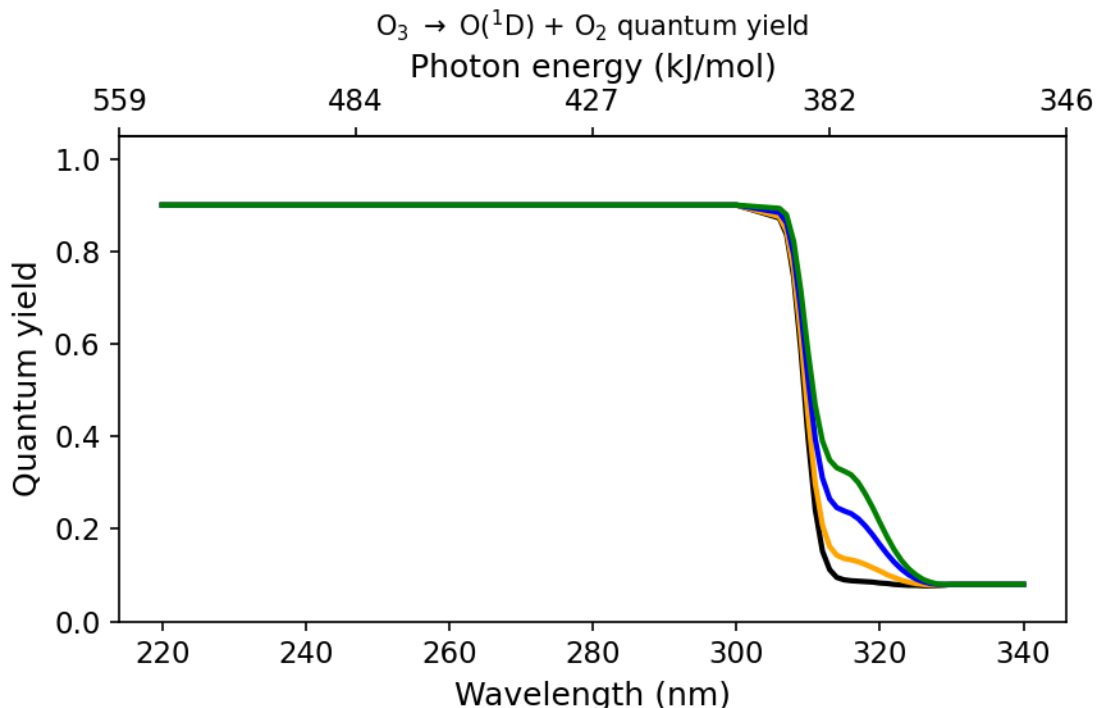
3.5 — Molecular ozone absorption cross-sections.

O₃ is relatively weakly bound compared to O₂ and can be photolysed over a wide range of wavelengths, with a theoretical threshold at 1180 nm. Absorption occurs in the so-called Hartley, Huggins and Chappuis bands. The precise photolysis products depend on the photon energy. The most important processes are photolysis to yield electronically excited oxygen atoms (rate constant $J_{O(^1D)}$) and photolysis to ground-state atomic oxygen ($J_{O(^3P)}$):



Using the absorption cross-section data together with the altitude-dependent spectral irradiance, we can calculate photolysis frequencies for O₃, just as for O₂. Photolysis of O₃ is much more rapid than photolysis of O₂: lifetimes of O₃ with respect to photolysis vary from ~8 hours to ~3 minutes over the altitude range 10–50 km.

Of more interest to our understanding of atmospheric chemistry is the reaction channel producing excited oxygen atoms, $J_{O(^1D)}$. Here we must follow the same approach as before, but rather than assuming unit quantum yield we need the wavelength (and possibly temperature) dependence of $\phi_{(\lambda)}$: at small λ the quantum yield is ~ 1.0 , whilst at $\lambda > 310 \text{ nm}$ it drops to ~ 0.0 .

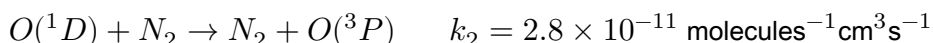
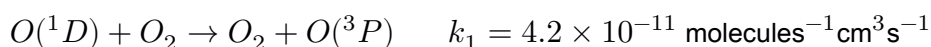


Figure

3.8 — Wavelength dependence of the O(¹D) quantum yield.

We will see later that O(¹D), while present in very low concentrations, is extremely important for atmospheric chemistry. It can actually be produced at somewhat longer wavelengths than 310 nm, possible explanations being: ‘hot band’ absorption by O₃, or possibly O₃ → O(¹D) + O₂(³Σ) (spin-forbidden).

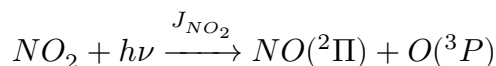
The very low concentrations of O(¹D) (order 1–100 molecules cm⁻³) occur because it is collisionally quenched back to the ground electronic state very rapidly:



3.5 Photolysis of NO₂

Nitrogen dioxide was likely first discovered by Priestley in the late 18th century. At room temperature it's a brownish gas, and — as you might imagine — this means it has a stonking great absorption cross-section in the visible spectrum.

Photolysis of NO₂ proceeds as:



The photolysis products can go on to form O₃ (through reaction with O₂ in a ter-molecular process). Indeed, photolysis of NO₂ is the main source of O₃ production in the troposphere (where O₂ cannot be photolysed).

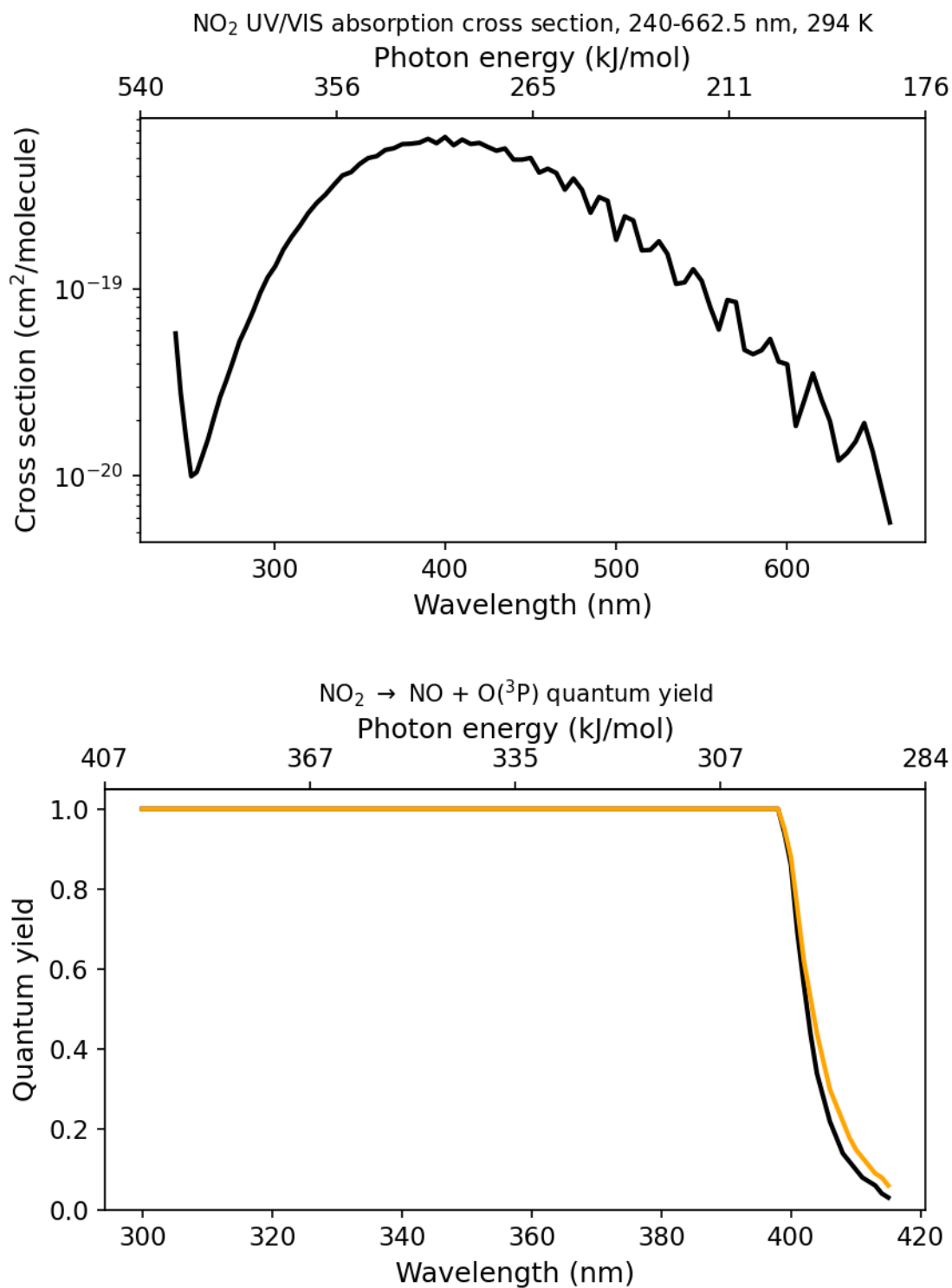


Figure 3.9 — NO₂ absorption cross-section and quantum yield.

As Fig 3.9 shows, the cross-section remains relatively large even at long wavelengths (where the atmosphere is otherwise practically transparent), resulting in large photolysis frequencies even near the surface:

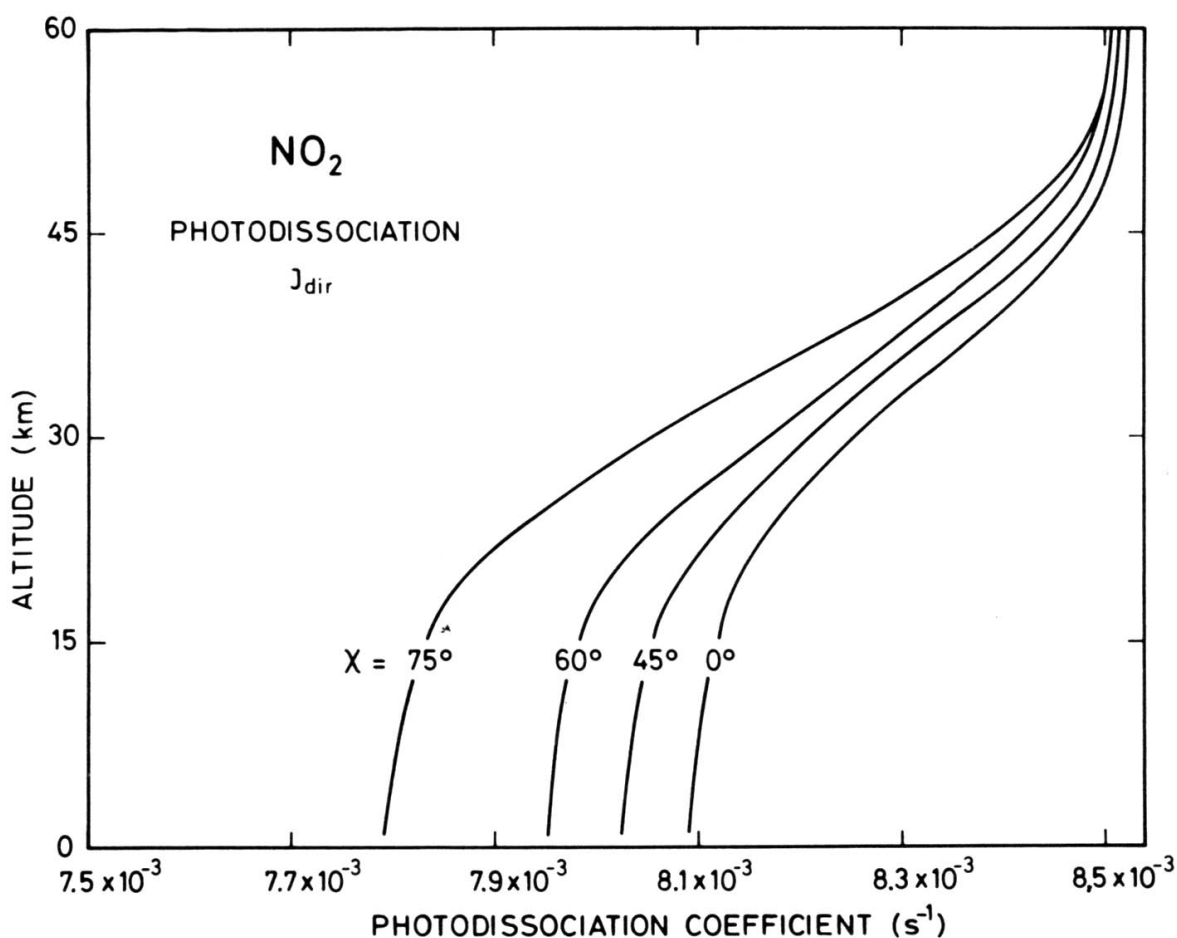
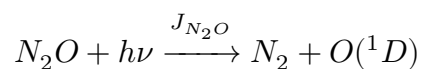


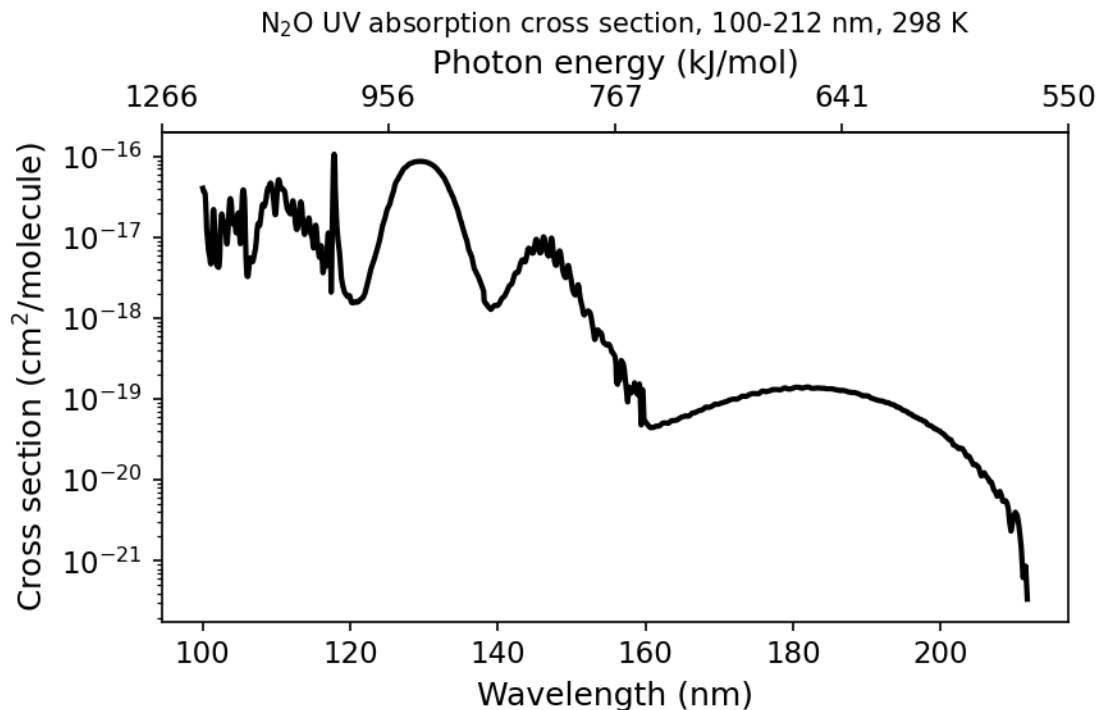
Figure 3.10 — NO_2 photolysis rates as a function of solar zenith angle.

NO_2 photolysis happens so rapidly that NO_2 can usually be thought of as being in steady state (i.e. the first-order rate of loss — photolysis — is large enough to keep its concentration low and steady) during daylight hours. Fig 3.10 shows that even at high solar zenith angles photolysis remains rapid ($\Delta\tau \sim 5\%$ between midday and 6 am). This is an important aspect of NO_2 chemistry, and one that will let us simplify complex reaction chains later in the course.

3.6 Photolysis of N_2O and other compounds

Photolysis of N_2O almost exclusively proceeds as:



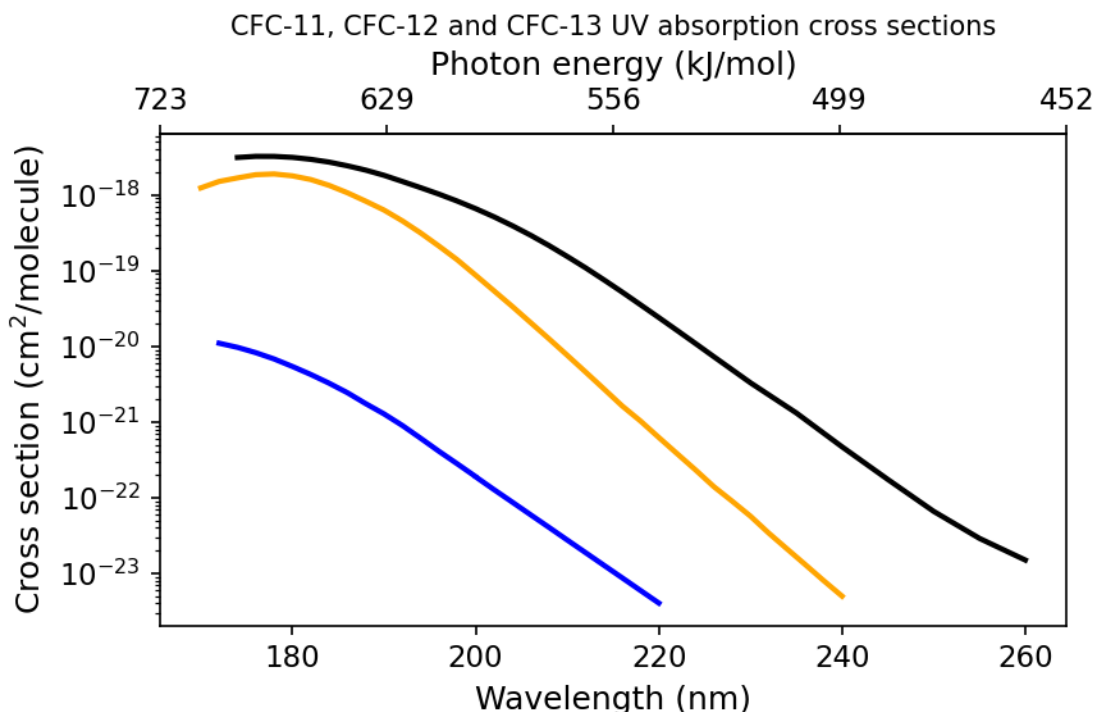


Figure

3.11 — N₂O absorption cross-sections as a function of wavelength (and energy).

N₂O absorbs strongly at short λ (< 220 nm). The main things to note: at the longer wavelengths available in the troposphere there is no photolysis of N₂O, and N₂O can contribute significantly to the optical depth at low wavelengths.

CFCs (chlorofluorocarbons) contain carbon, fluorine and chlorine and are entirely man-made. PFCs (perfluorinated carbons) are largely man-made, but the simplest PFC (CF₄) has a natural source from the oxidation of certain volcanic rocks. PFCs are very stable — in fact the absorption cross-section of CF₄ is so small that under most stratospheric conditions its lifetime is millions of years, so we won't worry about PFCs for now (although they are strong greenhouse gases, so don't think they aren't important!).



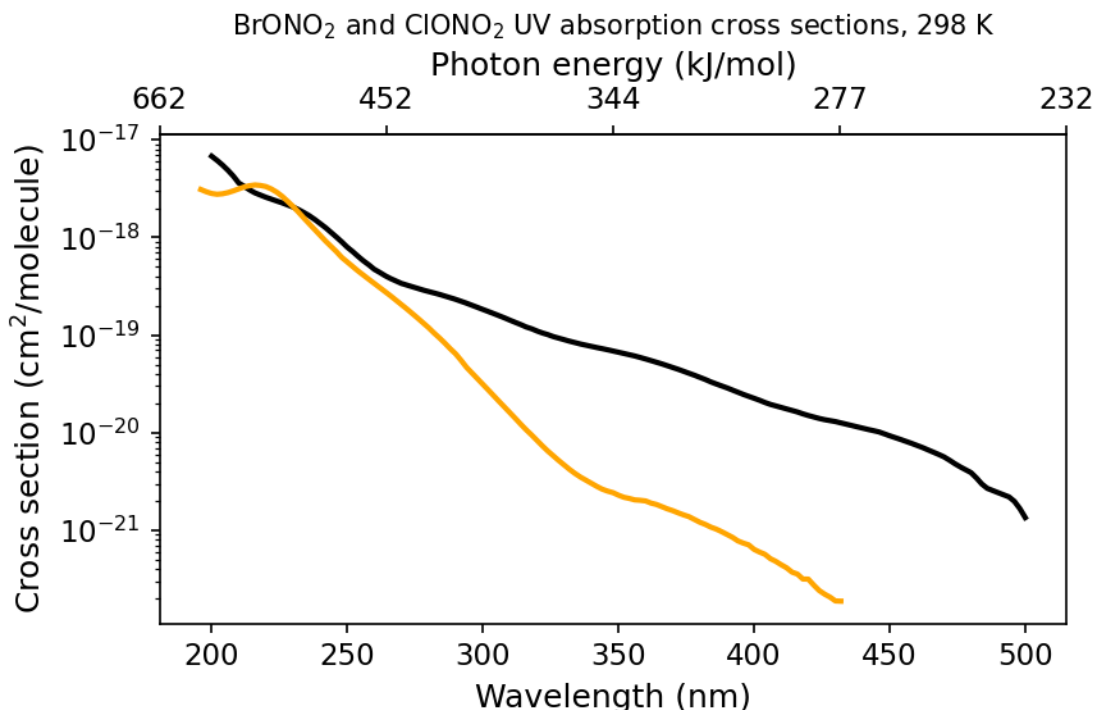
Figure

3.11 — CFC absorption cross-sections as a function of wavelength (and energy).

The naming convention for CFCs: the rightmost digit in the name gives the number of fluorine atoms (n_F); the next digit to the left gives the number of hydrogen atoms plus 1 ($n_H + 1$); and the next gives the number of carbon atoms minus 1 ($n_C - 1$), with zero values omitted. For example, CFC-11 has $n_F = 1$, $n_H = 0$ (so digit = 1), $n_C = 1$ (so digit = 0), giving CFC-11 = CCl₃F.

CFC absorption cross-sections are fairly large at very short λ and almost completely featureless (compare O₃ and NO₂). There is a huge range in CFC lifetimes as a function of altitude — tropospheric lifetimes are many thousands of years, but upper-stratospheric lifetimes are only a few days.

Important breakdown products from the photolysis of Cl- and Br-containing compounds in the stratosphere are the halogen nitrates. Their absorption cross-sections differ greatly at $\lambda > 260$ nm, with BrONO₂ having a sufficiently large cross-section at $\lambda > 320$ nm that its lifetime is very short.



Figure

3.11 — Halogen nitrate absorption cross-sections as a function of wavelength (and energy).

Try it yourself

Open [notebooks/03-photolysis-rates.ipynb](#) to:

- Implement the Beer–Lambert / optical-depth calculation and reproduce the qualitative shape of Fig 3.2 (attenuation depth vs. wavelength) for a simplified O₂/O₃ atmosphere.
- Compute a toy photolysis coefficient $J_i = \int \phi F \sigma d\lambda$ numerically given synthetic $\sigma(\lambda)$, $\phi(\lambda)$ and $F(\lambda)$ data, and convert to a photolysis lifetime.
- Explore how J scales with solar zenith angle via the $\sec(\theta)$ airmass factor, and reproduce the qualitative NO₂ vs. O₂ altitude-dependence contrast described in §3.2.
- Plot the O(¹D) quantum-yield step function (Fig 3.8) and see how a sharp cutoff wavelength propagates into a photolysis rate integral.

Next: [Module 4 — Stratospheric Ozone Chemistry: the Chapman Mechanism](#)

Stratospheric Ozone Chemistry: the Chapman Mechanism and Catalytic Cycles

Module 4 · Stratospheric Ozone Chemistry

Learning aims By the end of this module you should be able to: 1. Write down the Chapman reactions and derive the steady-state Chapman ozone concentration. 2. Explain why the Chapman mechanism alone overestimates stratospheric ozone, and what this implies about additional loss processes. 3. Describe the general form of a catalytic ozone-destruction cycle and derive the odd-oxygen loss rate for the NO_x, HO_x, ClO_x and BrO_x families. 4. Explain the role of reservoir species in moderating the efficiency of each catalytic family.

4.1 The Chapman Reactions

The discovery of O₃ in the atmosphere is usually attributed to Christian Friedrich Schönbein (1799–1868). Schönbein noticed a strange odour associated with electrical discharges — for those of you who have ever operated an “old” photocopier, you may recognize this odour.

Schönbein quantified the presence of O₃ in air using pieces of parchment soaked in a solution of KI, which would change colour on exposure to O₃. These early measurements are our only record of O₃ levels in the atmosphere at the time, and as you can imagine represent far-from-ideal data sets. Interestingly, Schönbein’s method has continued to this day, albeit with modifications, in the form of the KI electrochemical cell.

It wasn’t until the work of Gordon Dobson (1889–1975), who pioneered spectroscopic measurements of O₃ using the Dobson spectrophotometer during the 1920s, that we had a good picture of the distribution and abundance of O₃ in the upper atmosphere.

These early observations provided the first challenge for atmospheric chemists: to explain the occurrence of a thick layer of O₃ in the stratosphere. In 1930, Sidney Chapman (1888–1970) proposed a series of reactions to explain this distribution of stratospheric ozone.

Reaction	Rate coefficient	Eq.
O ₂ + hν → O + O	$J_2 \sim 5 \times 10^{-10} \text{ s}^{-1}$	4.1
O + O ₂ + M → O ₃ + M	$k_3 = 6 \times 10^{-34} (300/T)^2 \text{ cm}^6 \text{ s}^{-1}$	4.2
O ₃ + hν → O + O ₂	$J_3 \sim 2 \times 10^{-3} \text{ s}^{-1}$	4.3
O + O ₃ → O ₂ + O ₂	$k_4 = 1.0 \times 10^{-11} \exp(-2100/T) \text{ cm}^3 \text{ s}^{-1}$	4.4

Notice that the photolysis of oxygen is much slower than the photolysis of ozone ($J_2 \ll J_3$; values given are for ~40 km). Reactions 4.2 and 4.3 have very short time constants for the conversion of O to O₃ and vice versa, and establish a steady state much more rapidly than reactions 4.1 and 4.4.

Exercise 5 — Time constants for inter-conversion of O and O₃

As in Exercise 3, the time scale for interconversion of species is $(k_f + k_b)^{-1}$ (both must be first-order or pseudo-first-order rate constants).

O and O₃ are linked by interconversion reactions:



Here $k_f = k_{O+O_2}[M][O_2]$ (pseudo-first-order for reaction 4.2) and $k_b = J_3$.

Focusing on the middle stratosphere (30 km, $T = 225$ K), from Module 1's Exercise 1 we have $[M]_{30\text{km}} = 2.4 \times 10^{19} \exp(-30/7) = 3.3 \times 10^{17} \text{ cm}^{-3}$ ($[O_2] = 0.2[M]$). The interconversion timescale is:

$$(3.3 \times 10^{17} \times 0.2 \times 3.3 \times 10^{17} \times 6 \times 10^{-34} (300/225)^2 + 2 \times 10^{-3})^{-1} = 0.43 \text{ seconds! i.e. fast!}$$

Reactions 4.2 and 4.3 only interconvert the “odd oxygen” species O and O₃ — i.e. they conserve odd oxygen ($[O_x] = [O] + [O_3]$). In defining O_x we've invoked the idea of a chemical family: a collection of compounds connected via fast interconversion reactions, in steady state with each other. Since odd oxygen is only formed by reaction 4.1 and only removed by reaction 4.4:

$$\frac{d[O_x]}{dt} = 2J_2[O_2] - 2k_4[O][O_3]$$

Without invoking the O $\leftrightarrow$ O₃ steady state we'd instead have the more complex system:

$$\frac{d[O]}{dt} = 2J_2[O_2] - k_3[O][O_2][M] + J_3[O_3] - k_4[O][O_3]$$

$$\frac{d[O_3]}{dt} = k_3[O][O_2][M] - J_3[O_3] - k_4[O][O_3]$$

$$\frac{d([O] + [O_3])}{dt} = 2J_2[O_2] - 2k_4[O][O_3]$$

The use of odd oxygen thus leads, as we'll see again later, to both conceptual and mathematical simplification.

The timescale for steady state between reactions 4.1 and 4.4 varies strongly with altitude: ~hours at 40 km, but many years at 20 km. Invoking steady state in the upper stratosphere is a good approximation; in the lower stratosphere it would be poor, since solar intensity, temperature, and atmospheric transport all vary too rapidly to allow steady state to be established.

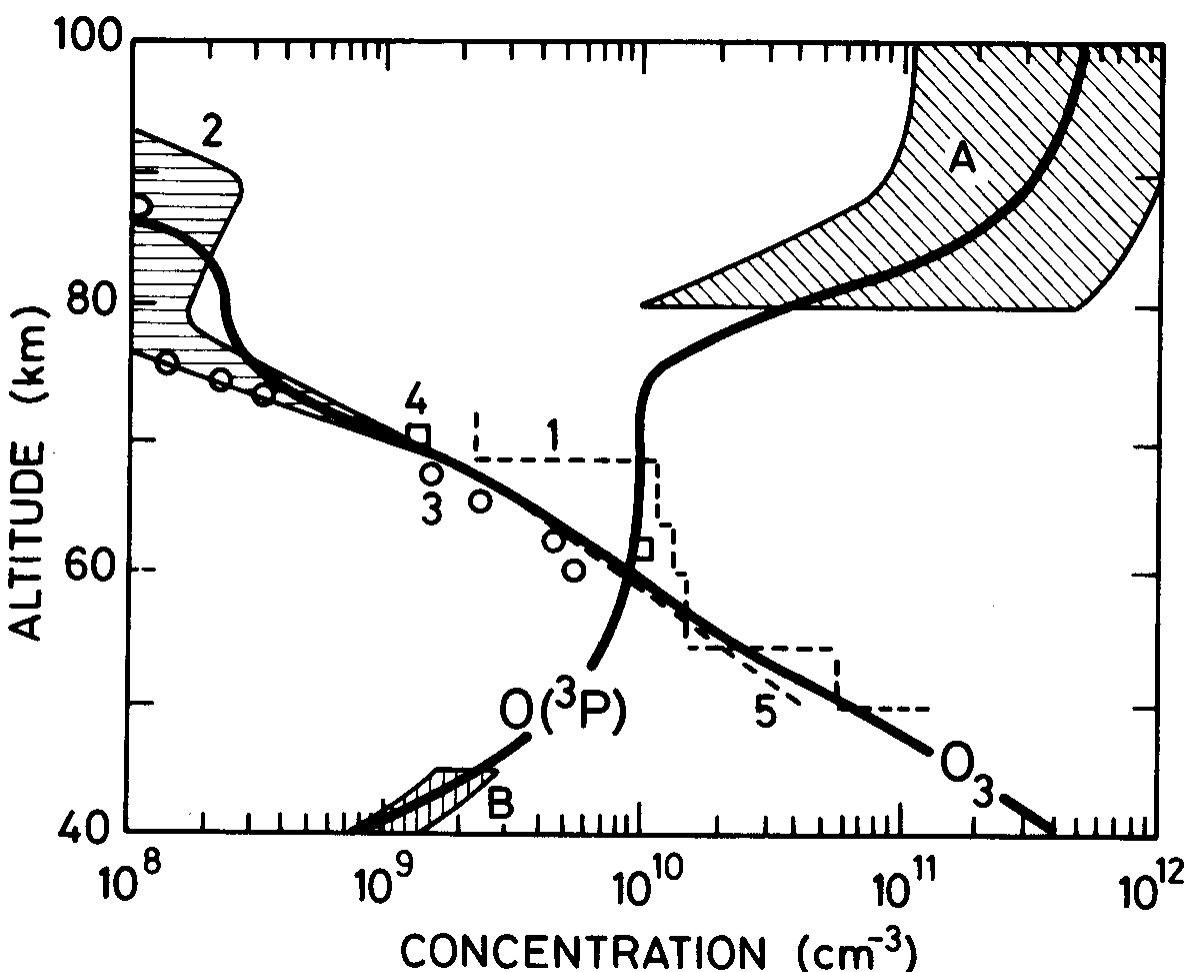


Figure 4.1 — Observed and calculated altitude profiles of $O(^3P)$ and O_3 .

From the steady state between O and O_3 , $[O]$ decreases very rapidly with decreasing altitude (both $[M]$ and $[O_2]$ are proportional to pressure), so reaction cycles involving O become very inefficient at low altitudes (Fig 4.1).

Exercise 6 — Steady-state distribution of ozone

This calculation only works where chemical production and loss rates balance. At steady state:

$$\frac{d[O_x]}{dt} = 2J_2[O_2] - 2k_4[O][O_3] = 0 \Rightarrow [O_3] = \frac{2J_2[O_2]}{2k_4[O]}$$

(Eq 2)

The problem is we don't yet know $[O]$. Using the $O \leftrightarrow O_3$ interconversion (reactions 4.2/4.3):

$$\frac{[O_3]}{[O]} = \frac{k_3[O_2][M]}{J_3}$$

(Eq 3)

Rearranging Eq 3 for $[O]$ and substituting into Eq 2:

$$[O_3]^2 = \frac{2J_2[O_2]k_3[O_2][M]}{2k_4J_3} \Rightarrow [O_3] = \sqrt{\frac{J_2[O_2]k_3[O_2][M]}{k_4J_3}}$$

(Eq 5)

Now $[O_3]$ can be calculated purely from rate constants and altitude (via $[O_2]$ and $[M]$).

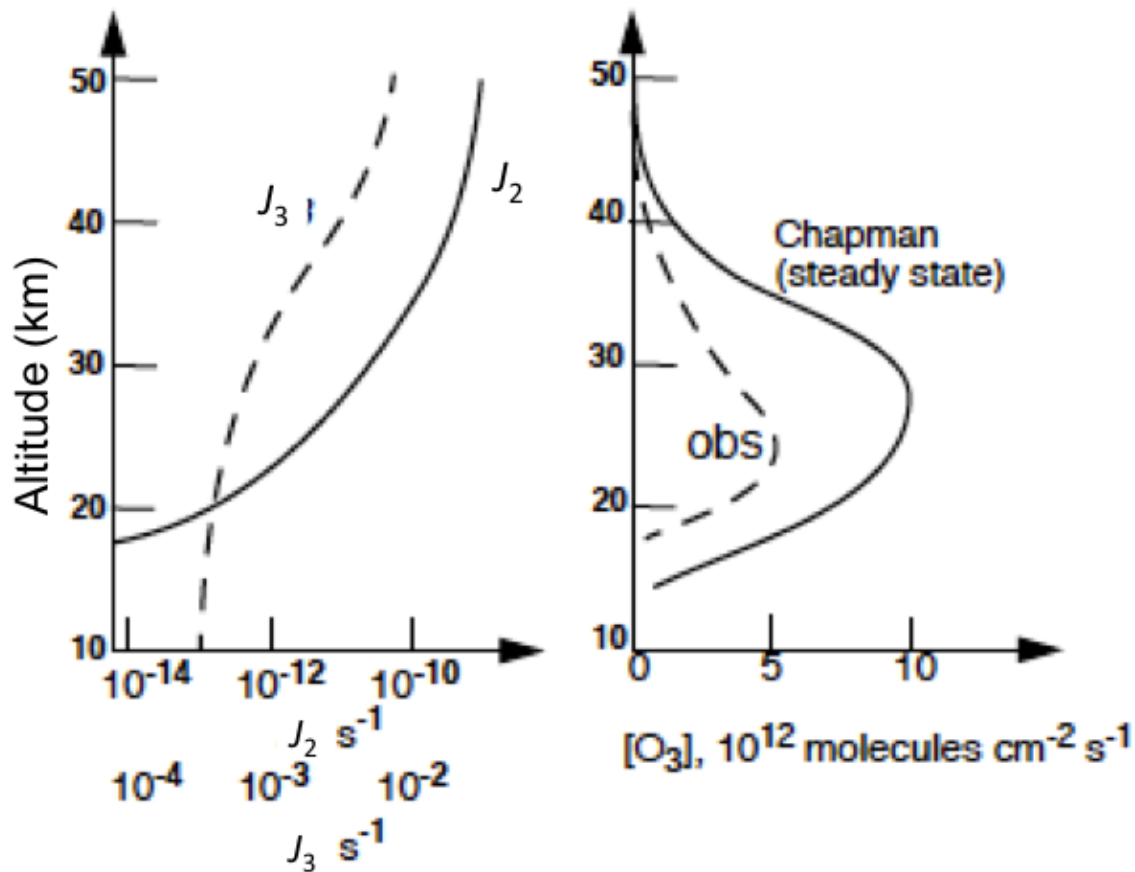


Figure 4.2 — Measured and calculated (Chapman mechanism) distributions of O_3 mixing ratios vs. altitude.

For many years it was thought that Chapman's model could adequately explain the distribution of stratospheric ozone. However, with improved laboratory and atmospheric measurements, it became apparent that reaction 4.4 only removes about 25% of the odd oxygen produced by oxygen photolysis. Calculations based on just the Chapman reactions seriously overestimate stratospheric ozone concentrations (Fig 4.2).

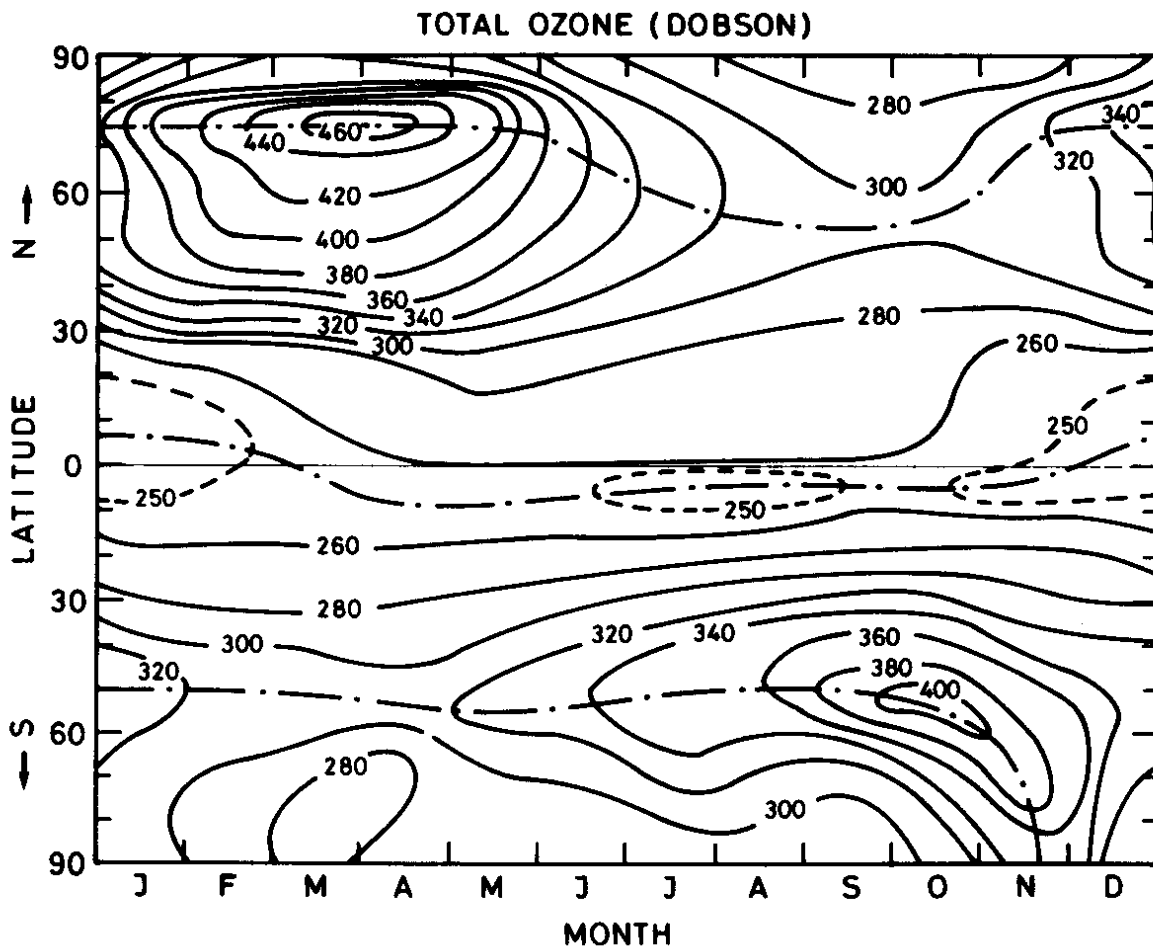
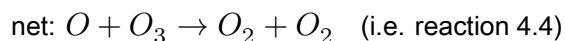
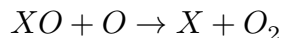
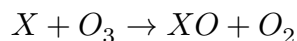


Figure 4.3 — Variation of total ozone as a function of latitude and season, showing highest values at high latitudes just after the polar night. Photochemical theory alone would predict highest ozone over the tropics; the observed distribution is strong evidence for the role of large-scale transport (the winds) in shaping the ozone distribution.

Observations of the total ozone column helped meteorologists and atmospheric physicists show there is a global overturning circulation, known after its discoverers as the Brewer–Dobson Circulation (BDC), which takes air from the tropics and redistributes it poleward.

4.2 Catalytic cycles

Reaction 4.4 has an unexpectedly high activation energy ($E_a \sim 17.5 \text{ kJ mol}^{-1}$) for such an exothermic reaction ($\Delta H \sim -390 \text{ kJ mol}^{-1}$). It was realised that, at stratospheric temperatures (200–290 K), odd oxygen could be removed efficiently by catalytic cycles which achieve the same net result as reaction 4.4, without net loss of the catalytic species X or XO:

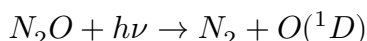


The rate-determining step is usually the reaction involving O. For efficiency we assume each step must be exothermic, which constrains the X–O bond energy to lie in the range $107 < D(X-O) < 498 \text{ kJ mol}^{-1}$. Suitable candidates for X present in the stratosphere include H, OH, NO, Cl and Br.

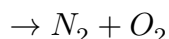
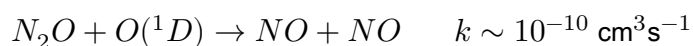
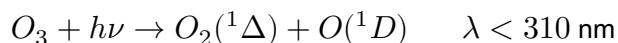
4.3 The oxides of nitrogen, NO_x

4.3.1 Sources

NO and NO₂ (NO+NO₂ = NO_x) are present in the stratosphere at ~10 ppb (compare ~10 ppm of O₃). The main source of NO_x in the stratosphere is nitrous oxide (N₂O), produced at the Earth's surface by denitrifying bacteria. N₂O is well mixed in the troposphere (~335 ppb), has a very long tropospheric lifetime, and is transported to the stratosphere where its main fate is photolysis ($\lambda < \sim 220 \text{ nm}$):



About 1% is instead converted to NO via reaction with electronically excited oxygen atoms:



N₂O mixing ratios are increasing at ~0.8 ppb per year. Nitrogen oxides are also emitted directly into the stratosphere by high-flying aircraft.

Key point: Emissions of NO_x into the troposphere from power stations, motor vehicles, etc. are very large and important for the troposphere, but little of this reaches the stratosphere, since conversion to HNO₃ and rainout is rapid.

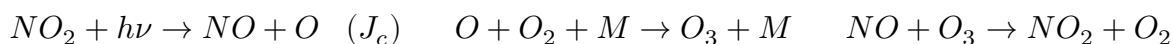
The stratospheric residence time is sufficiently long that NO_x from aviation is calculated to cause a significant reduction of stratospheric ozone, especially from a hypothetical fleet of advanced supersonic aircraft projected to fly even higher in the stratosphere.

4.3.2 Catalytic cycle

With X = NO:



This cycle is responsible for about 50% of odd oxygen removal from the stratosphere, despite competing reactions — the most important being NO₂ photolysis, which is very rapid even at low altitudes (Module 3). NO₂ photolysis produces a null cycle in which odd oxygen is conserved:



Steady state between NO and NO₂ is rapidly established (~100 s). Taking the rate of change of NO:

$$\frac{d[NO]}{dt} = -k_a[NO][O_3] + k_b[NO_2][O] + J_c[NO_2] = 0$$

$$\Rightarrow [NO] = \frac{k_b[NO_2][O] + J_c[NO_2]}{k_a[O_3]}$$

(I)

The rate of odd oxygen destruction by NOx:

$$\frac{d[O_x]}{dt} = -k_a[NO][O_3] - k_b[NO_2][O] + J_c[NO_2]$$

(II)

Substituting [NO] from (I) into (II):

$$\left. \frac{d[O_x]}{dt} \right|_{NO_x} = -2k_b[NO_2][O]$$

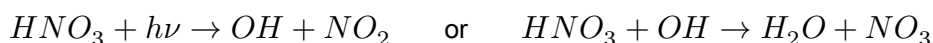
4.3.3 Reservoirs and sinks

A more comprehensive picture of stratospheric NOy chemistry (NOy = sum of all nitrogen oxides excluding N₂O) also involves NO₃, N₂O₅, HNO₄, HNO₃ (and ClONO₂ — §4.5). N₂O₅, HNO₃ and ClONO₂ are important reservoirs for NOx (and HOx, ClOx) — states where otherwise-reactive O₃-destroying radicals are held in less reactive form. For example, HNO₃ is formed by:



(4.5)

and destroyed by



(4.6)

At higher latitudes HNO₃ can become the major nitrogen oxide species. HNO₃ is transported from the stratosphere into the troposphere, where it is efficiently rained out — the major sink of stratospheric nitrogen oxides.

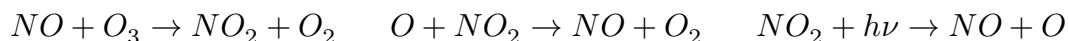
Reactions 4.5 and 4.6 are both favoured by low temperatures. For the termolecular reaction 4.5, this is obvious; the temperature (and pressure!) dependence for HNO₃ + OH (4.6) is more surprising — it clearly doesn't proceed by simple H-abstraction, but instead via a short-lived intermediate. Both reactions are very important in the very low stratosphere.

Climate change predictions indicate the troposphere will warm ('global warming') while the stratosphere cools. A cooler lower stratosphere would favour formation of the reservoir species (reaction 4.5) and water vapour from HOx (reaction 4.6). The resulting reduction in HOx radicals is predicted to lead to an increase in lower-stratospheric ozone later this century (with consequences also for the troposphere, since the stratosphere is a source of ozone to it).

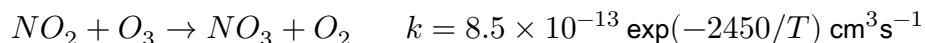
4.3.4 Diurnal variation of the nitrogen oxides

Balloon-borne tunable diode laser spectroscopy (TDLS) measurements have confirmed the basic chemistry above, including the night-time decay of NO_2 .

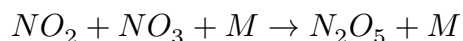
During sunlight hours, NO and NO_2 are in rapid equilibrium via:



At sunset, photolysis ceases and $[\text{O}]$ decreases rapidly, so $[\text{NO}_2]$ rises rapidly. Thereafter $[\text{NO}_2]$ falls via:



During the day NO_3 is photolysed very rapidly ($\sim$ seconds), but at night it's removed by the fast termolecular reaction:



The slope of the night-time NO_2 decay (Fig 4.5) is thus set by $[\text{O}_3]$ and temperature (since at high temperatures $\text{N}_2\text{O}_5 \rightarrow \text{NO}_2 + \text{NO}_3$).

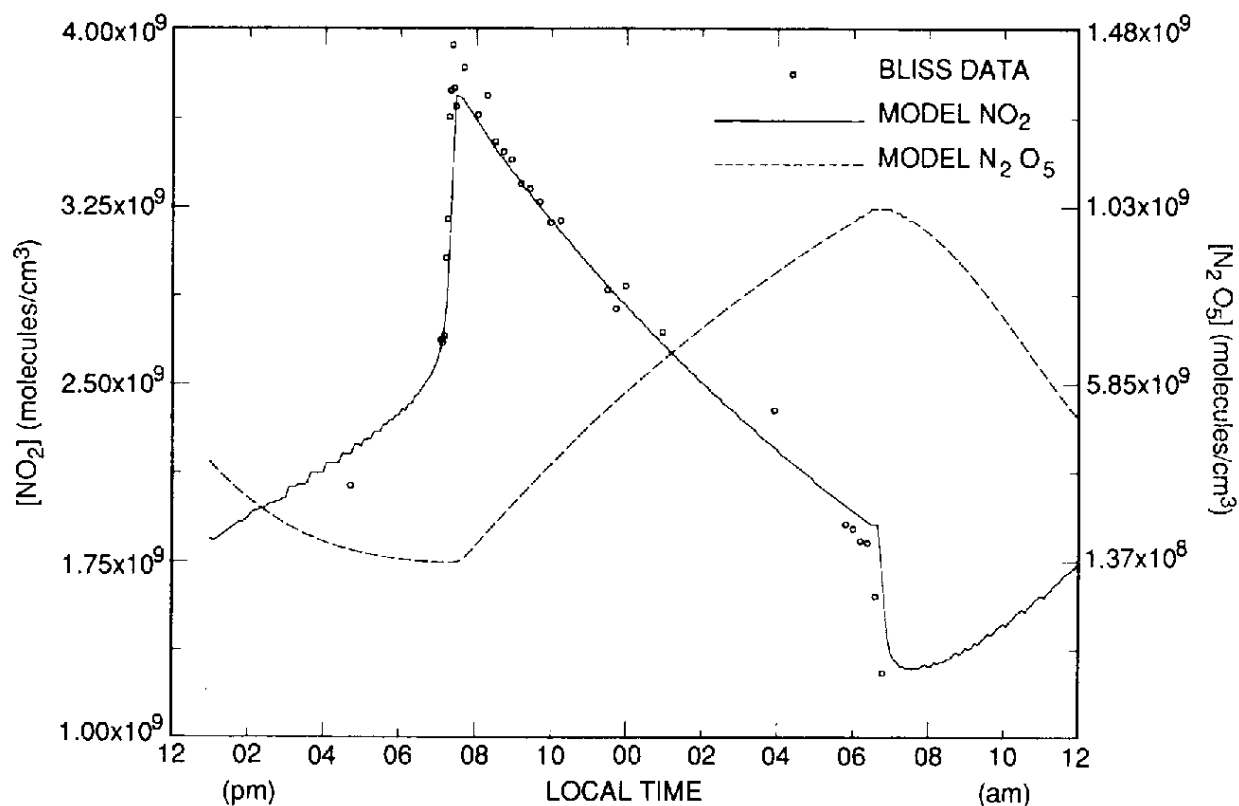


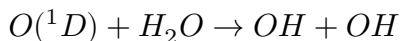
Figure 4.5 — Measured and modelled diurnal variation of NO_2 .

Fig 4.5 shows $[\text{NO}_2]$ falling at dawn with the onset of photolysis; the daytime increase in $[\text{NO}_2]$ reflects the slow ($\sim$ hours) photolysis of N_2O_5 . Global measurements of NO_2 , N_2O and HNO_3 have also been obtained from satellite instruments working in the infrared.

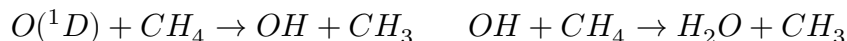
4.4 The oxides of hydrogen, HOx

4.4.1 Sources

The hydroxyl radical is one of the most important atmospheric species, in both the troposphere and the middle atmosphere. As in the troposphere, the main middle-atmosphere source of OH is:



Because air enters the stratosphere at the cold equatorial tropopause, the stratosphere is extremely dry (H_2O mixing ratios 2–6 ppm). CH_4 is also transported to the stratosphere, where it is destroyed by reaction with OH and $O(^1D)$:

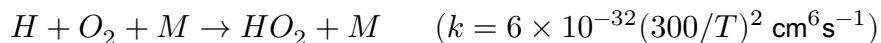


— followed by oxidation of CH_3 to H_2O and hydrogen radicals. In the upper stratosphere CH_4 mixing ratios are low and hydrogen is present mainly as H_2O , with the relationship $\Delta H_2O \sim 2\Delta CH_4$ holding. CH_4 is thus an additional source of H_2O and hence HOx, as well as playing other roles.

Major CH_4 sources are anaerobic fermentation in wetlands and paddy fields, ruminants, termites and biomass burning. Atmospheric CH_4 has been increasing ($\sim 1\% \text{ yr}^{-1}$, followed by a period of little change during the 2000s, then a significant increase in recent years — poorly understood), leading to the expectation that stratospheric HOx concentrations will increase.

4.4.2 Catalytic cycles

H, OH and HO_2 (collectively HOx) are closely coupled on a timescale of seconds by interconversion reactions. The three-body reaction



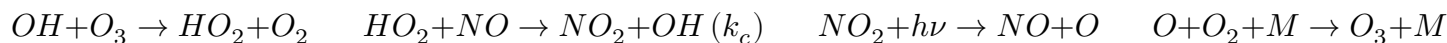
is 100 times faster than $O + O_2 + M$ (4.2), keeping the $HO_2:H$ ratio very high in the stratosphere. At lower pressures in the upper stratosphere/mesosphere, H atom concentrations can rise, enabling:



More important in the stratosphere itself:



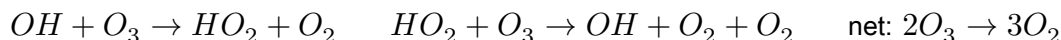
with, as for NOx, a null cycle:



The steady state between OH and HO_2 is rapidly established. By the same procedure as §4.3.2:

$$\left. \frac{d[O_x]}{dt} \right|_{HO_x} = -2k_b[HO_2][O]$$

In the lower stratosphere, as [O] falls, this cycle becomes inefficient and an alternative cycle not involving O becomes important:



4.4.3 Reservoirs and sinks

Hydrogen radicals are removed from the stratosphere by reformation of H₂O and reactions producing the temporary reservoirs HNO₃ and H₂O₂:



4.5 The oxides of chlorine, ClO_x

4.5.1 Sources

The major natural source of chlorine to the stratosphere is CH₃Cl (~0.6 ppb). Stratospheric chlorine is currently over 3 ppb, with the increase due largely to manmade CF₂Cl₂ and CFCl₃, used as aerosol propellants, refrigerants and foam-blowing agents since the 1960s. Chemically inert in the troposphere, these CFCs are transported effectively to the stratosphere, where they are broken down by photolysis and reaction with O(¹D), releasing chlorine atoms. The troposphere acts as a reservoir for these species, giving them lifetimes of 50–100 years (the long atmospheric lifetime reflects the time needed to cycle up to the very low pressures where local loss is more rapid). Other species contribute to the total chlorine budget (e.g. CCl₄, CH₃CCl₃).

As a consequence of the large stratospheric O₃ losses observed in polar regions, driven by Cl-compounds (see Part III), the use and release of all these compounds is now regulated by the Montreal Protocol.

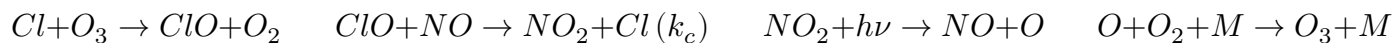
Because of their long lifetimes, these species will continue to play an important, if diminishing, role in ozone chemistry for at least the next 100 years. A group of substitute compounds, the HCFCs, are also regulated — being shorter-lived (they have a C–H bond, so react with OH in the troposphere), meaning the chlorine they carry is less likely to reach the stratosphere. However, many are potent greenhouse gases, as are some of the chlorine- and bromine-free replacements, the HFCs. Because of the long CFC lifetimes, there is little scope for more rapid reduction in total stratospheric chlorine.

4.5.2 Catalytic cycle

With X = Cl:



with, again, a null cycle:



By the same steady-state procedure as before:

$$\left. \frac{d[O_x]}{dt} \right|_{ClO_x} = -2k_b[ClO][O]$$

4.5.3 Reservoirs and sinks

Two important reservoirs for ClOx are HCl and ClONO₂, formed by:



and removed by:



Note the contrast with NOx: whereas OH forms the NOx reservoir HNO₃, here OH acts to release Cl from the reservoir HCl.

4.6 Other halogens

4.6.1 Sources

Catalytic destruction cycles could in principle also involve F, Br and I. The F cycle is unimportant because of the high stability of the HF bond (565 kJ mol⁻¹), and there are probably insufficient I-containing species for I to be a significant O₃ destroyer.

Atmospheric bromine levels are very low (~20 ppt), with the major natural source CH₃Br, and major man-made sources CH₃Br (soil fumigation), CF₃Br, CF₂BrCl and C₂F₄Br₂ (fire retardants) — but Br can nonetheless be important.

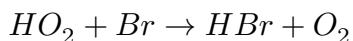
4.6.2 Catalytic cycle

As with chlorine:



4.6.3 Reservoirs and sinks

Bromine differs from chlorine in that Br + CH₄ → HBr + CH₃ is 74 kJ mol⁻¹ endothermic, making the slower reaction with HO₂ the main source of HBr instead:



Analogously to chlorine, BrONO₂ is formed and destroyed via:



However, BrONO₂ photolysis occurs at longer wavelengths than for ClONO₂, with a larger σ , making it ~20 times faster than for chlorine. The net effect: active BrO, rather than reservoirs, are favoured for BrOx — increasing its O₃ destruction efficiency per atom relative to chlorine.

4.7 Relative importance of the Ox, NOx, HOx, ClOx and BrOx cycles

The relative importance of the different catalytic destruction cycles is set by: the reaction rates of the different cycles; the stratospheric lifetimes of the various source gases (a longer lifetime implies release of the catalysts at a higher altitude, and further poleward); and the partitioning between reactive and reservoir species. The different chemical cycles contribute to odd oxygen loss in different proportions as a function of altitude — HOx and NOx cycles tend to dominate in different altitude bands, with ClOx/BrOx becoming disproportionately important in the polar lower stratosphere where heterogeneous chemistry (Part III) activates them from their reservoirs.

Try it yourself

Open [notebooks/04-chapman-mechanism.ipynb](#) to:

- Solve Exercise 5 ($O \leftrightarrow O_3$ interconversion timescale) as a function of altitude, and confirm it becomes “fast” only in the upper stratosphere.
 - Implement Exercise 6’s steady-state Chapman $[O_3]$ formula (Eq 5) and reproduce the qualitative shape of Fig 4.2 — including the ~overestimate relative to the real atmosphere once you compare against a fixed “observed” profile.
 - Build a generic catalytic-cycle odd-oxygen-loss calculator, $d[O_x]/dt|_X = -2k_b[XO][O]$, and compare the relative importance of NOx-, HOx- and ClOx-driven loss for representative concentrations at a chosen altitude.
 - Explore how reservoir partitioning (e.g. the $HNO_3 \rightleftharpoons NO_x$ or $HCl \rightleftharpoons ClO_x$ balance) changes the effective catalytic efficiency of a family, even when the intrinsic k_a , k_b are fixed.
-

Next: [Module 5 — Model Predictions of Changes in Global \$O_3\$](#)

Model Predictions of Changes in Global O₃

Module 5 · Model Predictions of Changes in Global O₃

Learning aims By the end of this module you should be able to: 1. Write down the multi-family odd-oxygen budget equation combining Ox, NOx, HOx, ClOx and BrOx loss terms. 2. Explain why gas-phase catalytic cycles predict ozone loss concentrated in the upper stratosphere. 3. Explain why a large local percentage change in ozone does not necessarily translate into a large column change, and why this means gas-phase chemistry alone cannot explain the Antarctic ozone hole.

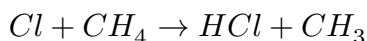
On the basis of the previous discussion, the rate of change of ozone (odd oxygen) can be written as:

$$\frac{d([O] + [O_3])}{dt} = 2J_a[O_2] - 2k_a[O][O_3] - 2k_b[O][NO_2] - 2k_c[O][HO_2] - 2k_d[O][ClO] - 2k_e[O][BrO] - \text{etc.}$$

It was realised in the 1970s that an increase in the concentration of the radical catalysts (e.g. NOx emitted directly into the stratosphere by aircraft; ClOx following degradation of CFCs; HOx either directly from aviation or through a changing climate) would change the balance in this equation, leading to lower ozone. Fig 4.11 (Module 4) showed a simplified version of the relative importance of the various catalytic Ox destruction cycles as a function of altitude.

In the case of the CFCs, peak depletion was predicted at about 40 km — the altitude at which ClO was predicted to peak. Chlorine-driven loss was predicted to be small in the low stratosphere, where [O] is low and ClOx was thought to be mostly locked up in the reservoirs ClONO₂ and HCl. Model calculations of the change in O₃ for a change in ClOx from around 1 ppb to 3 ppb (somewhat below present-day values) show reductions of greater than 20% at ~40 km at high latitudes.

Why the high-latitude enhancement? As CH₄ mixing ratios fall toward high latitudes (because the source of methane is the tropical troposphere), the reaction converting ClOx to HCl slows:

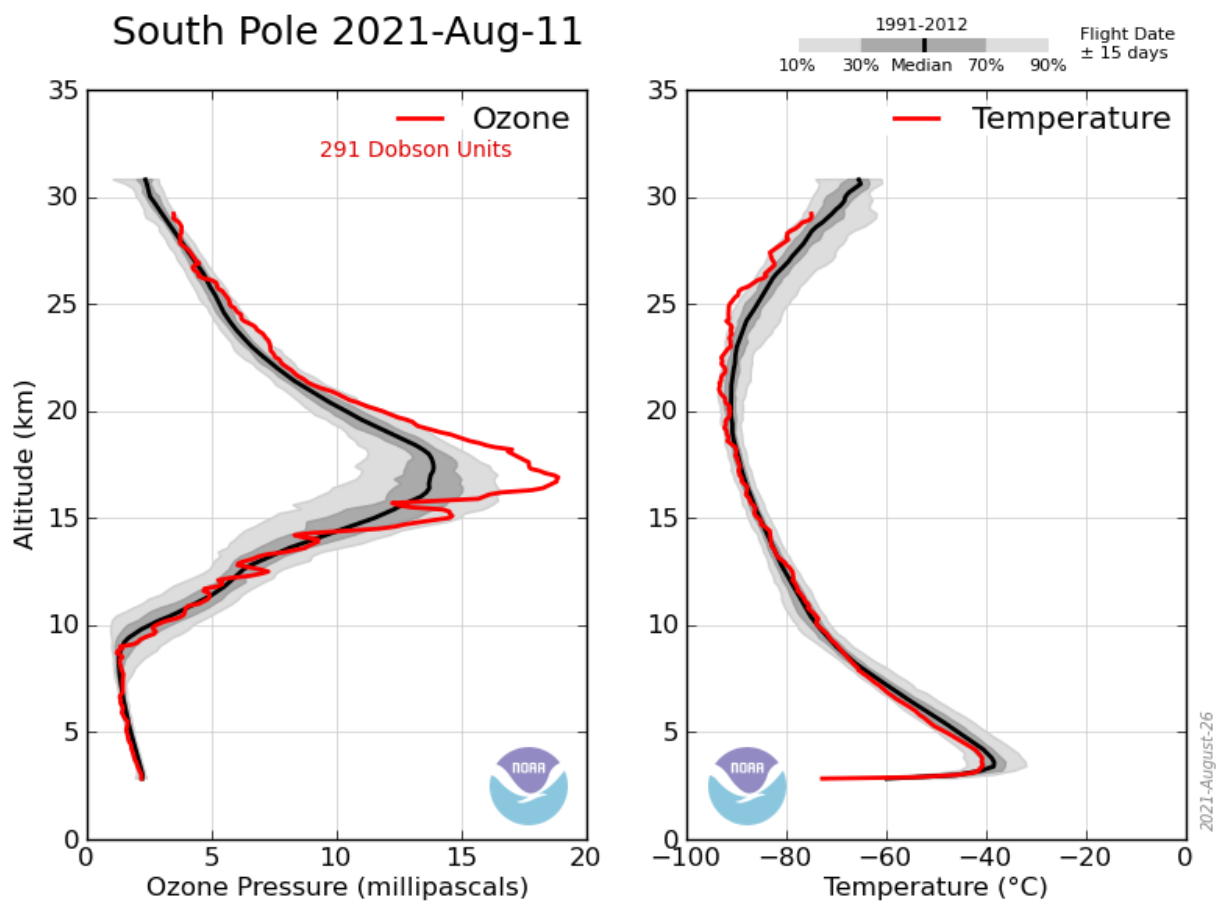


allowing more ClOx to remain in active form — leading to greater O₃ loss.

Ozone depletion has indeed been detected in the upper stratosphere in line with this picture. But do these calculations also explain the observed loss of ozone in Antarctica, first reported in 1985, where the total ozone column falls from >300 DU to ~100 DU in a six-week period each springtime?

The answer is 'No!' Despite the large percentage change in local O₃ calculated above, the change in the total column O₃ from upper-stratospheric loss alone is small.

South Pole 2021-Aug-11



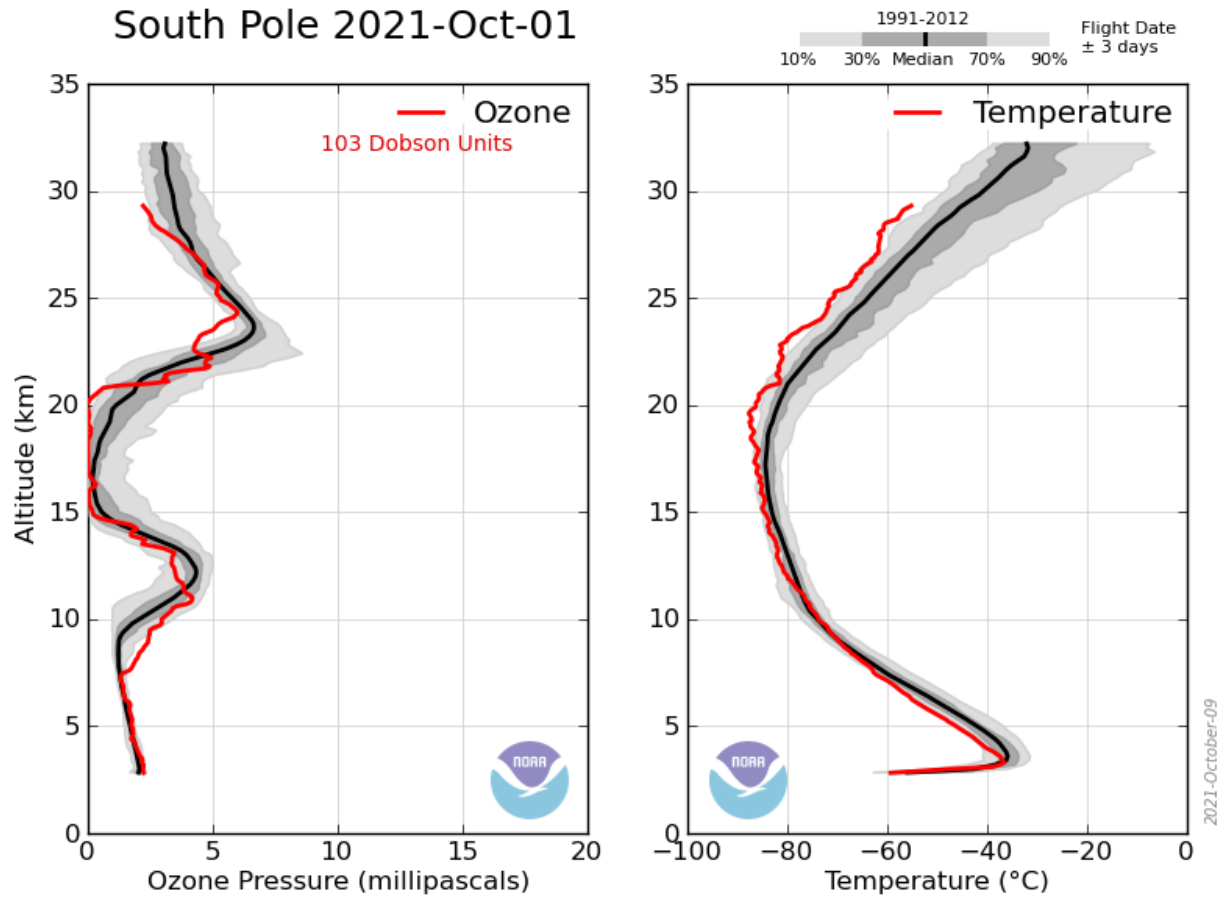


Figure 5.2 — Observed (ozone-sonde) vertical profiles of temperature and ozone. Note the difference between the two panels after 6 weeks — the springtime Antarctic ozone hole is a lower-stratospheric phenomenon, not the upper-stratospheric signature predicted by gas-phase catalytic cycles alone.

So the large observed change in the Antarctic is not explained by the upper-stratospheric losses calculated from gas-phase catalytic cycles. Our theory of catalytic cycles is correct — it explains ozone behaviour away from polar regions (e.g. the observed loss in the upper stratosphere) — but it is incomplete. Explaining the Antarctic ozone hole requires additional chemistry (heterogeneous reactions on polar stratospheric cloud surfaces, which activate ClOx from its reservoirs far more efficiently at low temperatures) — the subject of further courses.

One of the key questions current research aims to answer is how changes in stratospheric ozone are affected by, and will in turn affect, climate change.

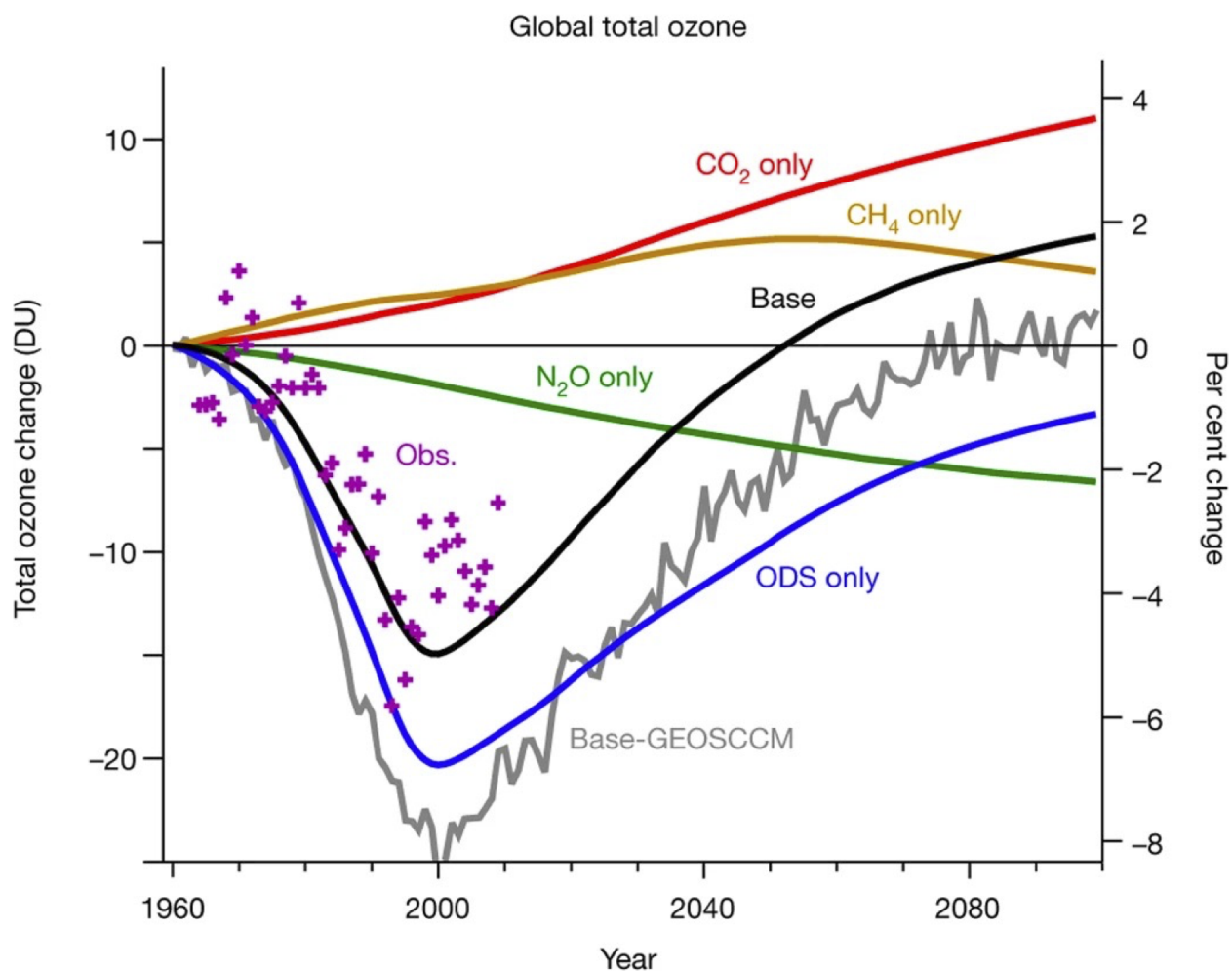


Figure 5.3 — Observed and modelled ozone from Chemistry Climate Modelling Initiative models. The observations show good skill of the models and the future scenarios highlight how different emissions/climate pathways will impact ozone

Try it yourself

Open [notebooks/05-ozone-loss-antarctic.ipynb](#) to:

- Build the multi-family odd-oxygen budget equation from this module as a simple weighted-sum model, and explore how sensitive total loss is to each catalytic term.
- Reproduce, schematically, why a large local percentage change at 40 km barely moves the total column — by integrating a percentage perturbation applied only above some altitude against a realistic ozone profile, versus the same perturbation applied throughout the whole column.
- Compare that column-integral behaviour to what a lower-stratospheric perturbation (like the real ozone hole) would do to the total column, to see why the altitude at which loss occurs matters so much.

This concludes the Michaelmas term (Lectures 1–6). Next: [Module 6 — Atmospheric Composition: Sources, Sinks and Lifetimes](#), opening the Lent term (Lectures 7–12).

Lent Term

Atmospheric Composition: Sources, Sinks and Lifetimes

Module 6 · Atmospheric Composition: Sources, Sinks and Lifetimes

Learning objectives By the end of this module you should be able to: 1. Outline the basic processes controlling trace gas and particle concentrations in the troposphere. 2. List the main natural and anthropogenic sources of tropospheric trace gases. 3. Describe the physical and chemical processes that remove trace constituents from the atmosphere. 4. Explain acid deposition and its effects on ecosystems. 5. Define and calculate the lifetime of an atmospheric trace gas.

1.1 Introduction

Chemistry in the Atmosphere is a two-part story. The first part of this course covered the stratosphere; this module opens the second part, which deals with the troposphere — the lowest part of the atmosphere, extending from the surface up to roughly 8–18 km depending on latitude.

Two regions matter here:

- Planetary boundary layer (PBL) — the lowest ~1 km, into which almost all surface emissions are injected. Under still (anticyclonic) conditions, pollutants can build up in the PBL, producing air pollution episodes.
- Free troposphere — the region above the PBL, extending to the tropopause. Mixing within the troposphere is relatively fast, but the tropopause is a fairly effective barrier to exchange with the stratosphere.

The troposphere is also where weather happens (clouds, precipitation), and radiative processes here dominate surface climate.

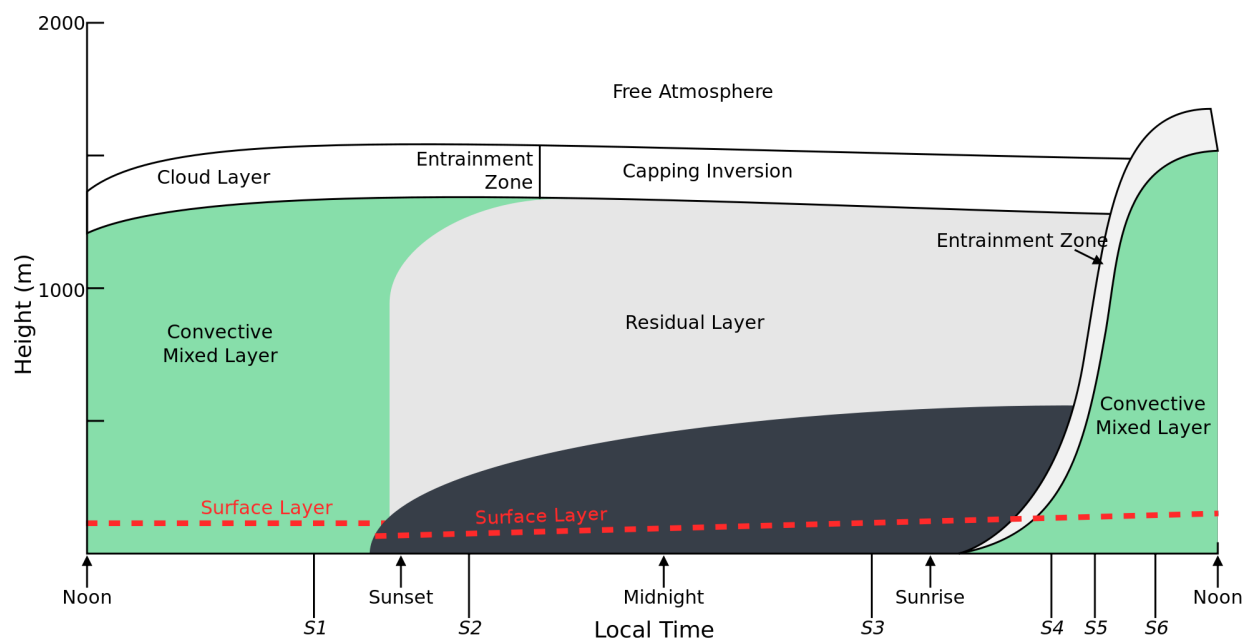


Figure 1.0 — Schematic of the diurnal variation in the planetary boundary layer (after Stull et al., 1990).

Historically, interest in tropospheric chemistry has been driven by air pollution — the effects of trace gases and particles on human health and ecosystems. Two classic pollution regimes are distinguished:

	Winter Smog	Photochemical (Summer) Smog
First recognised	Late 18th century	Mid-1940s, Los Angeles basin
Conditions	Winter, often foggy	High temperature, strong sunlight
Cause	Local pollutant accumulation (topography, temperature inversions)	High NO and organic emissions
Key emissions	High SO ₂ and soot (coal burning)	Organics + NO _x + sunlight → O ₃ + other products (Haagen-Smit, 1952)
Ozone formed?	No	Yes

This module — and the rest of the course — develops a quantitative understanding of the chemistry behind photochemical smog, so that we can predict how to minimise human exposure to harmful pollutants.

1.2 Atmospheric Composition

The composition of the atmosphere at any point in time reflects a balance between sources and sinks:

- Sources — primary emissions from atmospheric, land, or ocean processes; natural or anthropogenic.
- Sinks — removal by chemical or physical processes, operating on a wide range of timescales.

Because sources and sinks are spatially non-uniform, the resulting balance is complex, coupling chemistry with atmospheric transport. Quantifying this coupled system is a central aim of atmospheric chemistry.

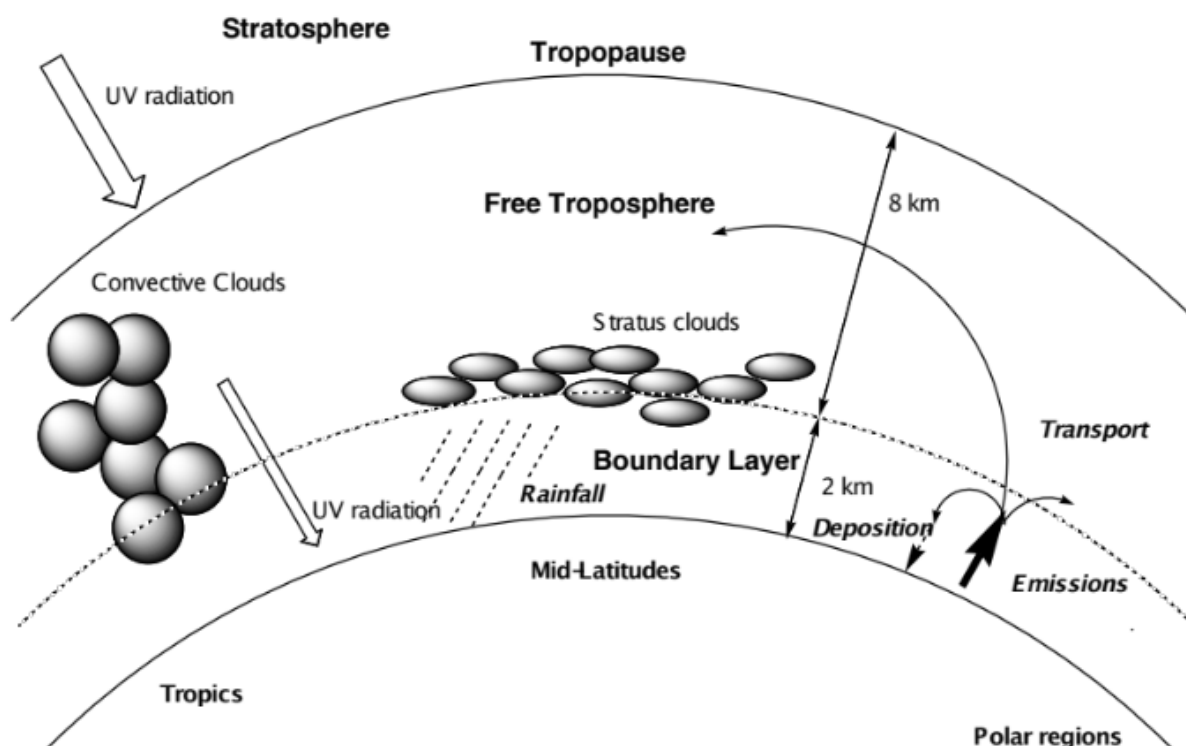


Figure 1.1 — Key features and processes in the troposphere.

About 90% of the total atmospheric mass resides in the troposphere, and most trace-gas emission (and a good deal of trace-gas formation) happens here. Chemically, the troposphere performs two important jobs:

1. Destruction — preventing surface-emitted gases from accumulating to toxic levels or reaching the stratosphere and damaging the ozone layer.
2. Transport and transformation — acting as the conduit for natural biogeochemical cycles.

Troposphere vs. stratosphere

Property	Stratosphere	Troposphere
Temperature	200–250 K	~288 K (“room temperature”)
Pressure	1–100 mbar	≥1000 mbar
UV reaching this altitude	< 200 nm	> 290 nm
Mixing time	Months–years	Seconds–days
Dynamics	Large-scale	Turbulent to large-scale
Number of compounds	Limited	> 10 ⁶
Dominant chemistry	Mostly inorganic (HO $\cdot$, NO $\cdot$, ...)	Inorganic and organic, roughly equal importance
Water abundance	Low	High — clouds, precipitation

1.3 Sources of the Minor Constituents

Most trace gases in the troposphere originate as surface emissions.

Compound	Main sources	Emission rate (Tg yr ⁻¹)
CH ₄	Wetlands; natural gas leakage; combustion	400–500
CO	Atmospheric VOC oxidation; combustion	800
Isoprene	Natural vegetation	500
VOC*	Solvents; combustion; fermentation; vegetation	>>100
NO	Soil microorganisms; lightning; combustion	40
N ₂ O	Soil/marine microorganisms; industry; combustion	4.4–10.5
NH ₃	Animal waste breakdown; soil microorganisms	82
SO ₂	DMS** oxidation; volcanoes; combustion; smelting	110
DMS	Marine microorganisms	40
CH ₃ Cl	Marine/terrestrial microorganisms	1.5
CH ₃ Br	Marine microorganisms; agriculture	0.1
CFCs/HCFCs	Solvents and refrigerants	1.1

* VOC = volatile organic compounds (hydrocarbons, halocarbons, oxygenated organics). ** DMS = dimethyl sulphide.

Natural emissions are mostly biogenic, though volcanism contributes significantly to atmospheric sulphur. Anthropogenic emissions arise from energy production, industry, and agriculture.

Chemical transformation of these primary emissions generates secondary products that can themselves be important — notably H₂SO₄, HNO₃, HCl, and a wide range of organic products from the oxidation of S-, N-, Cl-containing, or organic trace gases. Ozone (O₃), formed photochemically in the troposphere, is a particularly important example — central to tropospheric chemistry as well as the stratosphere.

1.4 Sinks of the Minor Constituents

Removal processes fall into two broad classes:

Sink process	Species removed
Physical — dry deposition to water/land	SO ₂ , O ₃ , HNO ₃ , CO ₂ , H ₂ O ₂ , aerosol particles
Physical — wet deposition in precipitation	HCl, H ₂ SO ₄ , NH ₃ , SO ₂ , HNO ₃ , H ₂ O ₂ , aerosol particles
Chemical — oxidation by OH	VOCs, CO, SO ₂ , NO ₂ , H ₂ O ₂ , H ₂ S, DMS
Chemical — direct photolysis	O ₃ , HCHO, CH ₃ I, H ₂ O ₂ , NO ₂ , NO ₃
Chemical — cloud/aerosol reactions	H ₂ SO ₄ , NH ₃ , SO ₂ , HNO ₃ , VOCs

These sink strengths vary considerably with time of day, season, and geography.

1.4.1 Dry deposition

Removal at the Earth's surface (water, soil, vegetation) in the absence of precipitation. Governed by transport through the boundary layer and by uptake at the surface. The flux to the surface, F (molecules cm⁻² s⁻¹), relates to the near-surface concentration c (molecules cm⁻³) via the deposition velocity v_g (cm s⁻¹):

$$F = v_g \cdot c$$

(1.1)

The lifetime of a species with respect to dry deposition depends on v_g and the mixing height h :

$$\tau = \frac{h}{v_g}$$

(1.2)

Worked comparison:

- SO_2 : $v_g \approx 0.8 \text{ cm s}^{-1}$ over NW Europe, mixed through $h \approx 1 \text{ km} \rightarrow \tau \approx 1.4 \text{ days}$.
- O_3 : similar v_g over land, but well-mixed up to the tropopause ($h \approx 12 \text{ km}$) $\rightarrow \tau \approx 17 \text{ days}$.

The large difference is entirely down to the mixing height — the same deposition velocity gives a very different lifetime depending on how deep an atmospheric column the species is spread through.

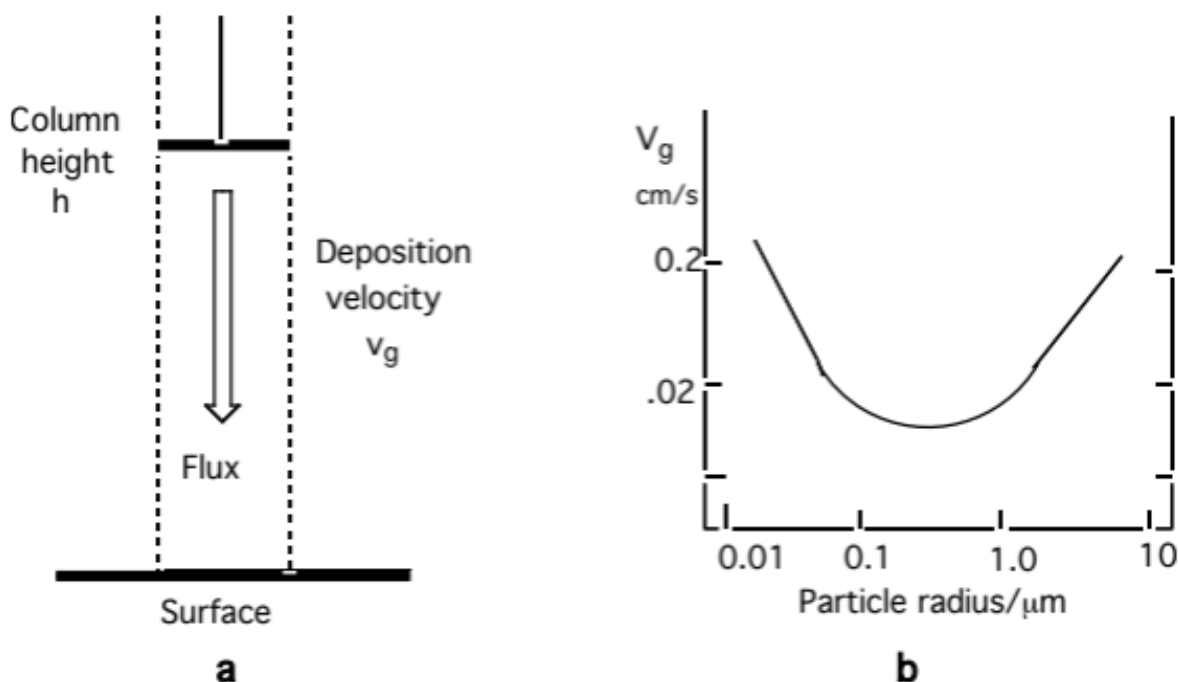


Figure 1.2 — Schematic illustration of surface deposition.

1.4.2 Wet deposition

Removal via precipitation (cloud, rain, snow):

- Rain-out / in-cloud scavenging — gases absorbed into droplets (possibly followed by reaction); particles act as condensation nuclei or are captured by coagulation.
- Wash-out / below-cloud scavenging — uptake into falling precipitation; removal times of order hours for soluble gases in moderate rain.

Most of these processes are reversible (e.g. droplet evaporation can release particles or gases back to the gas phase), and because precipitation is highly variable, quantitative estimates of wet deposition rates are difficult.

As an approximation, the wet deposition rate is taken as first-order in concentration:

$$\text{Rate} = \lambda c$$

where λ , the washout (scavenging) coefficient, scales with mean precipitation and is typically $0.12\text{--}0.5 \text{ day}^{-1}$ (lifetime 2–8 days).

1.4.3 Acid deposition (wet and dry)

Oxidising conditions in the atmosphere (Modules 2–3) generate inorganic acids (H_2SO_4 , HNO_3 , HCl) and organic acids (formic, acetic). These lower the pH of precipitation and are also removed by dry deposition.

“Acid rain” is not a modern discovery — Robert Boyle noted sulphur and acidity in rain in the 17th century — but it was only widely recognised as a fossil-fuel-driven pollution problem in the 1970s.

Ecological effects:

- Sulfate/nitrate deposition leaches nutrient cations (Ca, Mg, K) from foliage and soils, reducing buffering capacity and nutrient availability for trees.
- Mobilises soil aluminium, interfering with root nutrient uptake; combined with O_3 toxicity, this leaves trees more vulnerable to drought, temperature extremes and disease.
- Leached aluminium and low pH are toxic to fish and other aquatic species.
- SO_2/NO_x oxidation products damage buildings and cultural heritage — here dry deposition is usually the dominant pathway.

Regulation has cut SO_2 and NO_x emissions substantially in recent decades (SO_2 more than NO_x), but both remain major anthropogenic air-quality pollutants.

1.5 Lifetimes — putting it together

The atmospheric lifetime (or residence time) τ of a species is the average time a molecule spends in the atmosphere before removal. For a species at steady state with a single first-order loss process of rate constant k_{loss} :

$$\tau = \frac{1}{k_{\text{loss}}}$$

More generally, for a reservoir of total burden N (molecules) with a total removal rate R (molecules s^{-1}):

$$\tau = \frac{N}{R}$$

When several independent loss processes act in parallel (e.g. OH oxidation and dry deposition), the loss rates add, so the lifetimes combine as reciprocals:

$$\frac{1}{\tau_{\text{total}}} = \frac{1}{\tau_1} + \frac{1}{\tau_2} + \dots$$

— the fastest process dominates the overall lifetime.

Key points — Module 1 - Atmospheric composition is set by the balance of sources and sinks. - Sources: mainly surface emission, but some species (notably O_3) are produced photochemically in the atmosphere itself. - Sinks: physical (dry/wet deposition) and chemical (oxidation, photolysis)

removal, with widely varying efficiency and timescale depending on the species. - Lifetime ties source/sink strength to the standing concentration, and is essential for comparing how “long-lived” different pollutants are.

Worked Example 1 — Steady-state concentration of compound X

Problem. Compound X is emitted at the surface at a rate of 1 tonne yr⁻¹ (molar mass 44 g mol⁻¹). It is lost by reaction with OH, with rate constant $k = 1 \times 10^{-11}$ cm³ molecule⁻¹ s⁻¹, and by dry deposition with $v_g = 1$ cm s⁻¹. Assume $[\text{OH}] = 10^6$ cm⁻³ and a boundary-layer mixing height of $h = 1$ km.

Method. 1. Convert the emission rate to a molecular flux (molecules cm⁻² s⁻¹) using the molar mass and an assumed emission area, or work in a well-mixed box of height h to get a volumetric production rate (molecules cm⁻³ s⁻¹). 2. Write the two loss rate constants: chemical, $k_{\text{OH}} = k[\text{OH}]$; physical, $k_{\text{dep}} = v_g/h$. 3. At steady state, production = total loss: $P = (k_{\text{OH}} + k_{\text{dep}})[X]_{ss}$. 4. Solve for $[X]_{ss}$, and use $\tau = 1/(k_{\text{OH}} + k_{\text{dep}})$ to sanity-check against the emission rate.

This is exactly the kind of steady-state / pseudo-first-order problem you'll meet repeatedly through the course — it's worth being fluent doing it both by hand and by setting up the balance numerically. The companion notebook (06-sources-sinks-lifetimes.ipynb) walks through this example step by step, and lets you explore how $[X]_{ss}$ and τ respond to changing k , $[\text{OH}]$, v_g and h .

Try it yourself

Open [notebooks/06-sources-sinks-lifetimes.ipynb](#) to:

- Solve Worked Example 1 numerically and check it against the by-hand answer.
 - Build a simple one-box steady-state / time-dependent model with combined chemical + deposition loss.
 - Explore how lifetime and steady-state concentration change as you vary k_{OH} , $[\text{OH}]$, v_g , and mixing height h .
 - Reproduce the SO₂ vs. O₃ dry-deposition lifetime comparison from §1.4.1.
-

Next: [Module 7 — Tropospheric Photochemistry and the Hydroxyl Radical](#)

Tropospheric Photochemistry and the Hydroxyl Radical

Module 7 · Tropospheric Photochemistry and the Hydroxyl Radical

Aims of this module 1. To describe the basic characteristics of photolysis in the troposphere. 2. To outline the processes that result in a steady-state concentration of OH.

2.1 Introduction

In this module we introduce the basic photochemistry of the troposphere and show how photochemical reactions are the main driver leading to oxidation of trace gases — preventing their accumulation and pollution of the atmosphere.

As discussed in the first part of the lecture course, the rate of photolysis is given by:

$$J_{(i)} = \int_{\lambda=0}^{\infty} \phi_{(i,\lambda)} F_{(\lambda)} \sigma_{(i,\lambda)} d\lambda$$

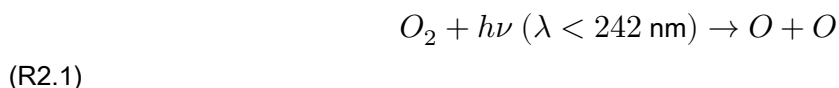
(2.1)

where J is the photolysis frequency (s^{-1}), obtained by integrating the product of the solar flux F , the absorption cross-section σ , and the quantum yield for dissociation ϕ , over all wavelengths λ where the molecule absorbs. Determination of the solar flux in the atmosphere requires either direct measurement, or a calculation including absorption, scattering and reflection of solar radiation entering the atmosphere.

2.2 Tropospheric Photolysis

The altitude dependence of photolysis rates was discussed in previous lectures. In spectral regions where atmospheric absorption by O_2 and O_3 is strong (λ shorter than ~ 290 nm), virtually no solar photons penetrate to the troposphere, while at longer (visible) wavelengths, where absorption is weak, the atmosphere is nearly transparent. The result: the photolysis environment in the troposphere differs dramatically from that of the stratosphere. Only molecules that absorb light in the near-UV/visible can be photo-dissociated in the troposphere — with important implications for tropospheric photochemistry.

One consequence: photolysis of O_2 , which requires photons with wavelength below the threshold for breaking the O–O bond,



cannot occur in the troposphere, so ozone cannot be produced there via the Chapman mechanism.

However, species such as O₃, NO₂, H₂O₂, HCHO (and other organic peroxides and aldehydes), which absorb at longer wavelengths, can be photo-dissociated in the troposphere — with important consequences.

For photolysis to occur there must be spectral overlap with the solar spectrum, and dissociation must occur with non-zero quantum yield — usually meaning the photon energy $h\nu$ must exceed the dissociation energy ε_0 . Some important tropospheric photolysis processes are given in Table 2.1, with representative photolysis coefficients for the lower atmosphere. Ozone photolysis is particularly important and is considered in detail below.

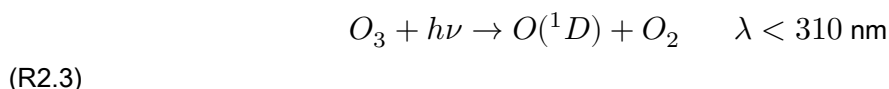
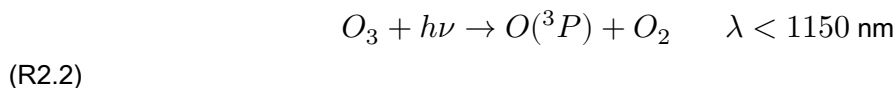
Table 2.1 — Important photolysis rates in the lower atmosphere

Photochemical process	$\varepsilon_0/\text{kJ mol}^{-1}$	$\lambda_{threshold}/\text{nm}$	$J_x (Z=30^\circ)^*/\text{s}^{-1}$
O ₂ → 2 O(³ P)	494	242	0
O ₃ → O(³ P) + O ₂ (³ Σ)	101	1180	4.17 × 10 ⁻⁴
O ₃ → O(¹ D) + O ₂ (¹ Δ)	386	310	2.73 × 10 ⁻⁵
SO ₂ → O(³ P) + SO	552	216	0
NO ₂ → O(³ P) + NO	300	398	1.6 × 10 ⁻²
H ₂ O ₂ → 2 OH	215	557	6.80 × 10 ⁻⁶
HONO → NO + OH	208	572	1.83 × 10 ⁻³
HCHO → H + HCO	364	329	2.77 × 10 ⁻⁵
HCHO → H ₂ + CO	-1.9	—	4.41 × 10 ⁻⁵
CH ₃ CHO → HCO + CH ₃	349	343	3.84 × 10 ⁻⁶
CH ₃ COCHO → HCO + CH ₃ CO	284	421	1.18 × 10 ⁻⁴
CH ₃ OOH → OH + CH ₃ O	188	637	5.02 × 10 ⁻⁶

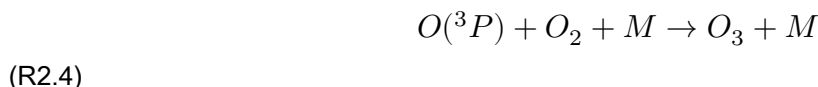
*J values calculated for the Earth's surface, summer N. mid-latitude.

2.3 Photolysis of ozone in the troposphere

Above 240 nm, O₂ photolysis is irrelevant, and in the 240–320 nm range O₃ is the dominant absorber. Absorption by ozone occurs in two spectral regions in the troposphere: the visible (450–600 nm) and the UV (290–330 nm). Photolysis of O₃ occurs by two pathways:



Photolysis at the longer wavelengths (R2.2) occurs in the visible, yielding ground-state O(³P), followed by recombination with O₂ to reform O₃:

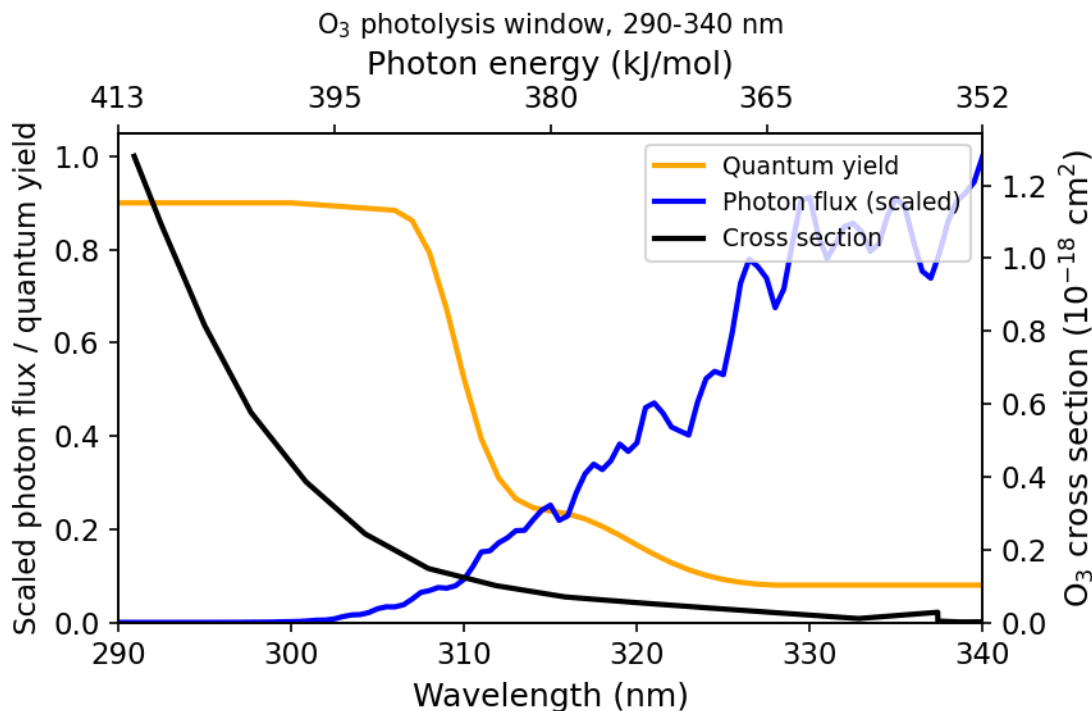


— this process has no net effect on ozone concentration.

Photolysis process R2.3 yields excited oxygen atoms, O(¹D). The flux of photons in the troposphere at wavelengths shorter than 310 nm is rather low, due to attenuation of UV radiation by ozone absorption higher up — this decreases the photolysis rate and O(¹D) production.

At the high pressures found in the troposphere, $O(^1D)$ is rapidly quenched to ground-state $O(^3P)$. If these were the only processes, there would be no net destruction of ozone by tropospheric photolysis, and the troposphere was initially thought to be rather chemically inert — with tropospheric ozone believed to result from direct transport from the stratosphere followed by dry deposition. Subsequent research showed this is incorrect.

The photolysis process R2.3 is in fact central to the chemistry of the troposphere, as it is the primary step in generating OH radicals — which, as we shall see, initiate oxidative chemistry.



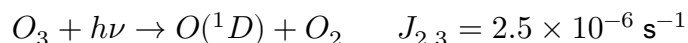
Figure

2.2a — Cross-section, quantum yield for reaction R2.3, and solar photon flux at the Earth's surface.

2.3.1 Fate of $O(^1D)$ in a dry atmosphere

A small amount of highly reactive excited atomic oxygen $O(^1D)$ is produced in the troposphere by photolysis of O_3 at $\lambda \lesssim 310$ nm. The rate of photolysis of ozone to produce $O(^1D)$ is typically written $J_{O(^1D)}$, incorporating the summation over all wavelengths and the wavelength dependence of quantum yield.

$O(^1D)$ is quenched to the ground state by reaction with N_2 or O_2 :

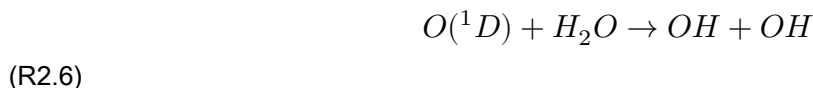


where $M = [N_2] + [O_2] = 2.4 \times 10^{19} \text{ cm}^{-3}$ at the Earth's surface.

Assuming steady state, $[O(^1D)] = \frac{J_{2.3}[O_3]}{k_{2.5}[M]}$.

2.4 Generation of OH radicals

Water vapour is abundant throughout most of the troposphere, its mixing ratio falling from ~1–4% at the surface to ~20 ppmv near the tropopause. H_2O competes effectively with quenching by M for reaction with $\text{O}(^1\text{D})$, giving a branching ratio, f , between quenching and OH formation of about 10%:



Reaction R2.6 is exothermic ($\Delta H^0 = -119 \text{ kJ/mol}$), while the corresponding reaction of H_2O with $\text{O}(^3\text{P})$ does not proceed (it's endothermic). The difference in enthalpy is largely because the electronically excited state of atomic oxygen lies ~190 kJ/mol above the ground state.

R2.6 represents the principal (though not sole) mechanism for generating hydroxyl radicals in the troposphere, initiating further reaction and degradation of VOCs.

The diurnal behaviour of [OH] closely tracks $J_{\text{O}(^1\text{D})}$ over the course of a day, measured in the unpolluted conditions typical of the Southern Hemisphere marine environment — demonstrating the fast conversion of $\text{O}(^1\text{D})$ into OH and the dominance of R2.3/R2.5–R2.6 in OH production. Under sunny conditions, $J_{\text{O}(^1\text{D})}$ reaches a maximum of about $3 \times 10^{-5} \text{ s}^{-1}$.

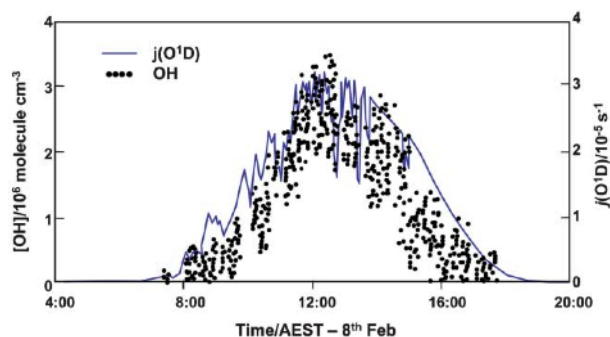
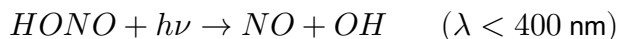


Figure 2.2b — Typical diurnal variation of [OH] and

$J(\text{O}^1\text{D})$ in the clean marine atmosphere.

2.4.1 Other sources of OH in the troposphere

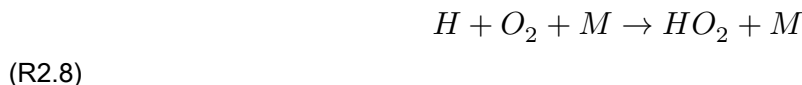
Although O_3 photolysis is the main OH source during the day, other sources matter in the early morning and at night. Photolysis of HONO (which builds up overnight) is an important OH source in the early morning:



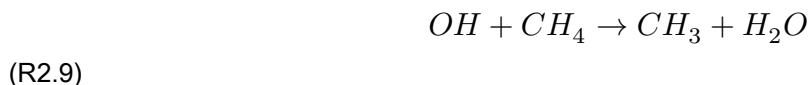
Photolysis of organic compounds such as formaldehyde, and reaction of alkenes with O_3 and NO_3 , also contribute to overall OH production (covered in Module 9).

2.5 The HOx family

OH does not react with the major atmospheric components (N_2 , O_2 , CO_2) but reacts with most trace gases. Following its formation from $O(^1D)$, OH is rapidly converted into HO_2 — primarily (~70% of the time) by reaction with CO, followed by fast reaction of H with O_2 :



About 30% of OH is converted to HO_2 via a more complex chain of reactions initiated by:



(details in Module 9). The lifetime of OH is less than a second — R2.9 sets an upper limit, since methane is widespread and well-mixed in the troposphere.

In relatively unpolluted (low-NOx) regimes, HO_2 reacts slowly with ozone to regenerate OH:



R2.10 is an interconversion reaction between the two HOx forms, letting us meaningfully define the odd-hydrogen family $HO_x = [OH] + [HO_2]$.

Alternatively, HO_2 can recombine to form hydrogen peroxide:



H_2O_2 is a reservoir and sink for HOx: being highly soluble, it's removed from the atmosphere fairly rapidly by absorption into cloud water and rainout. H_2O_2 can also be photolysed ($\lambda < 400$ nm), releasing HOx, though this is rather slow in the troposphere; alternatively it reacts (slowly) with OH to form HO_2 and water.

The lifetime of HO_2 is about a minute in clean air, depending on the rates of R2.10 and R2.11. HOx concentrations react very rapidly to changes in the ozone photolysis rate.

In summary, reactions R2.3–R2.11 (representing the unpolluted atmosphere) lead to loss of O_3 and formation of peroxides like H_2O_2 .

2.5.1 Steady-state concentration of OH and HO_2

Approximate values for $[OH]$, $[HO_2]$ and total $[HOx]$ can be derived from R2.3–R2.11 together with $J_{O(^1D)}$.

Globally, $J_{O(^1D)}$ has a rough average (over solar zenith angle etc.) of $2.5 \times 10^{-6} \text{ s}^{-1}$. With ozone at 40 ppbv, this gives an $O(^1D)$ production rate from ozone photolysis such that $O(^1D)$ is being formed at about $2.5 \times 10^6 \text{ molecule cm}^{-3} \text{ s}^{-1}$. As above, in the lower troposphere ~10% reacts with H_2O to form two OH (R2.6) — please do not commit this figure to memory! — giving an OH production rate of around $5 \times 10^5 \text{ cm}^{-3} \text{ s}^{-1}$.

OH is produced primarily from ozone photolysis, since the $O_3 + HO_2$ reaction (R2.10) is generally too slow to contribute significantly. OH is lost primarily by reaction with CO (R2.7). At steady state, production and destruction balance. Since $[CO] \sim 75$ ppbv on average and $k_{2.7} = 2.0 \times 10^{-13}$ at 1 atm, this leads to a steady-state OH concentration in the sunlit atmosphere of:

$$[OH] = 1.4 \times 10^6 \text{ molecule cm}^{-3}$$

In the clean troposphere, where $[NO_2]$ is very small, it's safe to assume R2.11 is the main HO_2 loss route, with $k_{2.11} = 6.0 \times 10^{-12} \text{ cm}^3 \text{ molecule}^{-1} \text{ s}^{-1}$. Putting HOx into steady state:

$$\frac{d[HO_x]}{dt}(\text{steady state}) = 0 = R_p(OH) - 2k_{2.11}[HO_2]^2$$

gives:

$$[HO_2] = 2 \times 10^8 \text{ molecule cm}^{-3}$$

Thus HO_2 is the dominant component of HOx. The ratio $[HO_2]/[OH]$ can be found from the interconversion reactions, e.g.:

$$k_{2.10}[HO_2][O_3] = k_{2.7}[OH][CO]$$

In general, the precise ratio depends on the composition of the air parcel — $[O_3]$, $[CO]$, etc.

Example 2 — steady-state $[OH]$ in the tropical atmospheric boundary layer

In the tropics, $[H_2O]$ is much higher than at mid-latitudes. The reduced overhead ozone column (see Michaelmas Module 1) also leads to increased rates of ozone photolysis. Work through the same steady-state derivation as above, but substituting tropical values for $[H_2O]$, the overhead O_3 column (and hence $J_{O(^1D)}$), and $[CO]/[O_3]$ — see the companion notebook.

2.6 Trace gas oxidation

OH is highly reactive with respect to many species, and is responsible for oxidising a range of tropospheric gases including NO_2 , SO_2 , CH_4 and nearly all VOCs, as well as CO. Reactivity varies greatly by hydrocarbon (Table 2.2). Saturated molecules react by H-atom abstraction, while unsaturated molecules react via electrophilic addition at the double/triple bond.

Oxidation of halocarbons (CH_3Cl , $CHCl_3$, C_2Cl_4 , CH_3CCl_3) also occurs by H-abstraction and addition; rate constants tend to be slower than the analogous hydrocarbons, but this remains an important removal process for these potentially ozone-depleting substances in the troposphere. Other H-containing molecules (H_2S , NH_3) are similarly removed by abstraction reactions with OH.

Fully halogenated hydrocarbons do not react with OH (the abstraction reaction to form HOX, $X = Cl, F$, is endothermic). These and other OH-resistant gases (e.g. N_2O , OCS) are, absent energetic short-wavelength photons, inert in the troposphere, and so pass unimpeded into the stratosphere, where they are destroyed by UV photolysis.

Table 2.2 — Examples of trace gas reaction rates with OH

Molecule	Rate coefficient / $\text{cm}^3 \text{ molecule}^{-1} \text{ s}^{-1}$	Atmospheric lifetime*
CH_4	$\sim 7 \times 10^{-15}$	~ 4.5 years
CH_3Cl	$\sim 4 \times 10^{-14}$	~ 0.8 year
CO	$\sim 2 \times 10^{-13}$	~ 2 months
C_2H_6	$\sim 3 \times 10^{-13}$	~ 1.5 months
C_3H_8	$\sim 1 \times 10^{-12}$	~ 11 days
C_2H_4	$\sim 8 \times 10^{-12}$	~ 1.5 days
C_5H_8 (isoprene)	$\sim 7 \times 10^{-11}$	~ 4 hours
CH_3SCH_3 (DMS)	$\sim 9 \times 10^{-12}$	~ 1.4 days
SO_2	$\sim 1 \times 10^{-12}$	~ 11 days
NO_2	$\sim 9 \times 10^{-12}$	~ 1.4 days
NH_3	$\sim 1.6 \times 10^{-13}$	~ 3 months
CCl_4	$\sim 1 \times 10^{-17}$	**

* Based on mean $[\text{OH}]$ of $1 \times 10^6 \text{ molecule cm}^{-3}$. ** Destroyed in the stratosphere — lifetime set by transport.

2.7 Observations of HOx radicals

Direct atmospheric measurements have convincingly confirmed the presence of OH in the daytime troposphere. Measurements in very clean atmospheres over the Southern Ocean confirm the basic mechanism, in which HOx radicals are predicted to have a square-root dependence on the ozone photolysis rate. The observations also show that ozone is slowly destroyed through photolysis, and that peroxides like H_2O_2 are formed.

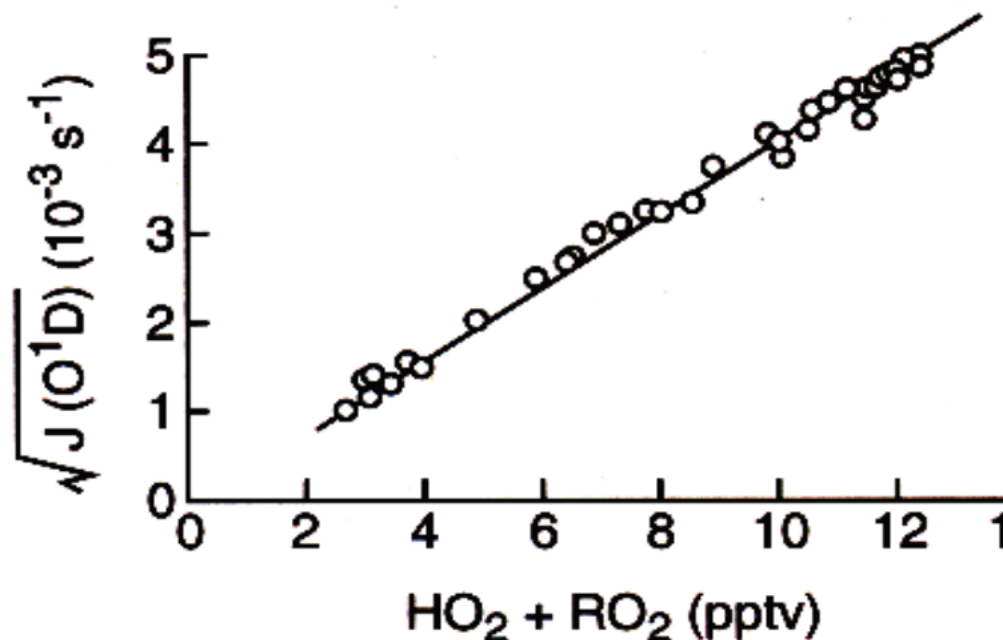


Figure 2.5 — Correlation plot of measured HO_2 (+ RO_2) radical concentrations vs. calculated $J(\text{O}^1\text{D})$, showing the dependence of peroxy radical concentration on the square root of $J(\text{O}^1\text{D})$. Data from the Cape Grim observatory, Tasmania.

Key points — Module 7 - Photolysis of trace gases in the troposphere occurs only at wavelengths longer than $\sim 300 \text{ nm}$. - OH and HO_2 form the HOx family. Key formation/loss processes and

steady-state conditions involve reactions with CO, CH₄, NO and NO₂. - OH reacts with many trace gases, driving their oxidation. Its presence provides the oxidizing capacity of the atmosphere, and is used to calculate lifetimes of tropospheric trace gases.

Try it yourself

Open [notebooks/07-oh-steady-state.ipynb](#) to:

- Reproduce the $[\text{OH}] = 1.4 \times 10^6 \text{ cm}^{-3}$ and $[\text{HO}_2] = 2 \times 10^8 \text{ cm}^{-3}$ steady-state results from §2.5.1 numerically.
 - Solve Example 2 (tropical boundary layer OH) by adjusting $[\text{H}_2\text{O}]$, the O_3 column/ $J_{\text{O}(^1\text{D})}$, and $[\text{CO}]$ to tropical values, and compare the resulting $[\text{OH}]$ to the mid-latitude case.
 - Explore the predicted square-root dependence of $[\text{HOx}]$ on $J_{\text{O}(^1\text{D})}$ (Fig 2.5) from the steady-state equations, and check it against the observational correlation.
 - Rank trace gases by OH-reaction lifetime using Table 2.2, and see how lifetime scales with rate coefficient for fixed $[\text{OH}]$.
-

Next: [Module 8 — Methane Oxidation and NO_x-Driven Ozone Production](#)

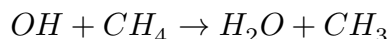
Methane Oxidation and NO_x-Driven Ozone Production

Module 8 · Methane Oxidation and NO_x-Driven Ozone Production

Aims of this module 1. To describe the oxidation of atmospheric methane. 2. To understand, qualitatively, the effect of methane on tropospheric ozone. 3. To describe the role of NO_x in production of tropospheric ozone. 4. To describe the processes controlling the concentration of nitrogen oxides in the troposphere.

3.1 Methane oxidation in the troposphere

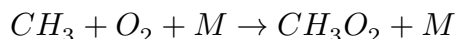
Hydroxyl radicals react with methane, constituting the major removal process for atmospheric methane:



(R3.1)

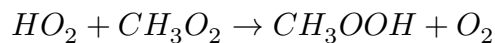
The lifetime of CH₄, based on the R3.1 rate coefficient of 6×10^{-15} cm³ molecule⁻¹ s⁻¹ at 288 K and the average tropospheric [OH], is approximately 7 years. This means methane is well mixed in the troposphere, and its oxidation occurs wherever OH is present. Indeed, the concentration of methane sets an upper limit on the lifetime of OH in the troposphere of about one second.

In clean, unpolluted air, about 30% of OH is removed by reaction with CH₄ (the remainder reacts with CO). The methyl radical formed reacts instantly with O₂ to form the methyl peroxy radical, CH₃O₂:



(R3.2)

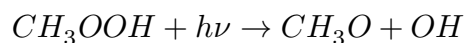
In a low-NO_x environment (unpolluted air), the principal fate of CH₃O₂ is reaction with HO₂ to produce methyl hydroperoxide, CH₃OOH:



(R3.3)

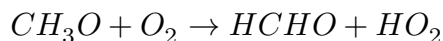
As in Module 7, peroxides are reservoirs for radicals, and methyl hydroperoxide — like H₂O₂ — is soluble and readily washed out, acting as a sink for HO_x. Since HO_x is formed from ozone photolysis, this washout makes the overall conversion of O₃ to peroxides (via reaction with methane) into a sink for O₃.

Photolysis of methyl hydroperoxide is also possible, releasing methoxy, CH₃O, and OH:



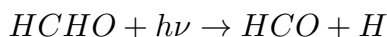
(R3.4)

CH₃O reacts with O₂ to form formaldehyde plus HO₂:

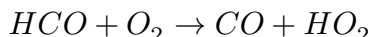


(R3.5)

and formaldehyde is itself photolysed to produce more HO₂:



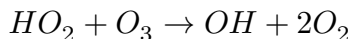
(R3.6)



(R3.7)

This recycles, and in certain circumstances (such as the dry upper troposphere) may even amplify [HOx].

Recall HO₂ converts back to OH by reaction with ozone:



(R3.8 / R2.10)

However, the efficiency of this OH recycling is rather low in the clean lower troposphere: both CH₃OOH and HCHO are soluble in water droplets, leading to a net loss of HOx through rainout. R3.8 is competitive with the HO₂ self-reaction at ozone concentrations typical of the clean troposphere, and will also contribute to O₃ removal.

To recap: R3.3, together with loss of peroxides (or HCHO) in rain, leads to a net loss of HOx radicals. As ozone is lost in the process of generating HOx from O(¹D), there is a net loss of ozone overall — in the unpolluted (low-NOx) troposphere.

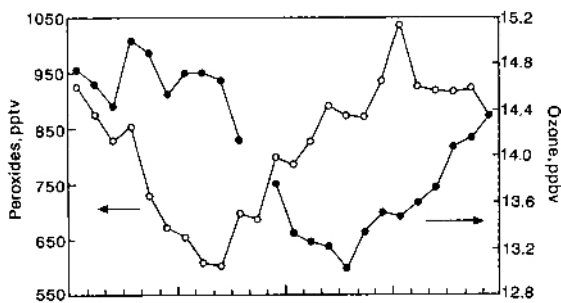


Figure 3.2 — Diurnal variation of peroxides ROOH (open symbols) and ozone (filled symbols) in the clean marine troposphere, showing production of peroxides and destruction of ozone during daytime (highlighted region).

3.2 Nitrogen oxides and production of tropospheric ozone

Much of the troposphere contains traces of NO and NO₂, which play an important role in tropospheric photochemistry. We've seen that in the unpolluted troposphere, oxidation of CO and CH₄ to CO₂ leads to a loss of both ozone and OH. The presence of nitrogen oxides changes this picture dramatically. In a polluted atmosphere, additional reactions must be considered to determine the overall oxidant budget.

NOx is emitted/generated from a number of surface and tropospheric processes. Major anthropogenic sources: fossil fuel combustion (mostly ground-level, with a small aviation contribution) and agricultural activities. Dominant natural sources: biomass burning (though much is human-caused, especially in the

tropics) and lightning (associated with deep convection, largest sources in the tropics). Only lightning and aircraft are non-surface sources.

NO_x is removed from the atmosphere through dry and wet deposition, with wet deposition of nitrate (nitric acid) the dominant process.

3.2.1 Photostationary state in the absence of peroxy radicals

Consider first the reactions of NO, NO₂ and O₃ in isolation. NO₂ is photolysed to O(³P), which reacts almost exclusively with O₂ to form O₃ (O-atom reactions with other pollutants don't compete under normal tropospheric conditions). O₃ then reacts with NO, reforming NO₂:



This coupled cycle establishes a photostationary state, with [O₃] set by the NO₂/NO ratio via the Leighton relationship:

$$\frac{d[O_3]}{dt} = J_{3.10}[NO_2] - k_{3.12}[NO][O_3]$$

At steady state:

$$[O_3]_{ss} = \frac{J_{3.10}[NO_2]}{k_{3.12}[NO]}$$

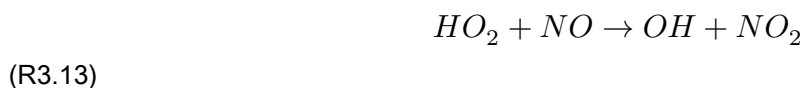
Example 3 — timescale for establishment of the photostationary state

As in Modules 2 and 4, the timescale to reach photostationary state between NO, NO₂ and O₃ is set by the sum of the pseudo-first-order forward and backward rates linking the species — here approximately $(J_{3.10} + k_{3.12}[O_3])^{-1}$. Work through this calculation with typical boundary-layer $J_{3.10}$ and [O₃] in the notebook: the PSS is normally established on a timescale of order 100 seconds — fast compared to the hours/days over which NO_x and O₃ budgets otherwise evolve.

3.2.2 Reaction of peroxy radicals with NO leads to O₃ production

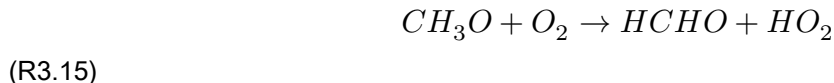
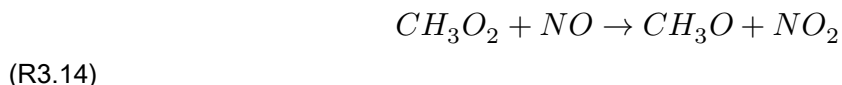
In the real atmosphere, the NO:NO₂ ratio is perturbed by other oxidants — mostly hydroperoxyl and organic peroxide radicals — which also convert NO to NO₂ and lead to net ozone production.

In the daytime, NO reacts with HO₂, regenerating OH (R3.13) and producing NO₂:



$$k_{3.13} = 8 \times 10^{-12} \text{ cm}^3 \text{ molec}^{-1} \text{ s}^{-1}$$

NO also reacts with CH_3O_2 , leading to HO_2 formation:



Although R3.13/R3.14 are much slower than $\text{NO} + \text{O}_3$ ($[\text{HO}_2]$ and $[\text{CH}_3\text{O}_2] \ll [\text{O}_3]$ in the troposphere), they significantly perturb the photostationary state. This is because reaction of NO with peroxy radicals RO_2 (e.g. HO_2 , CH_3O_2) oxidises NO to NO_2 without consuming O_3 . Ozone production follows when the resulting NO_2 is photolysed and the O product combines with O_2 .

3.3 Rate of production of ozone in the presence of alkanes and NOx

We've seen NO is oxidised by RO_2 radicals to NO_2 — a key ingredient of photochemical smog: conversion of NO to NO_2 via hydrocarbon oxidation drives ozone generation.

In the absence of hydrocarbons, the Leighton relationship tells us ozone and the NO/ NO_2 ratio stay constant: every $\text{NO} \rightarrow \text{NO}_2$ conversion costs an O_3 molecule, and every $\text{NO}_2 \rightarrow \text{NO}$ conversion generates one. But when hydrocarbon oxidation is occurring, $\text{NO} \rightarrow \text{NO}_2$ conversion proceeds faster, shifting the NO/ NO_2 ratio and increasing $[\text{O}_3]$. Increasing $[\text{O}_3]$ increases $[\text{OH}]$, which, to a first approximation, increases the rate of VOC oxidation — a positive feedback.

We can derive the rate of O_3 production in the presence of RO_2 and NOx in two steps.

Step 1 — steady state for $[\text{O}]$, from R3.10 and R3.11 (neglecting O_3 photolysis):

$$\frac{d[\text{O}]}{dt} = J_{3.10}[\text{NO}_2] - k_{3.11}[\text{O}][\text{O}_2][\text{M}] = 0 \Rightarrow [\text{O}]_{ss} = \frac{J_{3.10}[\text{NO}_2]}{k_{3.11}[\text{O}_2][\text{M}]}$$

Since essentially all O atoms proceed to O_3 via R3.11, the rate of O_3 formation from this branch is simply $J_{3.10}[\text{NO}_2]$.

Step 2 — steady state for $[\text{NO}]$, now including the peroxy-radical oxidation pathway (R3.13/R3.14) alongside R3.12:

$$\frac{d[\text{NO}]}{dt} = J_{3.10}[\text{NO}_2] - k_{3.12}[\text{NO}][\text{O}_3] - k_{3.13}[\text{RO}_2][\text{NO}] = 0$$

(taking $[\text{RO}_2] = [\text{HO}_2] + [\text{CH}_3\text{O}_2] + \dots$, and $k_{3.13}$ as a representative rate constant for all NO + peroxy-radical reactions.) Solving for $[\text{NO}]$ and substituting back gives the net ozone production rate:

$$P(\text{O}_3) = k_{3.13}[\text{RO}_2][\text{NO}]$$

— i.e. the rate of ozone production is set by the rate at which peroxy radicals oxidise NO to NO_2 . Thus, in the presence of NOx, ozone is produced rather than destroyed by the overall CH_4/CO oxidation cycle involving HOx radicals.

3.4 Formation of nitric acid and NOx lifetime

Depending on [NOx], the OH radical that initiates VOC oxidation (and hence ozone production) may have another fate: reaction with NO₂ to form nitric acid:



(R3.16)

This reaction matters for two reasons: HNO₃ is a reservoir species for both HOx and NOx, and its formation terminates the free-radical chain leading to ozone production. HNO₃ also has a high deposition velocity over land and is highly soluble, so it's readily lost by wet and dry deposition. Thus, at high NOx levels, the OH + NO₂ reaction controls the net loss of HOx: a decrease is observed in the steady-state [HOx] at high NOx levels.

R3.12 (NO + O₃ → NO₂ + O₂) is temperature-dependent: $k_{3.12} = 2 \times 10^{-12} \exp(-1400/T) \text{ cm}^3 \text{ molecule}^{-1} \text{ s}^{-1}$. This, together with changes in [O₃] and [OH] between the boundary layer and the upper troposphere, affects the lifetime of NOx with altitude. Assuming only R3.10, R3.12 and R3.16 set the NOx lifetime:

$$\tau_{NOx} = \frac{[NO_x]}{k_{3.16}[NO_2][OH]}$$

Fig 3.3 shows this lifetime increasing to about 15 days in the tropical upper troposphere, versus around one day in the boundary layer.

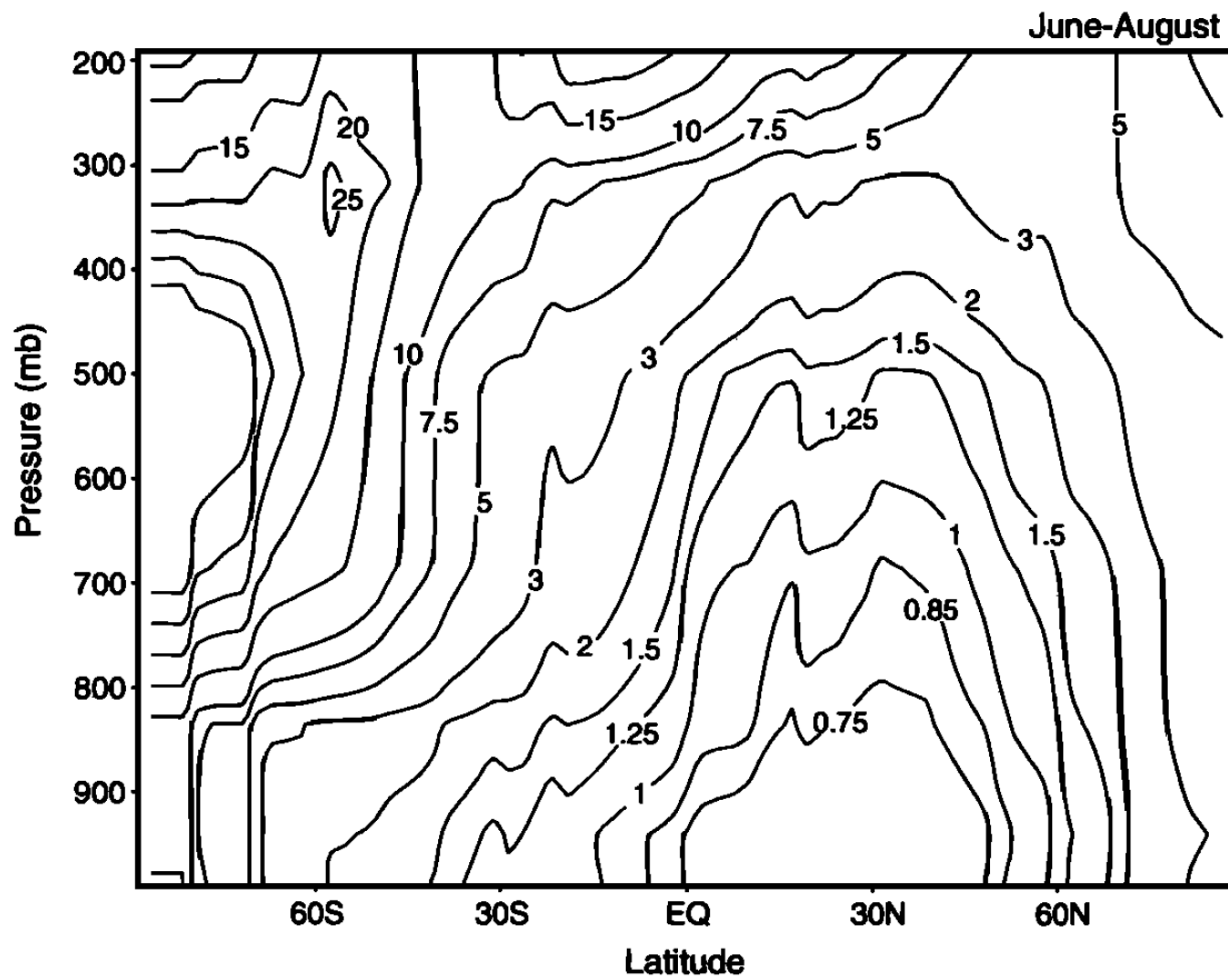


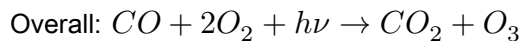
Figure 3.3 — Lifetime of NO_x in the troposphere (days), as a function of latitude and height.

3.5 Ozone production under low and high NO_x conditions

Consider CO oxidation once more. In the absence of NO_x, overall O₃ destruction results:



Compare with ozone formation in the presence of NO_x:



Clearly, increasing [NO_x] increases the rate of the ozone-production cycle. There's a critical NO_x concentration at which production outweighs destruction.

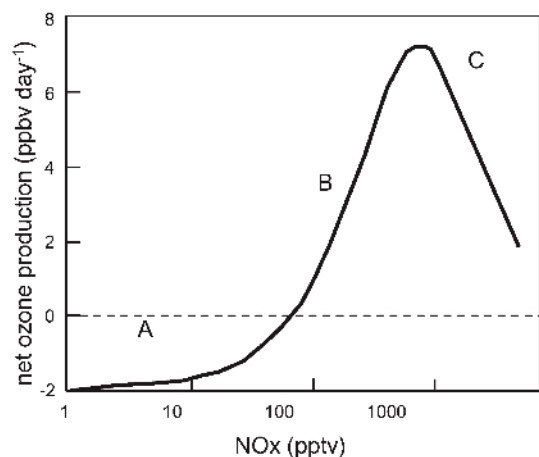


Figure 3.4 — Schematic representation of the dependence of net ozone production on NO_x mixing ratio.

The figure divides into three regions, illustrating a strongly non-linear dependence of ozone production on NO_x:

- Region A — ozone destruction dominates. As NO_x increases, the production rate rises until it exceeds the (NO_x-independent) destruction rate, and net production begins.
- The transition — where does it occur? To first approximation, treat HO₂ as the only peroxy radical. The transition occurs when enough NO is present for NO + HO₂ ($k_{3.13} \approx 8 \times 10^{-12} \text{ cm}^3 \text{ s}^{-1}$) to compete with the much slower O₃ + HO₂ ($k_{3.8} \approx 2 \times 10^{-15} \text{ cm}^3 \text{ s}^{-1}$). Equating these rates ([HO₂] cancels) gives $[NO] = k_{3.8}[O_3]/k_{3.13}$. For a typical [O₃] ~ 40 ppbv, this gives $[NO] \sim 0.01 \text{ ppbv}$ (10 pptv). Anthropogenic NO emissions (largely motor vehicles) significantly exceed this over much of the northern-hemisphere land area, so the ozone-production cycle dominates there. Even in clean oceanic air (Cape Grim, Tasmania), small amounts of NO suffice to cause net ozone production — photochemical ozone production is thus a global phenomenon. Only in remote marine areas ([NO_x] < 10 pptv) does photochemistry act as a net O₃ sink.

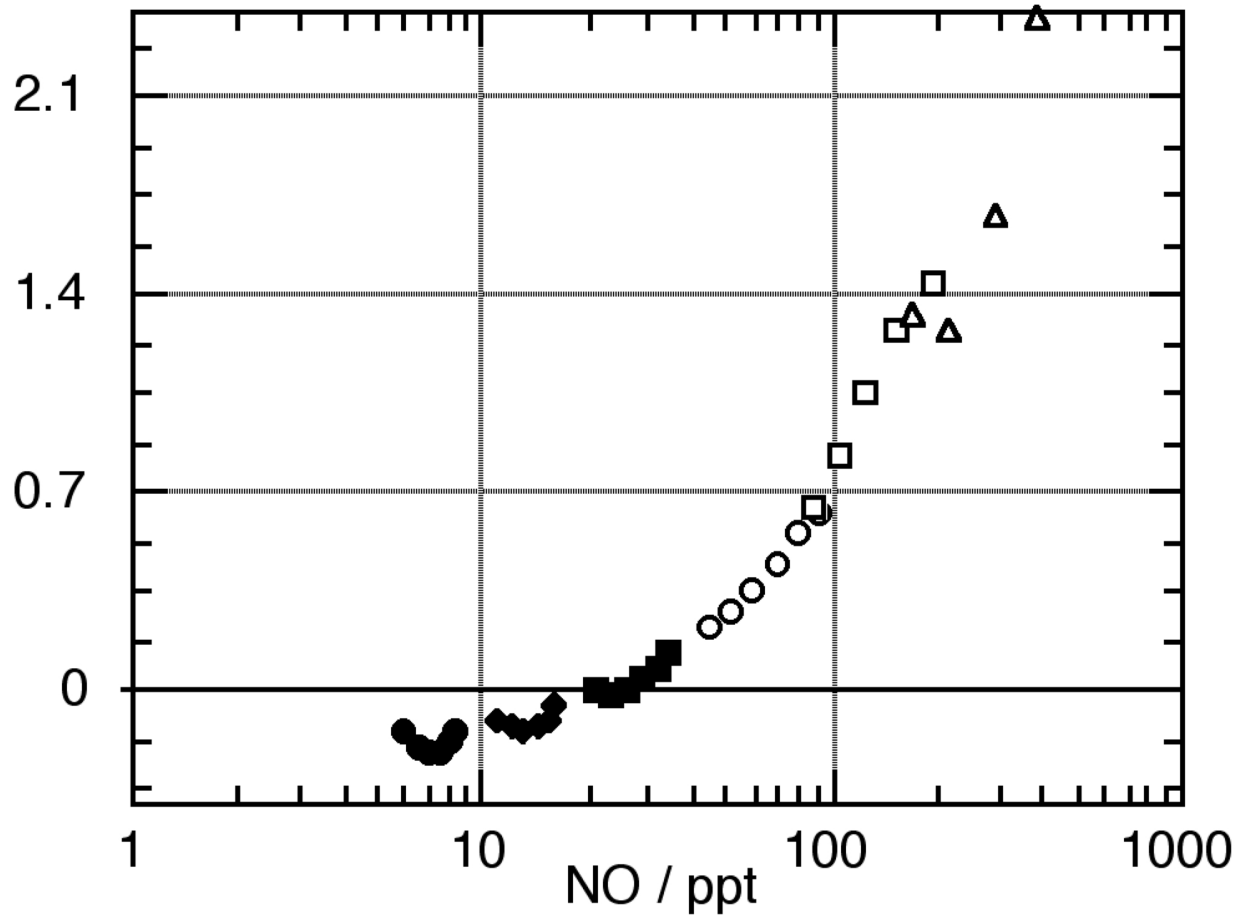


Figure 3.5 — Net ozone production as a function of [NO] (ppt), in clean oceanic air at Cape Grim, Tasmania.

- Ozone production does not keep increasing with NO_x indefinitely — at high enough NO_x, production peaks and then decreases. This turnover is caused by the increasing rate of the termination reaction R3.16: more NO_x means more OH + NO₂ → HNO₃, making the free-radical-catalysed production cycle less efficient.

This complex mechanism produces a strongly non-linear relationship between ozone amounts and precursor emission rates — an ozone “isopleth” surface in NO_x–VOC emission space:

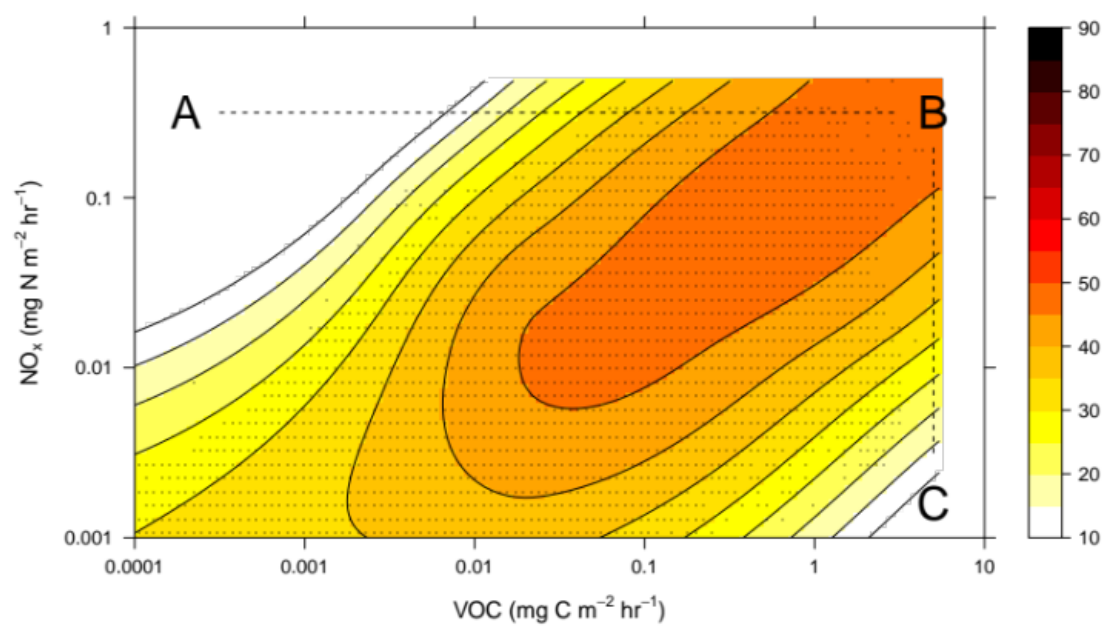


Figure 3.6 — Modelled ozone mixing ratio (ppb) as a function of NO_x emission rate and VOC emission rate.

Quite different regulatory responses are needed depending on where a region sits on this isopleth surface. For example: at point B, reducing NO_x emissions without reducing VOC (path B→C) has limited effect; reducing VOC alone (path B→A) would require ~3 orders of magnitude reduction to see significant effects. There is no magic bullet — the chemistry is complex! More detailed analysis suggests the best results come from tighter regulation of the most reactive hydrocarbons combined with NO_x reduction. (Note: not all VOCs are anthropogenic — isoprene, for example, is biogenic, emitted from certain plants and trees, at an emission rate comparable to CH₄.)

An increase in NO_x at point C leads to ozone production — this regime is ‘NO_x-limited’. At point A, adding VOCs leads to ozone production — this regime is ‘VOC-limited’. Much of the industrialised northern hemisphere is VOC-limited (high ambient NO_x); many tropical and southern-hemisphere locations are NO_x-limited. Predicting the atmospheric response to emissions policy is consequently very complex.

Try it yourself

Open [notebooks/08-photostationary-state.ipynb](#) to:

- Solve Example 3 (photostationary-state establishment timescale) and confirm it’s fast (~100 s) relative to NO_x/O₃ budget timescales.
 - Implement the Leighton relationship and reproduce how $[O_3]_{ss}$ depends on the NO₂/NO ratio.
 - Compute the low-NO_x/high-NO_x transition [NO] (§3.5) and reproduce the qualitative shape of Fig 3.4/3.5 as a function of [NO], including the high-NO_x turnover from R3.16.
 - Build a simple ozone-isopleth calculator as a function of NO_x and VOC emission rates, and locate NO_x-limited vs. VOC-limited regimes.
-

Next: [Module 9 — The Tropospheric Ozone Budget, PAN and NO_x Reservoirs](#)

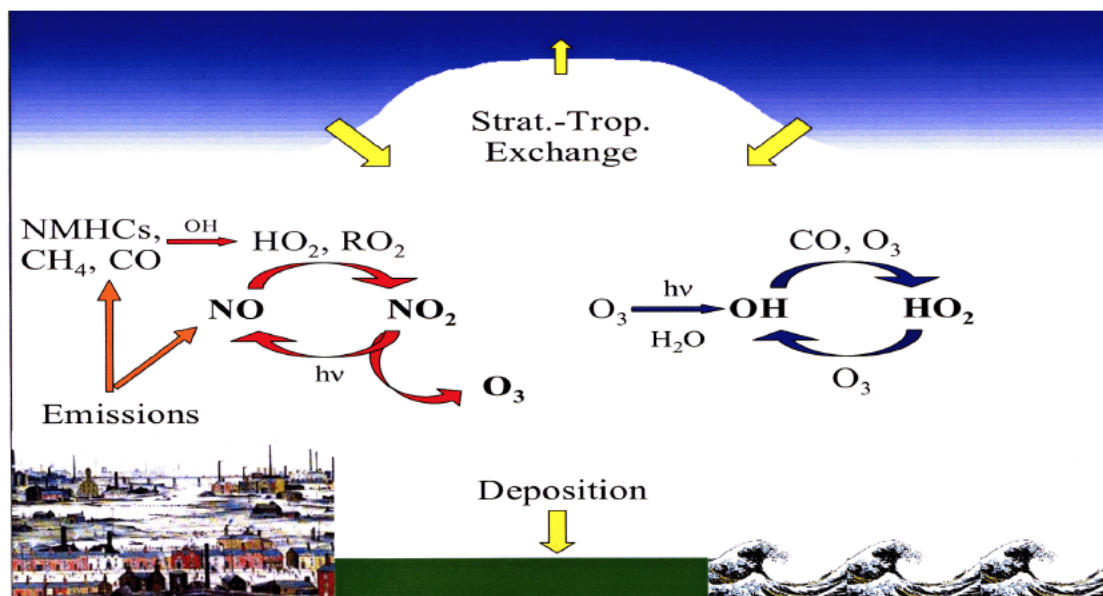
The Tropospheric Ozone Budget, Carbonyl Formation and NO_x Reservoirs

Module 9 · The Tropospheric Ozone Budget, Carbonyl Formation and NO_x Reservoirs

Learning aims By the end of this module you should be able to: 1. Describe the main terms in the global tropospheric ozone budget (stratospheric input, chemical production/loss, surface deposition) and explain why the net budget is so sensitive to the large gross chemical terms. 2. Describe how formaldehyde and other carbonyls are formed during NO_x-driven VOC oxidation, and their role in recycling HO_x. 3. Describe the formation, stability and atmospheric role of the main NO_x reservoir species: HONO, PAN, organic nitrates, and N₂O₅/NO₃. 4. Explain why NO₃ chemistry is particularly important at night.

3.6 The budget of tropospheric ozone

The main processes controlling tropospheric O₃ are shown schematically in Fig 3.7. There are four main terms: transport from the stratosphere (where the ozone mixing ratio is much higher than in the troposphere — a genuinely important source); in-situ photochemical production and destruction; and deposition at the surface. These terms approach balance in the annual mean, but are not independent — increased stratospheric flux, or increased photochemical production, might for example lead to additional O₃ deposition. Precursors of photochemical ozone production originate from both anthropogenic and biogenic processes.



Figure

3.7 — Schematic of the processes controlling tropospheric O₃.

Table 3.2 — approximate global budget of tropospheric ozone (Tg/year)

Stratospheric origin	Photochemical production – loss	Surface loss
400	800 (4000 – 3200)	–1200

Although the chemical production and destruction terms are individually large, their net effect is comparable in magnitude to the stratospheric influx and surface deposition. Despite these comparable net terms, photochemical O₃ production and loss are by far the largest gross terms — so any small trend (or error) in either has a disproportionately large impact on the tropospheric ozone burden (about 300 Tg).

O₃ destruction via O(¹D) + H₂O dominates in the tropics and near the surface, where [H₂O] is highest. O₃ surface deposition (expressed as a deposition velocity) depends strongly on surface type and is quite uncertain — some models use a deposition term half the size of others. Deposition to vegetated surfaces is much stronger than to ocean or snow/ice, but the dependence on vegetation type is still not well quantified.

Ozone concentrations in Europe and other industrialised regions increased strongly over roughly the last hundred years (Fig 3.8), due to increased anthropogenic activity and associated NO_x/VOC emissions.

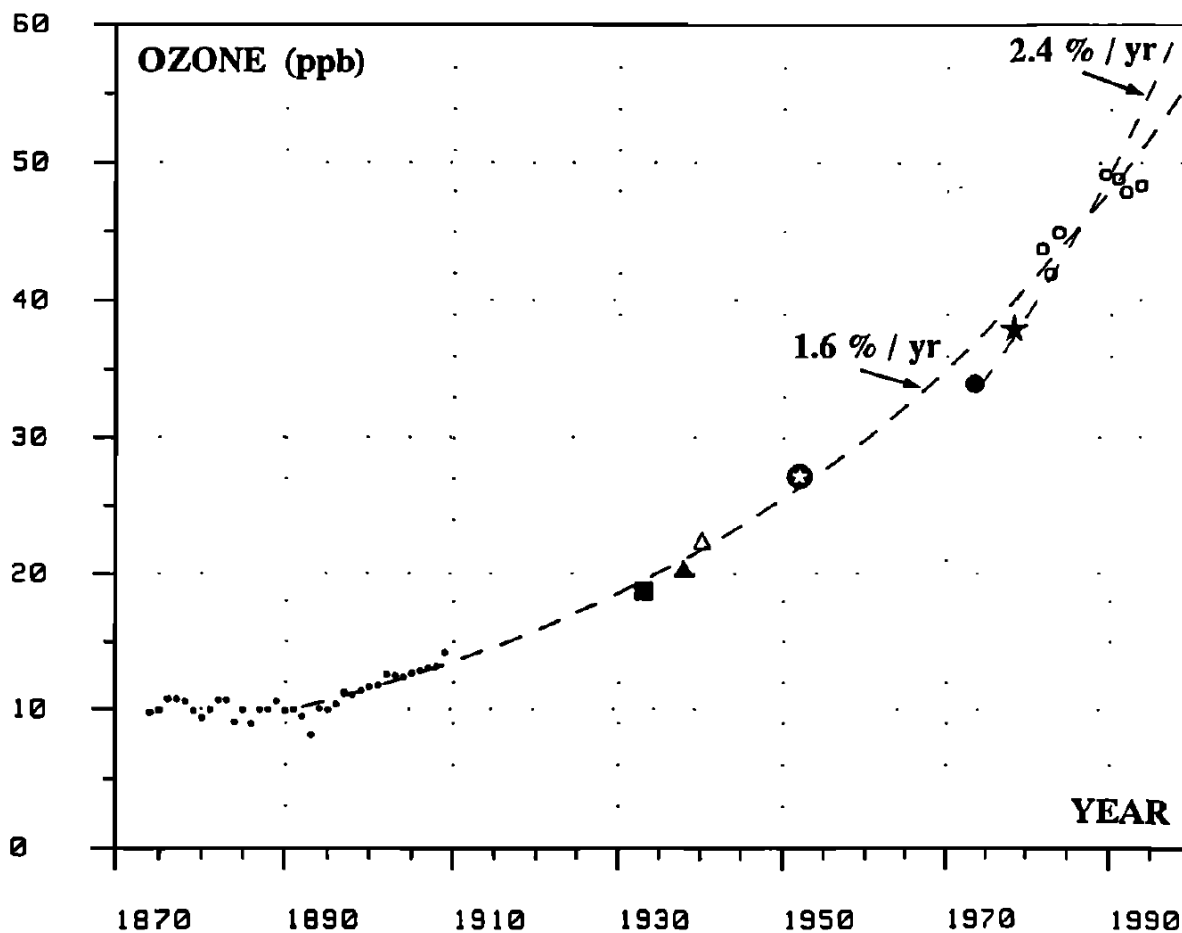
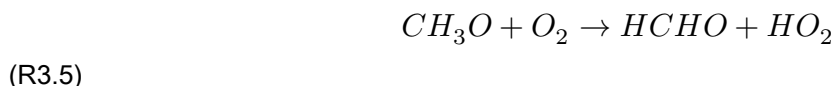
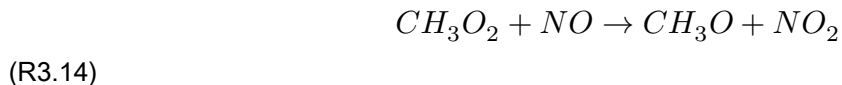


Figure 3.8 — Historical ozone concentrations in Paris since 1870. Annual average concentrations increased by a factor of 5–10 over this period.

3.7 Formation of carbonyl compounds

The reaction of NO with methyl peroxy radicals produces both NO₂ and formaldehyde (R3.15). The fate of this formaldehyde matters both for HOx concentrations and for the rate of VOC oxidation, since formaldehyde is photolysed in the troposphere to liberate HOx:



Radicals from R3.5 and R3.7 re-enter the HOx family, which can react further (e.g. R3.1) leading to more O₃ formation. Thus, the presence of NO fundamentally shifts the oxidation process in favour of producing both ozone and HOx.

3.8 NOx reservoirs

The importance of NOx to tropospheric chemistry is clear from the preceding discussion of its influence on ozone production. It follows that any mechanism removing NOx from the atmosphere, or transporting it from polluted to clean regions, could be highly significant for ozone photochemistry — particularly given how little NO is needed for net ozone production (§3.5).

We already discussed the role of HNO₃ as an important NOx sink (§3.4) and its ecosystem effects (Module 6, §1.4.3).

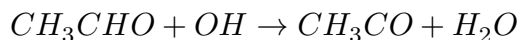
Nitrous acid, HONO (HNO₂), is mostly formed in heterogeneous reactions from NO₂, and represents a night-time reservoir for both HOx and NOx. HONO is quickly photolysed at sunrise, regenerating NO and OH:



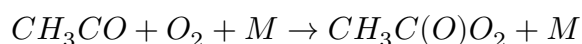
This generates a pulse of OH into the early-morning atmosphere, partly responsible for kick-starting daytime photochemistry (see Module 7, §2.4.1).

3.8.1 Formation of the NO_x reservoir peroxyacetyl nitrate (PAN)

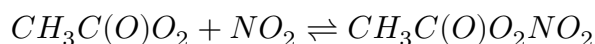
Peroxyacetyl nitrate (PAN: CH₃C(O)O₂NO₂) forms readily in the troposphere as a degradation product of C₂+ hydrocarbons in the presence of NO₂. For example, OH + acetaldehyde (a typical VOC degradation product) forms acetylperoxy radicals:



(R3.18)

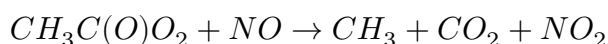


which react with NO₂ to form PAN. At ambient temperature, PAN has a relatively high rate of reverse decomposition, maintaining equilibrium with its precursors:



(R3.19 / R3.20)

In the presence of NO, the acetylperoxy radical instead decomposes:



(R3.21)

(the CH₃ radical is then oxidised to HCHO by the reactions covered earlier in this course). Steady-state analysis gives the net rate constant for PAN decomposition:

$$k = k_{3.20} \left\{ 1 - \frac{1}{1 + \frac{k_{3.21}[NO]}{k_{3.19}[NO_2]}} \right\}$$

The decomposition rate depends on the relative amounts of NO and NO₂, and on temperature — $k_{3.20}$ has a large activation energy: $k_{3.20} = 4.0 \times 10^{15} \exp\{-108/RT\} \text{ s}^{-1}$ (1 atm, E_a in kJ mol⁻¹). In the daytime boundary layer, NO and NO₂ are in photostationary state and PAN's lifetime is a few hours; at night, [NO] → 0 and the decomposition rate falls to zero.

Above the boundary layer, lower temperatures give PAN a much longer lifetime (up to several weeks) — long enough for significant transport to other parts of the atmosphere, where, on reaching warmer regions, it can dissociate, releasing NO₂ and affecting ozone chemistry there.

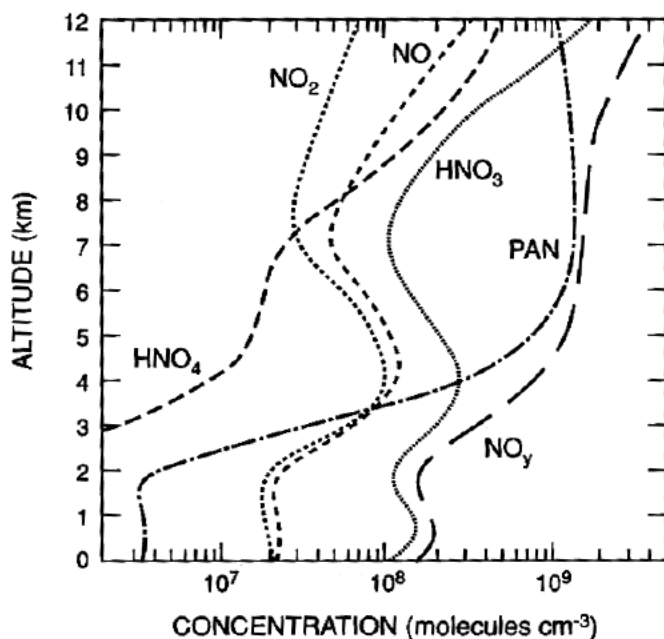


Figure 3.10 — Modelled concentrations of ni-

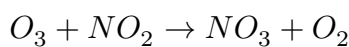
trogen compounds as a function of altitude throughout the troposphere. In the upper troposphere, PAN is the dominant nitrogen species.

PAN has indeed been detected in significant quantities in parts of the atmosphere remote from direct pollution, implying it affects the global ozone budget.

PAN should not be confused with the organic nitrates, RONO_2 , formed in small amounts from the $\text{RO}_2 + \text{NO}$ reaction (R = alkyl, aryl or allyl group). Organic nitrates are thermally stable, removed slowly by photolysis and reaction with OH — these too act as reservoirs for long-range NO_x transport.

3.8.2 Formation of N_2O_5 from NO_3 — at night — can lead to NO_x removal

NO_2 + ozone forms nitrogen pentoxide via the intermediate NO_3 radical:

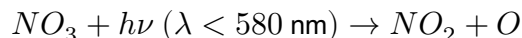


(R3.22)

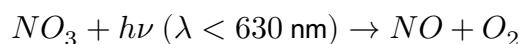


(R3.23)

N_2O_5 is thermally unstable and decomposes back to NO_3 , making R3.23 reversible. NO_3 undergoes very rapid photolysis in visible light:



(R3.24)



(R3.25)

so N_2O_5 is not formed in daytime. Night-time steady-state $[\text{NO}_3]$ (independent of $[\text{NO}_2]$, since production and loss are both proportional to it) is of order 1 pptv — some 30 times $[\text{OH}]$. Under these conditions, oxidation by NO_3 at night may rival OH oxidation for some VOCs (e.g. DMS, isoprene, terpenes).

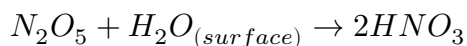
NO₃ also reacts with NO, rapidly converting back to NO₂:



(R3.26)

which competes with N₂O₅ formation (R3.23) near NO sources.

N₂O₅ can undergo heterogeneous reaction with water on aerosol, cloud or fog droplet surfaces to form HNO₃:



(R3.27)

Formation of N₂O₅ thus sequesters two molecules of NO_x into reservoir form, and acts as a sink for tropospheric NO_x (since the resulting HNO₃ can be wet- or dry-deposited) — a significant removal process affecting both the nitrogen budget and ozone.

Key points — Module 8/9 - Atmospheric methane is oxidised to formaldehyde, then CO, then ultimately CO₂, following reaction with photochemically generated OH. The average CH₄ lifetime is about 7 years. - The CH₄/CO oxidation mechanism, via peroxy radicals, leads to loss of tropospheric ozone when only very small [NO_x] are present. - At higher NO_x levels, the NO₂/O₃ photostationary state is perturbed by reaction of peroxy radicals with NO, and net ozone production occurs. - HNO₃, HONO, N₂O₅ and PAN are the major NO_x sinks and reservoir species. - NO₃ drives night-time chemistry.

Try it yourself

Open [notebooks/09-nox-reservoirs.ipynb](#) to:

- Build the global tropospheric ozone budget (Table 3.2) as a simple flux-balance diagram, and explore how sensitive the net trend is to small percentage changes in the large gross production/loss terms.
 - Implement the PAN steady-state decomposition rate constant formula and explore its dependence on [NO]/[NO₂] and temperature, reproducing the “few hours in the boundary layer, weeks aloft” contrast.
 - Model night-time NO₃/N₂O₅ steady state from R3.22–R3.27, and estimate what fraction of NO_x gets sequestered as HNO₃ overnight under different [NO] (i.e. R3.26 competition) scenarios.
-

Next: [Module 10 — Oxidation of Non-Methane Organic Compounds I: Alkanes and Alkenes](#)

Oxidation of Non-Methane Organic Compounds I: Alkanes and Alkenes

Module 10 · Oxidation of Non-Methane Organic Compounds I: Alkanes and Alkenes

Aims of this module 1. The basic reaction schemes of VOCs with OH. 2. Ozonolysis reactions of alkenes. 3. (Aromatic oxidation follows in Module 11.)

4.0 Introduction

The reactions of larger organic compounds are similar to those of methane discussed in Modules 8–9 — leading, in the presence of sufficient NO_x, to the generation of ozone.

Non-methane volatile organic compounds (NMVOCs) include, by definition, all gaseous hydrocarbons and partially oxidised hydrocarbons in the atmosphere, but exclude methane, CFCs, CO and CO₂.

There are many anthropogenic and biogenic NMVOC sources, but on a global scale biogenic, natural sources dominate — only about 10–20% of NMVOC emissions are anthropogenic (fossil fuel and biomass combustion, agriculture, industry). Over 10,000 NMVOCs have been found in the atmosphere — but the structure of most of them is unknown! Urgent work is needed in analytical/experimental atmospheric chemistry to fill this knowledge gap.

Governmental environmental policy (partly aimed at reducing ozone formation) has significantly reduced anthropogenic NMVOC emissions in Europe over recent decades — the opposite trend holds in developing nations like China and India.

4.1 The role of NMVOCs in ozone production

Whilst fascinating in their own right, the real reason we care about NMVOCs in the troposphere is that their photo-oxidation can generate ozone and other secondary pollutants harmful to human health and crops. There are countless possible NMVOC structures, but the capacity of different hydrocarbons to produce ozone (and HO_x) depends roughly on the number of C–H bonds in the molecule — for example, C₂H₆ oxidation in the presence of NO produces around double the O₃ molecules of CH₄ oxidation to CO₂ (mole/mole basis). Generally, each –CH₂– group oxidised to CO₂ in the presence of NO yields a maximum of 3 O₃ molecules.

The general mechanism of ozone formation in the presence of VOC and NO_x centres on the reactions of organic (RO₂) and inorganic (HO₂) peroxy radicals, which facilitate the interconversion of NO to NO₂ and so enable tropospheric ozone production (as in Modules 8–9).

As NMVOC complexity increases, the reaction mechanism becomes more complicated. In reality, reaction with NO₃, O₃, and even direct photolysis, may also be important initiation steps — the relative importance of each pathway is set by the respective (pseudo-)first-order rate constants.

This module (and Module 11) outlines the oxidation schemes for the most abundant organic compound classes in the troposphere. Based on this you should be able to construct plausible oxidation mechanisms for many different NMVOCs.

4.2 Prediction of rate coefficients for initiation of NMVOC oxidation

The first step in NMVOC oxidation is reaction with an oxidant — suitable oxidants include OH, Cl, O₃ and NO₃ (and, to a very small extent, Br). Which dominates depends on both the abundance of the oxidant and the rate constant for its reaction with the specific NMVOC. Knowledge of these rate constants is vital for evaluating the atmospheric lifetime and degradation mechanisms of organic compounds.

Rate constants have been measured in the laboratory for many reactions, and patterns of reactivity can be recognised within a given reaction type (e.g. H-abstraction, addition to C=C bonds) related to molecular structure. There are clear trends in rate constants with carbon number for many oxidants, but also significant deviations from these trends — carbon number alone is not ultimately the best predictor of the initiation rate constant.

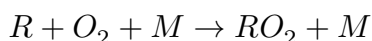
This nonetheless enables prediction of rate constants for molecules of known structure that are experimentally difficult to measure directly, and similar relationships can help predict products and their yields for reactions with multiple possible pathways.

4.3 Oxidation of alkanes

Under tropospheric conditions, alkanes react mostly with OH, and to a minor extent (~10%) with Cl radicals. Both proceed via H-abstraction, generating an alkyl radical plus water or HCl respectively. This reaction is generally faster for tertiary H atoms (>CH) than secondary (–CH₂–) or primary (–CH₃) H atoms.

Alkane + OH rate constants are typically 10^{–12}–10^{–11} cm³ molecule^{–1} s^{–1} (increasing slightly with carbon number) — about 10³ times faster than CH₄ + OH ($k = 6.2 \times 10^{-15}$ cm³ molecule^{–1} s^{–1}). Alkane + Cl rate constants are around 10^{–10} cm³ molecule^{–1} s^{–1}, but tropospheric [Cl] is very low (though uncertain, estimated at 10²–10⁵ molecules cm^{–3}), so Cl oxidation doesn't affect the overall alkane lifetime — though these reactions do represent a significant sink for Cl itself.

As with CH₄ oxidation, the alkyl radical reacts with O₂ to form a peroxy radical:

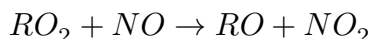


(R4.1)

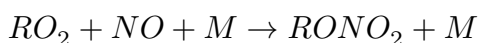
$k_{4.1}$ is fairly similar across measured R groups, spanning 5×10^{-12} – 2×10^{-11} cm³ molecule^{–1} s^{–1} (independent of M). Under standard tropospheric conditions, R has a lifetime of order 10^{–8} s.

Fate of RO₂

RO₂ can react with several tropospheric species. Reaction with NO gives two products:



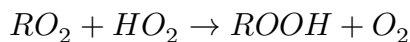
(R4.2)



(R4.3)

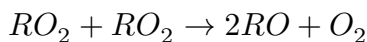
For most peroxy radicals, R4.2 dominates. For larger radicals, R4.3 becomes increasingly important, with yields up to 30%.

RO₂ can also react with HO₂ to form hydroperoxides:



(R4.4)

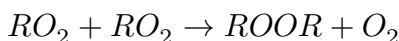
Reactions between different alkyl peroxy radicals are rather complex, with several observed overall pathways:



(R4.5)

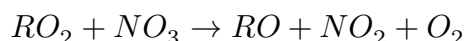


(R4.6)



(R4.7)

Reaction with NO₃,



(R4.8)

is unimportant during daytime but may become significant at night, when [NO₃] is highest.

Reaction of RO₂ with NO₂ forms peroxy nitrates, which are highly unstable at tropospheric temperatures and decompose back to RO₂ + NO₂ — not a significant pathway overall.

Among all RO₂ reactions, reaction with NO is by far dominant in the polluted atmosphere. Reactions with HO₂ and other RO₂ matter mainly in the clean/remote atmosphere, where NO is in the low-ppt range.

Auto-oxidation

In recent years, hydrogen atom-shift (H-shift) reactions have attracted much attention, as they can generate highly oxidised compounds bearing multiple hydroperoxy (–OOH) groups. This chemistry requires a sufficiently long carbon chain to enable 5/6-membered-ring transition states, so it's more important for biogenic NMVOC (terpenes, C10; isoprene, C5) than for anthropogenic NMVOC (dominated by C2–C4 compounds). Over the last decade it has become established that these highly functionalised molecules not only form rapidly in the atmosphere but can lead to new aerosol particle formation, influencing clouds and climate. This process of H-shift, followed by O₂ addition and subsequent internal H-shift, is termed “auto-oxidation”, since it requires no bimolecular reaction beyond addition of O₂.

Fate of RO

RO reacts via three channels: reaction with O₂, isomerization, and decomposition. The isomerization channel is only possible for compounds with more than 4 carbon atoms (able to form a 6-membered transition state). The O₂ and isomerization channels (where available) are generally more important than decomposition. Reaction of RO with NO and NO₂ to form nitro-compounds/organic nitrates is generally too slow to be significant.

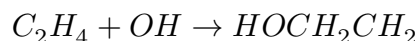
Example 4 — the fate of the 2-pentoxy radical in the urban boundary layer

Using the RO reaction channels above (O_2 -addition, isomerization via 6-membered TS, and decomposition), sketch the competing pathways for 2-pentoxy and estimate which dominates in a polluted urban boundary layer, given typical $[O_2]$, $[NO]$ and temperature — see the companion notebook for a quantitative rate-constant comparison.

4.4 Oxidation of alkenes

Most alkenes are emitted from biogenic sources — trees (isoprene, terpenes, sesquiterpenes) — with a smaller anthropogenic contribution, particularly for smaller carbon-number alkenes. Besides contributing to the atmosphere's oxidative capacity (they're a direct/primary oxidant sink), alkenes are also important organic aerosol precursors. Over many regions, biogenic hydrocarbons are more abundant than anthropogenic ones.

Alkene oxidation proceeds mostly via OH-addition rather than H-abstraction:



(R4.9)

The resulting hydroxy alkyl radical then reacts like the alkyl radical from alkane oxidation (e.g. with O_2 to form a hydroxy peroxy radical, $ROHO_2$).

NO_3 , the main night-time oxidant, reacts across the $C=C$ double bond, forming an excited nitro-oxy alkyl radical, which either forms an epoxide or nitro-oxy peroxy radicals (following the RO_2 scheme above). Terpenes — the most abundant atmospheric alkenes — react very rapidly with NO_3 ($k \sim 10^{-12}$ – 10^{-10} cm^3 molecule $^{-1}$ s $^{-1}$), so NO_3 oxidation remains important even though $[NO_3]$ rarely exceeds ppt levels.

In contrast to alkanes, alkenes also react significantly with ozone. Initial O_3 addition across the $C=C$ bond forms a primary ozonide, which is unstable and decomposes via two pathways to form Criegee intermediates (Criegee biradicals). Though postulated over 50 years ago (with first atmospheric rate estimates over 30 years ago), it's only in the last few years that their structure and kinetics have been unambiguously identified.

In the gas phase, the Criegee intermediate is either stabilised or decomposes via various channels — one, via a hydroperoxide intermediate, yields a carbonyl and OH. This OH-formation route can be especially important at night, when other major OH sources are inactive.

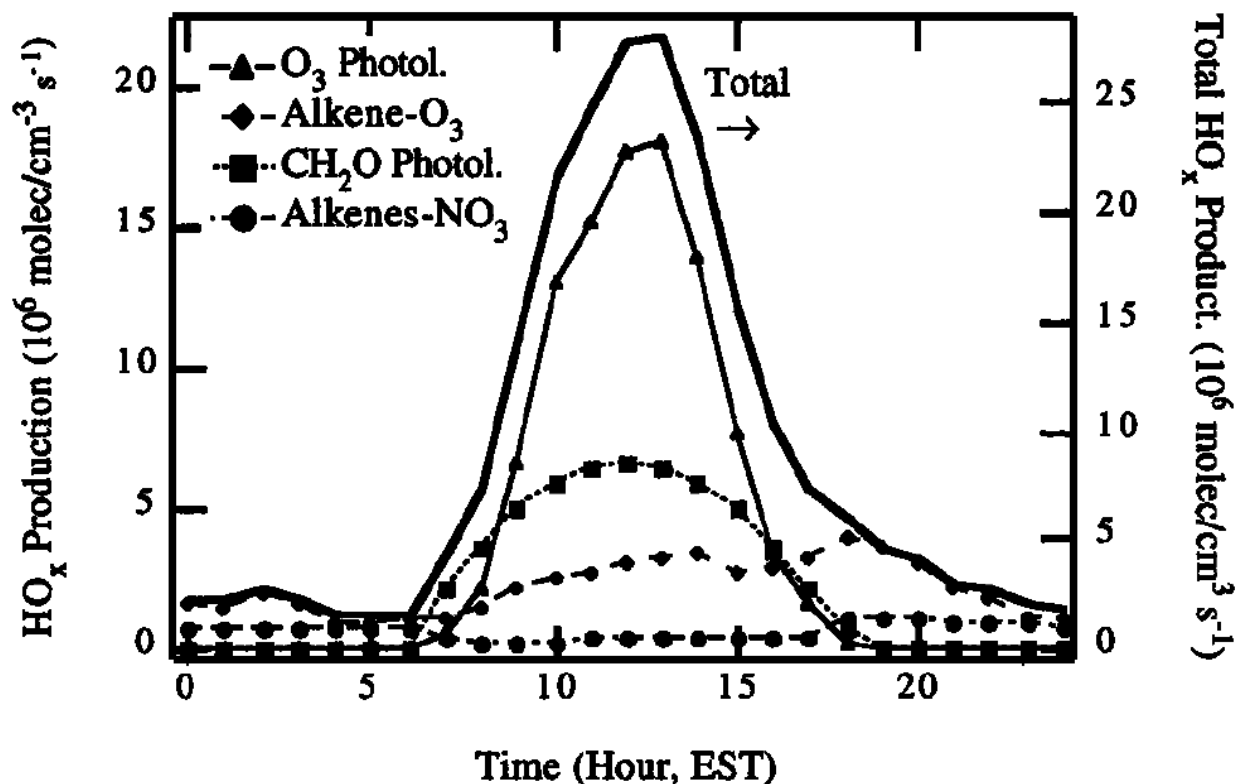


Figure 4.6 — Calculated rates of HO_x generation from various sources at a rural site (Paulson and Orlando, Geophysical Research Letters, 1996).

The major fate of the stabilised Criegee intermediate is believed to be reaction with H₂O, leading to carboxylic acids and hydroxy-hydroperoxides. Other reactions include those with NO₂, SO₂ and organics — the relative importance of these is not fully characterised.

Try it yourself

Open [notebooks/10-nmvoc-alkanes-alkenes.ipynb](#) to:

- Compare alkane OH- vs. Cl-oxidation lifetimes given realistic [OH] and [Cl] ranges, and confirm Cl oxidation doesn't control the overall alkane lifetime.
- Solve Example 4 (2-pentoxo radical fate) by comparing rate constants for the O₂, isomerization and decomposition channels at representative urban boundary-layer [O₂], [NO], T.
- Estimate O₃ yield per NMVOC carbon atom from the “max 3 O₃ per –CH₂– group” rule, and compare ethane vs. a longer-chain alkane.
- Build a simple RO₂ fate calculator (R4.2–R4.8) and see how the dominant RO₂ loss pathway shifts between polluted and remote-marine [NO] regimes.

Next: [Module 11 — Oxidation of Non-Methane Organic Compounds II: Aromatics and Oxygenated Organics](#)

Oxidation of Non-Methane Organic Compounds II: Aromatics and Oxygenated Organics

Module 11 · Oxidation of Non-Methane Organic Compounds II: Aromatics and Oxygenated Organics

Aims of this module 3. The oxidation scheme of aromatic compounds (continuing from Module 10).

4.5 Oxidation of aromatics

Most aromatics are emitted by anthropogenic processes — motor vehicle emissions, solvent use. They are also the most important anthropogenic organic aerosol precursors. Atmospherically relevant aromatics include benzene, toluene, xylenes and other methylated/ethylated benzene derivatives. OH is the most important oxidant for aromatics, with two competing pathways:

(a) H-abstraction (yield < 10%). Further reactions follow the alkane pathway, ultimately leading to aldehydes (e.g. benzaldehyde from toluene oxidation) or aromatic nitrates.

(b) OH addition to the aromatic ring (yield > 90%). Further reactions of the resulting OH–aromatic adduct are rather unclear, with many possible pathways proposed. The oxidation of aromatic compounds in the atmosphere is one of the least understood areas in tropospheric chemistry.

One of the more likely reaction routes (illustrated for toluene) generates mainly small dicarbonyls, like butenedial and methylglyoxal.

4.6 Oxidation of oxygenated organics

The alkane, alkene and aromatic reactions above all yield oxygenated compounds, which react further — ultimately to CO₂, or are removed by wet and dry deposition.

- Aldehydes react mostly with OH via abstraction of the weakly bound aldehyde H-atom. Further reactions involve O₂ addition and reaction with NO/NO₂, as described in Module 10.
- Ketones react similarly to alkanes, via H-abstraction at the alkyl chain.
- Alcohols also react analogously to alkanes (the alcohol O–H bond is stronger than the alkyl C–H bond, so abstraction of the alcohol H is unlikely).
- Carboxylic acids also undergo H-abstraction, but the main removal mechanism for most acids is wet and dry deposition.

Aldehydes (especially formaldehyde), ketones, and organic hydroperoxides are also readily photolysed in the troposphere — feeding back into HOx production, as discussed throughout Modules 8–10.

Key points — Module 10/11 (Chapter 4) - The OH-oxidation mechanism for many VOCs involves peroxy radicals, and leads, in the presence of NO_x, to net production of ozone and HOx. - Alkenes

react with OH but also efficiently with ozone, forming ozonides and ultimately hydroperoxides and carboxylic acids. - Tropospheric oxidation of aromatic compounds is highly complex and only partly understood; small dicarbonyls are abundant oxidation products. - Alkenes and aromatics are important biogenic and anthropogenic precursors of organic aerosols, respectively.

Example 5 — propose a mechanism for the oxidation of 2-methyl-2-butene

Using the alkene oxidation framework from Module 10 (§4.4) — OH addition across the C=C bond, the competing $O_3 + \text{alkene} \rightarrow \text{Criegee}$ pathway, and the general RO_2 fate scheme from §4.3 — sketch a plausible oxidation mechanism for 2-methyl-2-butene, and identify the expected major carbonyl products. The companion notebook sets up the rate-constant comparison needed to judge which initiation pathway (OH vs. O_3 vs. NO_3) dominates under different conditions.

Try it yourself

Open [notebooks/11-aromatics-oxygenates.ipynb](#) to:

- Compare OH-abstraction vs. OH-addition branching for a toluene-like aromatic, and see how the >90%/<10% split shapes the product distribution.
 - Solve Example 5 by comparing pseudo-first-order initiation rates ($k_{OH}[OH]$, $k_{O_3}[O_3]$, $k_{NO_3}[NO_3]$) for a representative alkene across day/night and clean/polluted scenarios, to identify which oxidant dominates initiation.
 - Build a simple multi-generation oxidation tracker (alkane $\rightarrow$ alkyl radical $\rightarrow$ peroxy radical $\rightarrow$ carbonyl $\rightarrow$ further oxidation), and estimate how many generations of oxidation are needed to reach CO_2 for a chosen starting NMVOC.
 - Wrap up the course: combine Module 10/11's rate-constant machinery with Module 7's OH steady-state calculator to estimate whole-atmosphere NMVOC oxidation lifetimes for a few compounds of your choice, and compare to Table 2.2 (Module 7).
-

This concludes the Lent term (Lectures 7–12) and the B4 course. See the [course README](#) for the full module list.